

Namo Bharat crosses 3 cr passenger journeys

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi-Ghaziabad-Meerut Namo Bharat has crossed 3 crore passenger journeys within months of the commissioning of the entire corridor, marking a major milestone for new-age regional transit in the National Capital Region (NCR). Over the past two years, it has steadily built commuter trust, now clearly reflected in the steady rise in ridership, and more and more people are choosing it as a fast, safe, and comfortable way to travel.

On 22 February 2026, the Prime Minister dedicated the entire Delhi-Ghaziabad-Meerut Namo Bharat corridor, along with the Meerut Metro, to the nation. Since then, ridership has been rising steadily. Apart from Sundays, which see around 85,000 passengers, daily footfall on weekdays ranges between 90,000 and 1,14,000.

Operations on the corridor first began on October 21, 2023, with the inauguration of the 17-km priority section between Sahibabad and Duhai Depot. In November 2023, after the first full month of operations, the section recorded a ridership of over 72,000. As services were extended to Modinagar North in March 2024 and further to Meerut South in August 2024, the operational section



expanded to 42 km with nine stations. With each extension, ridership kept steadily rising. By December 2024, average monthly ridership numbers had reached about 7 lakhs, nearly ten times higher than in the same period a year earlier.

According to a press statement, a major boost came in January 2025, when an additional 13-km Delhi section from New Ashok Nagar to Sahibabad became operational. With the commissioning of this section, stations like Anand Vihar, developed as a key multi-modal hub, made access easier for a much larger set of commuters. This helped bring in passengers not just from nearby areas but from across Delhi and adjoining regions. On 16th May 2025, a major milestone was achieved when the ridership hit the record of 1 crore.

By July 2025, average monthly ridership had reached close to 15 lakhs, more than double compared

to just six months earlier. Around the same time, daily ridership stabilised at about 55,000-60,000. To handle the growing demand, train frequency was increased from every 15 minutes to 10 minutes, with the system designed to go up to every 3 minutes when required. In December 2025, Namo Bharat crossed the milestone of 2 crore commuter trips.

"On 22nd February, the remaining 26 km section of the corridor, along with Meerut Metro, was commissioned, marking the operations of the entire corridor, and the ridership picked up even faster. Within a month, Namo Bharat emerged as a preferred mode of regional travel, and in March 2026 alone, monthly ridership reached around 27 lakhs. What stands out is the pace of growth. Namo Bharat crossed the milestone of 3 crore commuter trips in less than five months of reaching 2 crore journeys," it said.

BJP chief Nabin, CM Rekha offer prayers at Kalibari temple

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BJP national president Nitin Nabin, on Tuesday offered prayers at the Kalibari temple in Chittranjan Park in south Delhi, a day after his party registered a massive victory in the West Bengal and Assam polls. Nabin was accompanied by Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, state president Virendra Sachdeva, New Delhi MP Bansuri Swaraj, Greater Kailash MLA Shikha Rai and other BJP leaders.

On this occasion, Temple Committee Secretary Dr Rajeev Nag, President P.K. Das, Chief Advisor Dr Anand Mukherjee, and members Ajanta Bhattacharya, Saurabh Chakraborty, and Sujata Das were also present.

After the prayer, Nabin congratulated the people of all five states that went to elections and expressed

special gratitude to the people of Bengal, Assam, and Puducherry.

People compensated us this time for the 2024 Lok Sabha results, which had fallen short of expectations, he said. "I have come to pay obeisance for the victory of the party in the pious lands of Maa Kali and Maa Kamakhya," he said.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has been working as "Rashtra Nayak" and "Pradhan Sewak" for development and conserving the heritage and culture of the country, he said. "I believe the culture and heritage of Bengal can progress under the leadership of PM Modi only," he added.

After paying obeisance, the Chief Minister described the mandate as a turning point in Indian politics. She said that under the leadership of Prime Minister



BJP National President Nitin Nabin, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Delhi BJP President Virendra Sachdeva and MP Bansuri Swaraj at Chittaranjan Park Kail Mandir

Narendra Modi, the saffron flag is now 'flying high from Gangotri to Gangasagar,' adding that the result clearly reflects the public's growing faith in politics driven by development and nationalism.

Referring to the 'Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam', CM Rekha Gupta launched a sharp attack on the opposi-

tion, saying parties that had opposed the bill in Parliament have been decisively rejected by the women of Bengal. "The mothers and sisters of Bengal have sent a strong message through their votes," she said, asserting that women in the state have firmly turned away from fear, violence and appeasement politics. "They have shown

they are ready to stand up for their dignity and rights against any oppressive force."

The Chief Minister further said the victory represents the success of policies focused on women's dignity, safety and empowerment under Prime Minister Modi's leadership. Despite an atmosphere of fear and intimidation, she noted, women in Bengal voted fearlessly and played a key role in strengthening democracy and establishing a government committed to good governance.

Calling the win a tribute to countless party workers, she said their struggle and sacrifices have borne fruit.

"This victory is a testament to unwavering faith in democracy," CM said, adding that the courage shown by the people of Bengal in choosing governance over fear serves as an inspiration for the entire country.

Greater Noida: Student rusticated after assault video goes viral

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A female student has been rusticated from a private university in Greater Noida after a video showing her allegedly slapping and verbally abusing another student inside a hostel room surfaced on social media and triggered widespread outrage.

The university identified the incident as a dispute between two students of

the same batch and said it was not a case of ragging. Police, however, said no formal complaint had been received till Tuesday.

The video, which spread rapidly online, shows a group of female students gathered inside a room while one student is forced to repeatedly apologise.

In the footage, a girl can be heard telling the victim to keep saying sorry, adding that every apology would be answered with a slap.



Moments later, another student is seen holding the victim and slapping her

several times as others remain present in the room.

The disturbing visuals led to strong reactions on social media, with many users demanding strict punishment and questioning student safety inside campuses. Responding to the controversy, Bennett University said it had carried out a preliminary enquiry immediately after the matter came to its notice.

Registrar Ajay Kumar Yadav said the university

found that the incident involved an interpersonal conflict between two students and did not fall under ragging. He said disciplinary action had already been taken and the accused student had been rusticated from the institution.

Yadav added that a detailed enquiry was still underway to examine all circumstances related to the incident and identify the role of other students present during the assault.

The Pioneer Classified

LOST & FOUND

I, have lost my Original Society documents in the name of ALL INDIA SHIKSHA DEVI EDUCATION SOCIETY, DELHI-93 (Regd. No.-S.31844) along with its Original Registration certificate.

PD(1026)C

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Surendra Kumar Gupta S/o Kishori Lal Gupta R/o 3rd Floor, Plot No. 6, Niti Khand - 2, Swarn Jayanti Park, Indirapuram, Ghaziabad UP 201014, confirm that Surendra Kumar Gupta and Surendra Kumar belong to the same and one person. I will be known as Surendra Kumar Gupta for all future purchases.

PD(1023)C

I, Mahasena Parwin alias Mohsena Kamal W/o Mohammed Kamalun Nabi, residing at H.No. 84, Third Floor, Gali No. 18, Zakir Nagar, Okhla, New Delhi-110025 declare that I have changed my name from Mahasena Parwin alias Mohsena Kamal to Mohsena Parween for all future purposes.

PD(1024)C

I, MD. Kamalun Nabi alias Mohd. Kamalun Nabi, Mohammad Kamalun Nabi S/o Mohammed Abdun Nabi, residing at H.No. 84, Third Floor, Gali No. 18, Zakir Nagar, Okhla, New Delhi-110025 declare that I have changed my name from MD. Kamalun Nabi alias Mohd. Kamalun Nabi, Mohammad kamalun Nabi to Mohammed Kamalun Nabi for all future purposes.

PD(1024)C

I, VIDHI PAHWA, W/O, SHRI TARANPREET SINGH DHILLON, R/O, C - 193, TAGORE GARDEN EXTENSION, NEW DELHI 110027, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO VIDHI KAUR DHILLON, THAT VIDHI PAHWA AND VIDHI KAUR DHILLON IS ONE AND THE SAME PERSON

PD(1026)C

I, hitherto known as SUSHILA KHATRI ALIAS SUSHILA W/O DHARMENDER KHATRI R/O HOUSE NO. 390, NEAR MCD SCHOOL, VPO BANKNER, NARELA, NORTH WEST DELHI -110040, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as SUSHILA KHATRI.

PD(1027)C

I, hitherto known as DHARMENDER KHATRI ALIAS DHARMENDER S/O SHIVRAJ, R/O OF HOUSE NO. 390, NEAR MCD SCHOOL, VPO BANKNER, NARELA, NORTH WEST DELHI - 110040, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as DHARMENDER KHATRI.

PD(1028)C

I, Randhir Singh, Father of JC-474275W Nb/Sub Pardeep Kumar, R/o- Vill- Mohamadpur, PO- Naichana, Teh- Bawal, Dist- Rewari, Haryana- 123501, have changed my name from Randhir Singh to Randheer, vide affidavit dated 05/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1029)C

I, Sunil Kumari, Mother of JC-474275W Nb/Sub Pardeep Kumar, R/o- Vill- Mohamadpur, PO- Naichana, Teh- Bawal, Dist- Rewari, Haryana- 123501, have changed my name from Sunil Kumari to Sunil Devi, vide affidavit dated 05/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1030)C

I, hitherto known as Arora Prabhjot S/o- Iqbal Singh, R/o- S2/220, Third Floor, Old Mahavir Nagar, Tilak Nagar, West Delhi, Delhi-110018, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Prabhjot Singh.

PD(1031)C

I, Sayed Peeran, F/O- No.15573356L Hav Syed Miya, R/o- Vill- Gachibowli

H.No. 2-64/108, Rahamthgulsan Colony, Teh- Seri Ligampali, Dist- Ranga Reddy, Telangana- 500032, in my son's service document my D.O.B. is wrongly written as 14/04/1948, whereas my correct D.O.B. is 20/12/1950, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(1033)C

In service record my son name wrongly recorded as Garv, correct name is Garv Lather. It should be updated in service records of Army No.18009119A Hav Amit Kumar, R/o- HQ CWE Delhi Cantt- 110010.

PUBLIC NOTICE

To be known to all that I, RACHNA CHATURVEDI D/o SH. SHASH PAL PURI R/O 103, Konark Apartments, Plot No.22, I. P. Extension, Patparganj, Delhi-110092, am absolute and exclusive owner/Purchaser of freehold flat No. 103, situated on the ground floor in Nigam Co-operative Group Housing Society Ltd. (known as Konark Apartments), Plot No.22, I. P. Extension, Patparganj, Delhi-110092. I have misplaced/lost all the original documents i.e. Allotment and Possession letter & Share Certificate issued by Nigam CGHS Ltd. and conveyance deed executed by DDA in favour of Sh. A. K. Chaturvedi S/o Sh. N. C. Chaturvedi and also original sale deed dated 13.07.2005 which was duly registered as document No.8771 in Book No.1, Volume No. 1843 at pages 8 to 17 on 13.07.2005 in the office of Sub Registrar-VIII, Delhi, in respect of the above flat. An FIR/NCR to this effect has been lodged in the Police Station Mandawali-Police Station, East Distt./Crime Branch, Delhi vide LR No.237779/2026 dated 16.04.2026

Any person(s) claiming any right, title or interest, having any claim or found in possession of the above said original documents, may write/contact with above named person at above address/phone No.9910953099 within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice.

(RACHNA CHATURVEDI)

PUBLIC NOTICE

In the matter of Allis Bulidtech Private Limited having its registered office at A-702, Navratna Apartments Plot No. 7A, Sector-23, Dwarka, New Delhi-110075

Petitioner Notice is hereby given to the General Public that the company proposes to make application to the Central Government under Section 13 of the Companies Act, 2013 seeking confirmation of alteration of the Memorandum of Association of the Company in terms of the Special Resolution passed at the Extra-Ordinary General Meeting held on Monday, 30th day of March, 2026 to enable the company to change its Registered Office from "National Capital Territory of Delhi" to "State of Haryana at 102, Floor-Tenth, Tower No. - C3, Sobha City, Sector- 108, Gurugram, Haryana 122017".

Any person whose interest is likely to be affected by the proposed change of the registered office of the company may deliver either on the MCA-21 portal (www.mca.gov.in) by filing Investor Complaint Form or cause to be delivered or send by registered post of his/her objections supported by an affidavit stating the nature of his/her interest and grounds of opposition to the Regional Director, Northern Region, New Delhi at the address B-2 Wing, 2nd floor, Pt. Deendayal Aroraodaya Bhawan, CGO Complex, New Delhi-110003 within fourteen days of the date of publication of this notice with a copy to the applicant company at its Registered Office at the address: A-702, Navratna Apartments Plot No. 7A, Sector-23, Dwarka, New Delhi-110075.

For and on behalf of
Allis Bulidtech Private Limited
Nitin Rajpal Director
DIN: 02400262
Delhi 06/05/2026

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform to all that my client Raju Anand owner of Property No. K-2/37, UGF, without road, area 62sq yds, Kharsa No.64/1, Mohan Garden Extn., Gali No. 8, 30-A, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi, and My Client Purchased aforesaid property from Bimla Devi Anand vide notarized GPA, ATS and Will dated 21.01.2010 now My Client wants to sell aforesaid property. And it is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

PUBLIC NOTICE

The Public at large is hereby notified that we, (i)Mr. Vishvajet Sharma S/o Shri Yogeshwar & (ii)Smt. Payal Sharma W/o Shri Vishvajet Sharma intend to purchase a Property No.A-113, Second Floor, Measuring Area 180 Sq.Yds. Situated at Anand Vihar, Delhi-110092 From Shri Ghanshyam S/o Late Man mohan R/o E-6/25, Krishna Nagar, Delhi, who represent himself absolute owners of the property on the basis of REGD. WILL dated 13.02.2018 executed by his mother Late Smt. Sneh Lata. It is therefore, Notified that anybody claiming any rights, title, interest, share or lien over the aforesaid property may file such claim or objection to the undersigned within a period of 15 days from the date of Publication of this notice. Otherwise, it will be presumed that the said property is free from all encumbrances, charges and/or lien, etc. and We are free to purchase the said property from the above named seller.

Mr. Vishvajet Sharma S/o Shri Yogeshwar & (ii)Smt. Payal Sharma W/o Shri Vishvajet Sharma R/o F-20, Gali No.11, Jagatpuri, Parwana Road, Krishna Nagar, Delhi-110051

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform the general public that Mr. Man Singh S/o Late Sh. Dev Singh, R/o C-55, Rama Park, Dwarka Mor, New Delhi, is the lawful owner and in possession of property bearing No. C-7A & C-7B, Upper Ground Floor, Rama Park Extn., Block-C, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059. Certain original documents of the above property were handed over to Mr. Sanjay Sharma (S. Krishna Homes Pvt. Ltd.) in connection with a proposed deal, which stands cancelled. The said person has failed to return the documents and is suspected to be misusing them. Public at large is hereby cautioned not to deal with the said property through the above person or anyone claiming through him. Any such transaction shall be at their own risk, and the owner shall not be responsible. Date 26-Feb-2026 or First week of March.

Rajeev Wassan (Advocate)
Chamber No 558 Dwarka Court

SOUTH EASTERN COALFIELDS LIMITED

"A MINI RATNA COMPANY"

NOTICE

All the tenders issued by SECL for procurement of Goods, Works and Services are available on website of SECL <http://www.secl-cil.in>, CIL e-procurement portal <http://coalindiatenders.nic.in> and Central Public Procurement Portal <http://eprocure.gov.in> In addition, procurement is also done through GeM portal <http://gem.gov.in>. SECL's mining services tenders are also now available on GeM portal <http://gem.gov.in>

IITM

INSTITUTE OF INNOVATION IN TECHNOLOGY AND MANAGEMENT

Accredited 'A' Grade by NAAC, Approved by AICTE
Recognised Uls 2 (f) of UGC Act
& ISO 14001:2015, 17020:2012, 21001:2018 & 50001:2018 Certified

17 Years of Nurturing Excellence

IITM, a Group of A+ category premier Institution conducting BBA, BCA, B.Com (H.), invites applications for the recruitment at the following positions:-

Director/Professors /Associate Professors/ Assistant Professors in Department of COMPUTER SCIENCE & MANAGEMENT/ COMMERCE

Qualification: As per AICTE/UGC Norms.
Director: Ph.D. with min. 15 Years of experience in a relevant field.
Professors: Ph.D. with min. 10 Years of experience in a relevant field.
Associate Professors: Ph.D. with min. 8 Years of experience in a relevant field.
Assistant Professors: Ph.D. with min. 3 years experience in a relevant field.
Note: As per UGC guidelines, NET is a mandatory requirement for all positions.
Pay Scale: As per 7th Pay Commission recommendations.
***Higher salary may be considered for exceptionally qualified eminent educationists. Sr. Educationists from eminent Educational Institutions and Industry are also welcome to work both as Professor of Practice or Visiting Faculty at handsome remuneration. Please mail your CV latest by 30th June 2026.**

D-27/28, Institutional Area, Janakpuri, New Delhi – 110058
Email: hr@iitjmp.ac.in / registrar@iitjmp.ac.in / appointments@iitjmp.ac.in
Website : www.iitjmp.ac.in

BSES

BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, New Delhi

TENDER NOTICE

Sealed tenders under two Bid System (Unpriced & Priced) is invited for following job from all bidders.

NIT No.	Brief Item Description	Estimated Annual Cost w/o GST (₹)	Cost of EMD (₹)	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & Time of Opening
CMC/BR/26-27/FK/CR/SL/1357	ENGAGEMENT OF AGENCIES FOR MEDIA BUYING SERVICES IN BRPL	2.5 Crore	5,00,000/-	26.05.2026 15:30 HRS	26.05.2026 16:00 HRS

Cost of each Tender Document: ₹ 1180/- (Non Refundable)

For details in respect of Equipment/BOM/Services, Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/submiton of tender documents etc. please visit our website www.bsedelhi.com

Head (Contracts & Materials)

Regd. Off. : BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, BSES Bhawan, Nehru Place, New Delhi-110019 | Corporate Identification No.: U40109DL2001PLC111827
Telephone No. : +91 11 4910 7235 | Website : www.bsedelhi.com

PUBLIC NOTICE

Known to all that my client Raju Anand owner of Property No. K-2/37, UGF, without road, area 62sq yds, Kharsa No.64/1, Mohan Garden Extn., Gali No. 8, 30-A, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi, and My Client Purchased aforesaid property from Bimla Devi Anand vide notarized GPA, ATS and Will dated 21.01.2010 now My Client wants to sell aforesaid property. And it is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

PUBLIC NOTICE

Known to all that my client Anari Devi owner of Plot No. C-2 and Plot No. C-2A area 200 sq yds., Kharsa No. 25, 26, 27, 28 Vipin Garden Extn., Gali No. 8, 30-A, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi, and My Client Purchased aforesaid property from Rakesh Kumar vide notarized GPA, ATS and Will dated 21.01.2010 now My Client wants to sell aforesaid property. And it is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

PUBLIC NOTICE

Known to all that my client Mrs. Shwani Singh W/o Nitin who is purchasing Flat No.UG-3C on Upper Ground Floor, Northern Side, Sector-10, Area 75sq.Yds.Property No.WZ-11/1.Old Plot No.WZ-10/1A and WZ-10/Kharsa No.927/3.Sadh Nagar,Gali No.16.Palam Colony,Village Palam, Delhi from Mr.Anil Sharma who is the owner of the subject prop erty by virtue of Two Gift Deed dated 14.01.2010 (Doc.No.11240) and Gift Deed dated 23.11.2009 (Doc.No.9834) that the both the Gift Deed dated 14.01.2010 vide Doc.No.11240 and Gift Deed dated 23.11.2009 (Vide Doc. No.9834 have been lost and not available. And it is informed that any deal with said documents by any person except my said client and said institution regarding said property, shall be deemed as null and void. If any person having any claim, right in said property then he may contact and handover the same and apprise his claim to undersigned within 15 days of this publication.

AD REM LEGAL SOLUTION
Ch. No. 760 - Dwarka Court Sector-10, Dwarka, New Delhi-75
Mobile :- 9899013918

SRF LIMITED

Regd. Office.: The Galleria, DLF Mayur Vihar, Unit No. 236 & 237, 2nd Floor Mayur Vihar Place, Noida Link Road, Mayur Vihar Phase I Extn, Delhi-110091
Tel. No (Regd office) : (+91-11) 49482870; Fax : (+91-11) 49482900
E-mail: cs@srfl.com, Website: www.srfl.com; CIN: L18101DL1970PLC005197
Corporate Office: Block-C, Sector 45, Gurugram, Haryana- 122 003

NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that Share Certificates pertaining to shares of the Company detailed below have been reported lost and request(s) for issue of duplicate Certificates in lieu thereof have been received by the Company :-

Sl. No.	Folio No.	Name of the Share Holder / Legal Heir (Claimant)	Cert-No.	Dist-No.	Lost Shares
1	R0000086	RANBIR KUMAR GUGNEJA : Shareholder	139532-33	5691666- 737	72
			976545	18589223-366	144
			90169586-588	12897630-749	120
2	D0002243	DOMINGOS VICENTE GERALDO L P DIAS : Deceased Shareholder MARIA CONCEICAO EDELTRUDES P E DIAS:Deceased Shareholder	6425	1473226-50	25
			60231	2901899-2901909	11
			102247	4280462-4280479	18
			309202-05	15882697-778	82
			458202-05	23902489-570	82
			678402-07	56304846-5067	222
			748721-22	61805153-158	6
		WILSON JOSE SOCORRO DIAS :Claimant LAURA MISQUITTA: Claimant	776207	65758789-798	10
			1129157	309718586-849	2264
			90017040-41	6360502-561	60
			90155581	10600015-64	50

Any person having any claim /objection in respect of the above requests should lodge such claim/objection with the company at its Corporate Office within 15 days of the publication of this notice, failing which the company will consider to give effect to the above requests. Public is hereby cautioned against dealing with the aforesaid share certificates.

for SRF LIMITED
Sd/-
RAJAT LAKHANPAL
Sr. VP (Corporate Compliance)
& Company Secretary

Place: Gurugram
Date : 05.05.2026

BSES

BSES Yamuna Power Limited, Delhi

... A Joint venture with Govt. of NCT of Delhi

NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Date: 06.05.2026

E-tenders are invited under the Two-Bid System (Unpriced & Priced Bid) for the following materials/works:-

NIT & SRM RFx No.	Tender Description	Estimated Cost (₹)	Cost of EMD (₹)	Due Date / Time (Submission/Opening)
CMC/BY/26-27/RS/PM/JYS/6 [RFx No: 2200000209]	PROVIDING WHATSAPP BUSINESS AND VOICE BOT & CHATBOT SOLUTION* WORK IN BSES YAMUNA POWER LIMITED (BYPL).	1.00 Crore	2.00 Lakh	26.05.2026 / 15:00 hrs (Submission) 26.05.2026 / 16:00 hrs (Opening)
CMC/BY/26-27/RS/SKS/SV/7 [RFx No: 2200000208]	TURNKEY PACKAGE FOR SUPPLY, INSTALLATION, TESTING & COMMISSIONING (SITC) OF 11 KV SINGLE PHASE POLE MOUNTED CIRCUIT BREAKER FOR HVDS NETWORK	2.65 Crore	5.30 Lakh	26.05.2026 / 15:00 hrs (Submission) 26.05.2026 / 16:00 hrs (Opening)
CMC/BY/26-27/RS/SKS/SV /ASR/8 [RFx No: 2200000207]	SUPPLY OF POWER CABLE 33 KV, 3CX400 SQ. MM. (A2XWY)	14.13 Crore	14.13 Lakh	26.05.2026 / 15:00 hrs (Submission) 26.05.2026 / 16:00 hrs (Opening)
CMC/BY/26-27/RS/SKS/MD/9 (RFx no: 2200000210)	SURVEY, DESIGN, ENGINEERING, SUPPLY, ERECTION, TESTING, & COMMISSIONING OF 11KV & 33KV AIS PANELS ALONG WITH MISCELLANEOUS ITEMS AND ACTIVITIES AT SHASTRI PARK (CENTRAL) GRID IN BYPL.	3.93 Crore	7.86 Lakh	26.05.2026 / 15:00 hrs (Submission) 26.05.2026 / 16:00 hrs (Opening)

Cost of each Tender Document: ₹ 1,180/- (Non-refundable)

For detailed information on the Equipment, Bill of Materials (BOM), Services, Qualifying Requirements, Terms and Conditions, Technical Specifications, and submission of Tender Documents - including any corrigendum - please visit our website at www.bsedelhi.com — BSES Yamuna Power Ltd —> Tenders —> Open Tenders, or access our e-tendering portal at <https://srmpdrportal.bsedelhi.com/irjportal>

Head (Contracts & Materials)

Regd.Off: BSES Yamuna Power Ltd, Shakti Kiran Building, Karkardooma, Delhi-110032 | CIN: U40109DL2001PLC111525
Website: www.bsedelhi.com TEL: 011-4247111

Govt approves pay hike for vocational, samagra teachers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday said the Cabinet on Tuesday approved a substantial pay hike for teachers of Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan and vocational courses to the tune of ₹14,000 to ₹18,000.

According to the chief minister, vocational teachers will now receive ₹38,100 per month, while teachers working at special training centres under Samagra Shiksha will get ₹35,420.

The revised salaries are significantly higher than the earlier honorarium structure, under which vocational teachers were paid between ₹20,000 and ₹23,000, and Samagra Shiksha teachers received ₹21,000 a month.

Calling it an important Cabinet decision, the Chief Minister said the increase was aimed at both improving financial security for teachers and recognising the critical role they play in Delhi's education system. She said around 1,131 vocational teachers across the capital will



benefit from the revision.

These teachers provide students with practical and skill-based education in different disciplines and are considered central to career-oriented learning in Government schools.

The decision will also benefit teachers posted at 784 Special Training Centres functioning under the Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan.

These centres are designed for children who have either dropped out of school or have never been enrolled. Teachers at these centres work to prepare such children for admission into mainstream classes.

The Chief Minister said the

salary revision now places Samagra Shiksha teachers on par with primary and upper primary teaching staff.

She said the Government viewed the move not simply as a pay increase but as institutional recognition of teachers who often work under demanding social and academic conditions.

According to the Chief Minister, many of these teachers deal directly with vulnerable children who require extra academic support, counselling, and regular follow-up before they can return to formal schooling. She said motivated teachers are essential if the government wants to

improve learning outcomes and reduce dropout numbers.

The Chief Minister also stressed that ensuring no child remains outside the education network is one of the government's main priorities. She said the special training centres function as an educational bridge for children who have been disconnected from school and need structured support before rejoining regular classrooms. Officials said the salary revision is expected to improve teacher retention, as many contractual educators had been working on modest honorariums despite carrying substantial responsibilities.

The government believes that better pay will improve morale and reduce uncertainty among teachers who form a key support layer in the public education system.

Apart from the financial revision, the Chief Minister said the government is also working on improving the functioning of these centres through regular review, stronger parental counselling, and better coordination among departments.

Delhi night shelters struggle to keep cool as heatwave exposes gaps: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A field survey of night shelters in the national Capital has flagged serious gaps in heat-wave preparedness under the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board's (DUSIB) Summer Action Plan, with nearly half of the cooling infrastructure found non-functional and water shortages reported across several facilities.

The assessment, conducted by the Centre for Holistic Development (CHD) — a Delhi-based NGO — on April 24-25, covered 24 shelters across areas such as Sarai Kale Khan, Jama Masjid, Bangla Sahib, and Mori Gate. The report is titled 'Field survey report on the assessment of the DUSIB Summer Action Plan 2026-27.'

"Around 50 per cent of cooling units, including fans and desert coolers, were not working, raising concerns as temperatures continue to rise," the report states.

A senior DUSIB official, speaking on condition of anonymity, said the report has made "unverified claims" and that the situation was "not that dire".



ACCORDING TO THE REPORT, ACCESS TO DRINKING WATER ALSO EMERGED AS A MAJOR CONCERN

"The data is not factually correct. Our summer action plan 2026-27 is scheduled to commence on May 15. We have set a deadline of May 10 to correct discrepancies," he said.

"We agree that there are a few lapses in a few of the night shelters, but they are of a minor nature, and they are being worked upon," the official said.

At some locations, however, conditions appeared more severe. A shelter at Lahori Gate reported most of its fans and

coolers lying defunct, while another at Sarai Kale Khan had no functional coolers. Frequent power tripping at certain shelters worsened conditions, making it difficult to operate any equipment that remained operational.

According to the report, access to drinking water also emerged as a major concern, with about 40 per cent of the surveyed shelters lacking permanent water connections. Several facilities were dependent on tanker supply that arrived only once every two days.

"Shortage of basic medical supplies such as oral rehydration salts (ORS) was also reported at multiple locations," the report states.

The report claimed two suspected heat-related

deaths during the survey period and noted widespread instances of dehydration and skin infections among shelter residents amid limited medical outreach.

The report also highlighted gaps in awareness among staff, with many caretakers unaware of helpline services and mobile applications meant for emergency response and rescue of homeless people.

In a case study cited in the report, a 35-year-old man found in distress near a shelter near Bangla Sahib Gurudwara in central Delhi allegedly did not receive timely medical assistance despite repeated calls for help. He was eventually taken to the hospital only after police intervention, pointing to lapses in coordination between shelter staff and emergency services.

The organisation has urged immediate steps to repair cooling systems, ensure a reliable water supply, provide essential medical kits, and strengthen emergency response mechanisms, warning that delays could put vulnerable homeless populations at greater risk during the ongoing heat wave.

Court directs confiscation of UK-based arms consultant Bhandari's properties

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Tuesday directed the confiscation of several properties of UK-based arms consultant Sanjay Bhandari under the Fugitive Economic Offenders Act.

Special Judge Sanjay Jindal noted that on July 5 last year, Bhandari was declared a fugitive economic offender in connection with a money laundering case, following which the present court had been tasked with the consequential confiscation proceedings. The judge said the properties sought to be confiscated by the Directorate of Enforcement were in two categories.

"The first category includes properties that are claimed to be in the exclusive name or control of the respondent (Bhandari). The second category includes properties stated to be held by the benamidars, or the companies beneficially owned by the respondent," he said.

The judge underlined that, according to the Act, even if it was not clearly established that a particular property was part of the proceeds of crime,



Sanjay Bhandari

FILE PHOTO

it could very well be confiscated if the fugitive economic offender had an interest in it.

"So, in the absence of any categorical denial and presence of indirect admissions on the part of the respondent, it can be said that the Directorate of Enforcement has successfully discharged its burden to prove that the properties falling in the first category (properties in the name of the respondent), except the foreign immovable properties ... and bank accounts ..., are liable to be confiscated," the judge said.

He said the foreign immovable properties and bank accounts needed further verification before confiscation.

Regarding the second category of properties, which were allegedly indirectly owned by Bhandari, the judge underlined that the law required that a notice be sent to people interested in these properties, and after notices were sent to 16 such people, responses had been received from Bhandari's wife Sonia and Niho Realtors (India) Pvt Ltd. He said the properties regarding which objections had been raised by the two notices required further consideration or verification before a confiscation order was passed.

The remaining 14 notices did not respond to the notices, the judge said, adding that in the absence of any contest from their side, it could be assumed that the properties stated to be held by Bhandari through such persons or entities were actually owned by him, and so they could very well be confiscated without any further inquiry. He, however, said that "the properties which are held in the names of persons or entities other than the respondent and where no notice has been issued cannot be confiscated summarily."

"We have decided that

Vivek Vihar fire tragedy: Residents push for urgent safety overhaul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In the aftermath of a devastating fire that killed nine people in east Delhi's Vivek Vihar, locals have begun mobilising to address glaring safety lapses, deciding to hold meetings every 15 days to discuss fire preparedness and structural changes in residential buildings.

On May 3, a fire broke at a four-storey building in Vivek Vihar Phase-I, rapidly spreading from the rear portion and engulfing flats from the first to the fourth floors. Nine people from two families, including a toddler, died while several others were rescued.

Initial investigation suggested an air-conditioner blast on a lower floor triggered the blaze, which intensified due to strong winds. The building's design -- including a single central staircase, locked terrace access, and iron grills at the rear -- significantly hampered escape and rescue efforts.

Against this backdrop, residents in nearby blocks and localities have started discussions on improving safety mechanisms.

"We have decided that



meetings will be conducted every 15 days and will discuss several ways out during any fire-related incidents," a local resident, Rakesh Singh, said. He added that the meetings would also focus on the risks posed by electronic door locking systems, which can fail during emergencies.

"Residents will also discuss electronic door locking systems, as such doors do not open in emergency situations. We got to know that some of the family members were not able to come out of the building due to the electronic locking system, and they charred to death," he said.

Another resident, Shiv Sharma, who owns two flats on the second floor of a building in B-Block located around

100 metres from the fire site, highlighted a long-standing but unwritten practice that may have contributed to the fatalities.

"It is an unsaid rule that those who stay in top flats can only use the rooftop, and they even lock the rooftop. Such was the case in the fire incident, as due to the lock, many people were unable to reach the rooftop and died there," he said.

He stressed that keeping terrace access open for all during emergencies could save lives. "Had it not been locked, more lives could have been saved. During the meetings, we will raise this issue and ensure that rooftops are not locked so that people can reach there in emergency conditions," Sharma added.

POLICE, FORENSIC EXPERTS RECONSTRUCT FATAL SEQUENCE OF EVENTS

New Delhi: Police, forensic experts and authorities are reconstructing the sequence of events behind the devastating May 3 blaze in Vivek Vihar Phase-I that claimed nine lives, police sources said on Tuesday.

Investigators revisited the gutted site, collected fresh evidence and recorded residents' statements and first responders to determine the exact time the fire broke out and the speed of the subsequent emergency response.

The inferno had ripped through a four-storey residential building, reportedly originating from the rear portion before rapidly spreading upwards and engulfing flats from the first to the fourth floors.

Nine people belonging to two families, including a toddler, lost their lives, while several others were rescued amid chaotic scenes.

"Multiple facts are being examined. We are verifying the exact time of the fire, the first distress calls and the response time of emergency services. CCTV footage is also being

analysed to determine the origin and progression of the blaze," the source said.

He said footage from nearby buildings is being scanned to corroborate witness accounts and identify the initial point of ignition, while technical teams are assessing possible causes.

On Tuesday, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visited the spot and asked the police officers for a fair probe. Initial findings suggest the blaze may have been triggered by an air-conditioner explosion in a first-floor flat.

Investigators said strong winds may have intensified the fire while most residents were asleep, delaying evacuation.

Police have also flagged structural issues, including a single central staircase, locked terrace access and iron grills at the rear, which hindered escape and rescue efforts.

Several victims were found near staircases and upper floors, indicating they were trapped while trying to flee.

Jr engineer sacked after child dies in open drain

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday ordered the immediate dismissal of a junior engineer of the Irrigation and Flood Control Department after a young girl died after falling into an open drain in Mukundpur in the Bhalswa Dairy area. Calling the incident deeply disturbing, the Chief Minister said negligence in matters involving public safety, especially children, would not be tolerated, and responsibility would be fixed on all officials found at fault. The action came hours after the death of the child triggered outrage over the condition of uncovered drains in the locality.

In an official statement, the Chief Minister said the Government had taken the matter with utmost seriousness and moved swiftly against the concerned official.

On her directions, the contractual junior engineer posted with the Irrigation and Flood Control Department was removed from service with immediate effect.

The Chief Minister said the death of the child was not merely an unfortunate accident but a reminder of the grave risks created by administrative carelessness. She said every department concerned with civic infrastructure has been asked to



conduct an urgent survey of open drains and other unsafe spots falling under their jurisdiction.

According to the Chief Minister, all such vulnerable points that pose danger to life and property must be identified, and corrective work must begin without delay. She made it clear that future lapses would invite direct accountability. Officials who fail to take preventive steps despite clear instructions will face strict action, she said.

The Chief Minister also expressed condolences to the bereaved family and said the government stood with them in this difficult period. She said ensuring that such a tragedy does not happen again would be the most meaningful response to the loss of the child.

The development follows the death of a two-year-old girl in Mukundpur after she allegedly fell into an open drain near her house while playing on Sunday evening. Police had said the child had stepped out of her home in Ishu Vihar and suddenly went missing.

Delhi cools down with hail, thunderstorms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Coming on the heels of a period marked by searing heat, hailstones on Tuesday battered parts of the national capital along with thunderstorms, leading to a sharp drop in temperatures and the cleanest air of the year in the city. According to an official, five flights were diverted at the Delhi airport on Tuesday evening due to inclement weather conditions.

Several areas, including Dwarka, Najafgarh and the IGI Airport, experienced intense hail showers, catching residents off guard yet bringing much-needed respite from the summer heat. The AQI remained in the 'satisfactory' category for the second consecutive day.

In terms of rainfall, Palam recorded 9.8 mm between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm, followed by Ayanagar at 1.4 mm, while



Safdarjung recorded only trace rainfall and Lodi Road and Ridge reported none during this period.

Till 8.30 am, Ridge recorded 11.9 mm rainfall, followed by Lodi Road at 6.1 mm and Safdarjung at 4.6 mm, while

Palam recorded only trace rainfall and Ayanagar reported none.

The city remains under a yellow alert, with the weather department forecasting rain and thunderstorms in isolated areas later in the evening and night.

The national capital recorded below-normal maximum temperatures across all major weather stations, with Safdarjung logging a high of 33.6 degrees Celsius, 5.7 degrees below normal, while Palam recorded 32.8 degrees Celsius, 7.3 degrees below normal.

Lodi Road registered a maximum of 32.2 degrees Celsius, 5.8 degrees below normal, Ridge 32.8 degrees Celsius, 7.2 degrees below normal, and Ayanagar logged 32.8 degrees Celsius, 8.0 degrees below normal. Minimum temperatures also remained below seasonal averages at most stations, with Safdarjung recording 19.6 degrees Celsius, 5.1 degrees below normal.

Police bust fake luxury brands racket

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police Crime Branch has busted a large counterfeit branded garments racket operating from a luxury hotel in Vasant Kunj and seized fake clothing, watches, handbags and footwear worth lakhs that were being sold to customers as genuine premium products during a discount exhibition.

Police arrested one man from the spot and said the operation was part of an organised network that staged temporary sales in reputed hotels to pass off



duplicate branded goods as original merchandise.

Deputy Commissioner of Police Pankaj Kumar of the Crime Branch said the racket was cheating consumers on a large scale by creating a

professional retail setup and offering heavy discounts on what were projected as authentic branded items.

He said the operation also caused financial losses to original companies and the

government. The raid was carried out on May 3 by Western Range I of the Crime Branch at the ballroom of Hotel The Grand in Vasant Kunj after a complaint from representatives of Brand Protectors India Pvt Ltd. The complainants informed police that a suspicious exhibition sale was offering clothing and accessories under the names of several well-known international and national brands.

A police team entered the venue and found a full-fledged temporary showroom functioning under the banner of a discount sale.

Govt ends licence renewal requirement for weights, measures businesses

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has introduced lifetime validity for licences issued to manufacturers, dealers and repairers of weights and measures, doing away with the need for periodic renewals. The Government also plans to launch a mobile application to make the licensing process digital.

According to an official statement, the decision, taken under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, is part of a broader push to improve ease of doing business and reduce compliance burden on enterprises in the national Capital. The reform is part of Delhi's Deregulation Exercise 2.0, which seeks to reduce compliance burden and rationalise regulatory frameworks across departments.

"With amendments to the Delhi Legal Metrology (Enforcement) Rules, 2011, the government has also removed the requirement of physical site inspections before the grant of licences. Instead, licences will now be issued on the basis of self-declaration, a move aimed at cutting delays and reducing procedural hurdles," the statement read. The

approved reform amends the Delhi Legal Metrology (Enforcement) Rules, 2011, to remove the requirement of physical site inspection before the grant of licence and allow licences to be issued on a self-declaration basis. The move is expected to substantially improve the ease of starting and operating businesses in the sector by reducing delays, procedural bottlenecks and unnecessary interface points.

Industries Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said the changes are intended to simplify regulatory processes and make them more responsive to the needs of businesses.

"Honest businesses should not be weighed down by repetitive and avoidable procedures," he said, adding that the shift to a trust-based system would make it easier for enterprises to start and operate.

Officials said the new framework effectively creates a lifetime approval system, under which licences will remain valid unless suspended or cancelled by the competent authority. The move is expected to lower recurring costs and provide greater certainty to businesses.

IN FOCUS



A flock of great white pelicans flies inside the National Zoological Park in New Delhi on Tuesday

PTI

People of Gorakhpur suffered from mafia before 2017: CM Yogi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gorakhpur

Attacking the Samajwadi Party, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Tuesday said before 2017, people suffered from 'mafia' and 'macchar' (mosquitoes) due to a lack of security.

"What was Gorakhpur's image before 2017? There was a lack of security. People were troubled by the mafia and mosquitoes. People were afraid even to hear the name of Gorakhpur, and no one came to invest. The youth here depended on their identity, forced to wander the country for jobs and hide their identities," Adityanath said.

While addressing a gathering after inaugurating a two-lane bridge built over a water body in the Taramandal area of Gorakhpur, he said, "Today,



Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath during the inauguration of the two-lane bridge in Taramandal, Gorakhpur district

PTI

they don't have to wander or hide their identities. In Gorakhpur alone, more than 50,000 youths have found jobs through industries in the Gorakhpur Industrial Development Authority (GIDA)."

The Gorakhpur Development Authority (GDA) constructed the 112-metre-long bridge for ₹14.33

crore, connecting two parts of the Taramandal locality previously separated by the water body.

The chief minister also highlighted the city's improved connectivity, AIIMS, the revived fertiliser plant and sugar mill, tourism projects around Ramgarh Tal, educational institutions and other infrastructure

developments.

Referring to the Taramandal area, the CM said people once hesitated to settle there due to flooding and a lack of facilities.

"Today, it has emerged as one of the city's most developed and expensive residential areas," he said, adding that the bridge would further strengthen internal connectivity.

He also directed officials to develop the water body, like Ramgarh Tal, including boating and recreational facilities for families and children. MP Ravi Kishan praised the chief minister's leadership and said Gorakhpur has become a model of planned urban development. During the inspection, Yogi also interacted with labourers involved in the bridge construction and posed for photographs with them.

Gujarat MLAs get enhanced travel perks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gandhinagar

In a significant move, the Gujarat government has expanded the travel privileges of Members of the Legislative Assembly (MLAs), allowing them to travel in executive class on premium trains at the state's expense.

According to a notification issued by the Gujarat Legislative Assembly Secretariat, MLAs will now be entitled to travel across India in executive class on all trains, including premium services such as Vande Bharat Express, Tejas Express, and Duronto Express.

The revised provision has been published in the Gujarat Government Gazette (Extraordinary). Earlier, under the Gujarat Legislative Assembly Members' Salaries and



Allowances Act, 1960, MLAs were permitted to travel in first-class or second-class air-conditioned coaches. With the latest amendment, their eligibility has been upgraded to include executive class or any class of travel on all trains.

The notification clarifies that this new facility is in addition to the existing travel benefits available to MLAs, and there are no changes to other conditions specified under Section 5B of the Act. All other related provisions governing MLAs' travel entitlements will continue to remain in force.

Congress to play role of proactive Opposition in Assam: Gaurav Gogoi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

A day after the Congress was routed with its worst ever performance in Assam, the party's state chief Gaurav Gogoi on Tuesday said it will play the role of a "proactive opposition" to raise people's issues in the coming days.

Addressing a press conference here, he also said the Congress and the Opposition will keep a watch on the activities of the BJP-led government and protest if any anti-people policies are adopted.

"We accept this verdict of the people. Now, we will play our role as a proactive opposition to highlight people's issues. If the government seeks our positive suggestions, we will definitely give those in Assam's interest," Gogoi said.

The party will go to the people again to seek their feedback, and then it will work to strengthen the organisation, he added.

"We will keep a watch on the BJP government and Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's works. We will raise our voice if any anti-people



APCC President Gaurav Gogoi addresses a press conference following the Assam Assembly elections result at Rajiv Bhawan in Guwahati on Tuesday

PTI

stand is taken or injustice is done," Gogoi said. The Opposition will also stand up to the government if it indulges in corruption or threatens any segment of the population, he added.

"Even if we have fewer MLAs, we will not go silent. We have not accepted defeat mentally. If the Congress does not play the role of a true Opposition, democracy will be at stake. The government must be made accountable to the people," Gogoi said.

He hoped that the BJP would not repeat the "mistakes" committed in the last five years and will solve

people's problems with renewed vigour. For its crushing defeat, he accepted moral responsibility as he was "the captain of the Opposition alliance".

When asked where the party and the Opposition failed, Gogoi said, "It's too early to say what went wrong, we will have a detailed analysis of the results in the coming days. We could not get the number of seats expected by us." Without specifying, he questioned the neutrality of the Election Commission and said all the processes were made to help the BJP win polls in the country.

Trump lauds Modi after BJP's win in West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

US President Donald Trump has congratulated Prime Minister Narendra Modi following what the White House described as a "historic and decisive election victory" for the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in West Bengal.

White House spokesperson Kush Desai said that during a recent phone call last month, Trump expressed admiration for Modi's leadership and said India is "lucky" to have him as its Prime Minister. "The President congratulates Prime Minister Modi on this recent, historic, and decisive

election victory," Desai was quoted as saying.

The BJP's reported win in West Bengal marks a major political shift in the state, which has long been a stronghold of the opposition Trinamool Congress led by Mamata Banerjee. The result, as cited in a media report, ends Mamata Banerjee's 15-year hold on power and represents a significant breakthrough for the BJP.

The outcome is being seen as a boost for Modi's national standing midway through his third term, strengthening the party's influence in one of India's most politically significant states.



FROM PAGE - 1

consensus-driven process among Assam MLAs.

Political observers say that these twin appointments reflect the BJP's renewed focus on eastern and North-eastern India. With West Bengal and Assam holding strategic importance both politically and demographically, the party is keen to project stability and strong central backing as it prepares to take charge. The coming days will see hectic parleys in both states, as the saffron party moves swiftly to translate electoral gains into administrative authority.

The developments have triggered intense speculation in political circles, with allies and rivals alike watching closely how the BJP manages the delicate task of Government formation while balancing regional aspirations and national priorities.

Poll setbacks trigger push for INDIA bloc unity

Rahul Gandhi, in a social media post, expressed his party and himself to be on the side of Mamata by stating that elections in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu were stolen and alleged the BJP and the election machinery conspired to repeat what they did in Haryana, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh.

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah attributed the BJP's West Bengal win to a "significant role" played by the Election Commission (EC). He also cited a consolidation of Hindu votes and a fractured minority mandate. Shiv Sena (Uddhav) leader Sanjay Raut said outgoing Mamata committed a "big mistake" by not listening to Rahul Gandhi and not holding alliance talks with him.

Abdullah also said the INDIA bloc needs to define its role in the political landscape of the country and make it clear whether the opposition alliance was limited to the parliamentary elections or extended to the state elections as well. Raut said despite the defeats of prominent opposition leaders like Mamata Banerjee and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M K Stalin in the assembly elections, the future of the Opposition India bloc was very bright.

Second day of drone attacks on UAE

At least three people were wounded in attacks the day before, and a drone sparked a fire at a key oil facility in the eastern emirate of Fujairah.

Iran's effective closure of the strait, through which major oil and gas supplies passed before the war, along with fertilizer and other petrole-

um-derived products, has sent fuel prices skyrocketing and rattled the global economy.

Breaking Iran's grip would deny its main source of leverage as US President Donald Trump demands a major rollback of its disputed nuclear program.

US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth and Gen. Dan Caine, the US military's top officer, told a news conference Tuesday that Iran's renewed aggression hadn't reached the threshold of what Caine called "major combat operations." He said Tuesday marked a "quieter" day in the strait.

"No, the ceasefire is not over," Hegseth said, affirming Caine's assessment. They spoke before the latest attacks on the UAE.

Iran has said the new effort does violate the ceasefire. Iran's parliament speaker and chief negotiator, Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf, accused the US of undermining regional security.

In a post on X, he signalled that Iran has yet to fully respond to the US attempt to reopen the waterway. "We know full well that the continuation of the status quo is intolerable for America; while we have not even begun yet," he said. His statement did not mention negotiations with the US that are now in the form of passing messages via Pakistan. Disputing Washington's claim of sinking six boats, an Iranian military commander said two small civilian cargo boats were hit on Monday, killing five civilians, Iran's state TV reported. Caine, the top US general who serves as chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, said more than 100 US military aircraft are patrolling skies around the strait.

"Since the ceasefire was announced, Iran has fired at commercial vessels nine times and seized two container ships, and they've attacked US forces more than 10 times - all below the threshold of restarting major combat operations at this point," Caine said.

The administration has cited the April 8 ceasefire in asserting that the president does not have to give a formal update to Congress on the war under the War Powers Resolution.

That law typically requires presidents to seek formal approval from Congress for war activities 60 days after beginning military action. (AP)

India condemns UAE strike, calls it unacceptable

He also stressed that ensuring safe and unimpeded navigation through the Strait of Hormuz is "vital for enduring regional peace, stability and global energy security."

The attack on the Fujairah oil facility came amid heightened tensions in West Asia, shortly after the United States launched Project Freedom



serial numbers of EVMs brought to the counting tables and the records in Form 17C. He questioned how machines used for long hours showed "unusually high battery levels" of over 90 per cent.

Asked about the presence of returning officers, micro-observers, counting agents and central forces personnel during the counting, he claimed their deployment alone did not guarantee transparency. "There can still be possibilities of malpractice," he alleged.

"I demand that CCTV recordings covering the full counting day, particularly between 12 pm and 6 pm, be released in the interest of

transparency," he said, alleging that counting was deliberately slowed during the afternoon hours.

Banerjee, who is the nephew of the TMC supremo, said the party would review the issues internally and set up a fact-finding team.

He also alleged that widespread violence happened in the aftermath of the results, claiming that 300 to 400 party offices were vandalised across the state by BJP supporters "in the name of celebration".

He also claimed that the house of the winning TMC candidate, Bina Mondal, was ransacked and her car damaged at Swarnapagar in North 24 Parganas district.

Mamata refuses to quit, calls verdict a conspiracy

Now the same leader who once boasted of controlling every polling station suddenly discovers that the Commission is an enemy agent. The irony is brutal, and the institution she once praised for declaring her a winner is now a BJP puppet because it declared her a loser.

Her refusal to resign is more than theatrical. "They can take action as per constitutional norms," she taunted. "Let them try, she will sit in Nabanna, dare the Governor, dare the courts and dare everyone to physically remove her."

This is not defiance born of principle. It is the last gasp of a political machine that mistook power for ownership. Over three terms, Banerjee turned the state into a family fiefdom, nephew as de facto deputy, party as personal army, administration as electoral machinery. Sandeshkhali, the teachers' recruitment scam, the unchecked rise of Syndicate Raj, all of it carried the unmistakable stamp of unchecked authority. When voters finally said enough, she responded by delegitimising their verdict. When a defeated incumbent refuses to vacate, she normalises the idea that elections are valid only when she wins.

The message to every future loser is simple: "Cry conspiracy, stall and dare the system to enforce its rules". The Election Commission, which conducted a largely peaceful poll under intense scrutiny, is now painted as partisan. Tomorrow, another party will do the same. Trust erodes. Democracy becomes a ritual without consequence. Banerjee's press conference was not an act of resistance. It was an admission of political mortality wrapped in conspiracy theory. She did not lose, she insists. The people did not choose. Only the system betrayed her.

History, however, records a simpler truth after 15 years, West Bengal voted for change. The outgoing Chief Minister's refusal to accept that verdict is less a defence of democracy than a warning of how fragile it can become when leaders begin to believe the state belongs to them rather than the voters.

A Breach of democratic norms

Article 164(2) further states that the Council of Ministers is collectively responsible to the Legislative Assembly.

Once election results are declared and a new Assembly is constituted, if the ruling party loses its majority, constitutional convention

ECI notifies constitution of new Assemblies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a key procedural step marking the culmination of the 2026 Assembly elections, the Election Commission of India (ECI) has officially notified the constitution of new Legislative Assemblies in five States and one Union Territory. The notifications, issued under Section 73 of the Representation of the People Act, 1951, were dispatched to the respective Governors and the Lieutenant Governor of Puducherry on Tuesday.

The ECI's 'Due Constitution Notification' lists the names of all newly elected Members of Legislative Assemblies (MLAs) and formally brings



the new Houses into existence. The States and Union Territories covered are: Assam (126 seats), Kerala (140 seats), Puducherry (30 elected seats),

Tamil Nadu (234 seats) and West Bengal (294 seats). This routine yet constitutionally significant step signals the end of the election

process and paves the way for the formation of new Governments in these regions, whose previous terms were due to expire between May

With the Assemblies now duly constituted, the constitutional machinery for Government formation has been set in motion.

The Governors and the Lieutenant Governor of Puducherry will soon invite the leader of the party or coalition that commands a clear majority in the respective House to form the government. The swearing-in of the Chief Minister-designate and the Council of Ministers is expected to take place within the next few days.

According to the latest trends and results available as of May 5, 2026, the major takeaways are:

West Bengal: The BJP led alliance has crossed the majority mark with over 200 seats, poised to form the State Government for the first time in the State's history.

Assam: The BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) has secured a comfortable victory and will return to power for a third consecutive term.

Kerala: The Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) has emerged victorious, with the Congress set to lead the next Government.

Tamil Nadu: Actor-politician Vijay's Tamizhaga Vetri Kazhagam (TVK) has stunned

observers by emerging as the single-largest party with a clear majority on its own.

Puducherry: Trends strongly favour the NDA and its alliance partners, though final seat-wise details in a few constituencies are still being confirmed.

The ECI's notifications are not merely administrative formalities; they confer legal sanctity to the newly elected Houses and trigger the immediate commencement of the democratic process of Government formation.

Political observers are closely watching the swift transitions expected in the coming days across these five important political battlegrounds.

India, Japan commit to healthcare collaboration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Japan on Tuesday committed to deepen bilateral collaboration in the health sector, with Union Health Minister JP Nadra saying that cooperation between the two countries is anchored in a shared vision of strengthening health systems, improving accessibility and promoting innovation.

Nadra was speaking at the third Joint Committee Meeting (JCM) on Healthcare between India and Japan held at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi, which he co-chaired with Japan's minister in charge of Healthcare Policy, Kimi Onoda.

Welcoming the Japanese delegation, Union Health Secretary Punya Salila Srivastava said, "The Joint Committee Meeting, held under the India-Japan Memorandum of Cooperation, has served as an important platform for advancing this partnership



through regular dialogue and deeper mutual understanding." Nadra said the meeting reflects the shared commitment of both countries to foster new partnerships in the health sector.

He noted that India-Japan cooperation is guided by the Memorandum of Cooperation in healthcare and wellness, alongside a common goal of strengthening health systems and promoting innovation. Nadra said the relationship is rooted in over a century of engagement across sectors and reiterated India's commitment to inclusive development under the guiding principle of 'Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas'.

BJP slams Rahul's hypocrisy over EVM theft claims

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Tuesday accused Congress leader Rahul Gandhi of hypocrisy over his allegations against the Election Commission of India (ECI) and EVMs, and claimed that the INDIA bloc has "completely fallen apart" after the West Bengal election results.

In a video post on social media, BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla alleged that Rahul Gandhi questions electoral processes only after defeats but accepts results where his party wins.

"This is sheer hypocrisy and shamelessness of Rahul Gandhi. His party has won elections in Kerala, where SIR took place, and elections were held with EVM. The elections were completely fine, and that was the verdict of the people. Now he is hypocritically blaming EVM and the ECI in West Bengal and Assam," he said.

Poonawalla further accused Rahul Gandhi of



making repeated allegations without evidence and said courts have not upheld such claims.

"You ran an entire campaign on vote theft and on voter deletions in Bihar, and nothing could be provided to the Supreme Court," he said. The BJP spokesperson alleged that such claims were aimed at avoiding accountability.

"You make these eternal allegations against the ECI every time you lose an election. This is like a post-poll

did in Falta, what they did in other parts of West Bengal in other elections," he said.

Targeting the INDIA bloc, Poonawalla claimed it stands divided after the West Bengal results, with partners offering conflicting reasons for the defeat.

"Following the results of West Bengal, the INDIA alliance has completely fallen apart - it is fragmented, broken into pieces, and divided. On one hand, the Trinamool Congress says it lost due to vote theft and rigging, on the other hand, Shiv Sena (UBT) claims that is not the reason," he said.

He also questioned the lack of consensus within the Opposition bloc and termed it "directionless".

"The alliance now exists only in name, not in function. It has no mission, no vision — only confusion and an obsession with opposing Prime Minister Modi," he added. He also cited purported remarks by Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Sanjay Raut to highlight the "contradictions within the alliance".

Bihar CM orders urgent probe after damage to Vikramshila Bridge

SK JHA ■ Patna/Bhagalpur

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary has ordered an urgent technical assessment and immediate traffic diversions after damage was reported to a span of the Vikramshila Bridge over the Ganga, a key arterial link between Bhagalpur and Naugachhia.

A technical investigation team is working in Bhagalpur, comprising officials from the Bihar State Bridge Construction Corporation Limited and experts from IIT Patna and NIT Patna, and headed by the state's engineer-in-chief

(works management). The team is expected to submit a detailed report on the cause of the damage which has affected the movement of 16 districts of the State.

Bihar State Bridge Construction Corporation Chairman Chandrashekhar Singh said that Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary has spoken with the Defence Minister and the Army chief to ensure alternative arrangements for people with the help of Border Road Organisation and the army setup.

Chairing a high-level review meeting in Patna, the CM directed officials to secure

alternative transport arrangements for commuters and ensure that restoration work is carried out "expeditiously" once expert findings are received. He also called for strict enforcement of maintenance standards across all major bridges in the state, warning that negligence would not be tolerated.

In the interim, the state government announced a free steamer service for pedestrians and two-wheelers across the Ganga to reduce disruption. Authorities have also been instructed to streamline vehicular movement on the



Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary during an inspection in Khagaria district

PTI

alternative Munger-Bhagalpur route via the Shri Krishna Setu and National Highway 33.

The crucial link between Bhagalpur and Seemanchal in North Bihar totally snapped on Sunday night after one slab of the bridge collapsed suddenly. The crack had emerged recently, and it was seen by many travellers. The huge rush of vehicles from Bhagalpur and adjoining districts to Purnia, Katihar, Kishanganj and ten districts, as well as Nepal, came to a sudden halt. This bridge is a link between southern Bihar and Seemanchal.

Rijiju visits Jivetsal for Buddha relics exposition

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Leh/Jammu

Union Minister Kiren Rijiju on Tuesday visited Jivetsal in Choglamsar to witness the exposition of the relics of Gautama Buddha, describing their presence in Ladakh as a "blessing that transcends time, geography and borders."

"Deeply humbled to bow in sacred veneration of the holy relics of Tathagata Buddha at Jivetsal in Leh. The arrival of the revered Piprahwa relics in Ladakh is a blessing that transcends time, geography and borders, carrying the living



Union Minister Kiren Rijiju offering prayers to an idol of Lord Gautam Buddha during his visit to Dharma Centre in Leh, Ladakh

PTI

presence of the Tathagata and his eternal message of compassion, wisdom and peace," Rijiju said, according to a statement.

During his visit, the minis-

ter witnessed a traditional Chod performance, performed by students from Druk Padma Karpo School in Shey.

Rijiju inaugurated the Bakula Rinpoche Memorial

Lecture Series at the Central Institute of Buddhist Studies (CIBS), Choglamsar, and interacted with monks, scholars, and students.

The minister also inspected the reconstruction work of Chowkhang Vihara, a site of spiritual significance.

The exposition of relics entered its fourth day on Tuesday, drawing a massive turnout of devotees from across the region. According to the Ladakh Buddhist Association Youth Wing, around 15,000 people from areas ranging from Stakna to Likir visited the site to pray and seek blessings.

Industry must match Government research spend, says Pradhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Tuesday batted for an equal contribution by the private sector and the Government in research and innovation, noting that about 70 per cent of research investment in India currently comes from the Government.

Inaugurating the IIT Madras Technology Summit 2026 in New Delhi, he said that while the Government has significantly increased funding for research and development, industry contribution needs to rise. "At present, around 70 per cent of research investment comes from the Government, reflecting strong public com-



mitment. However, the long-term direction must move towards a more balanced 50:50 partnership between the public sector and industry to accelerate innovation and scale impact," the minister said.

India needs its own model for rare diseases, says ICMR chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An India-specific model focusing on resource optimisation, indigenous innovation and preventive strategies is needed to strengthen rare disease care in the country rather than relying solely on Western frameworks, ICMR chief Dr Rajiv Bahl said on Tuesday. He also batted for a context-driven approach to tackling rare diseases.

Addressing the two-day national conference on rare diseases organised by the Union Health Ministry in New Delhi, the director general of the Indian Council of Medical



Research (ICMR) said India must chart its own path in diagnosis, treatment and prevention rather than relying solely on Western frameworks.

He noted that while developed countries have greater resources, India can leverage its strengths through population-based approaches, preventive strategies, and

the effective use of digital technologies, including social media and emerging tools such as artificial intelligence, to expand outreach and improve early detection.

Highlighting the progress over the past three decades, Bahl said, "In the 1990s, identifying a patient with a suspected rare disease often led to a sense of helplessness, as diagnosis was extremely difficult and treatment options were virtually unavailable." "Today, while even financial support of Rs 50 lakh per patient may seem insufficient given the high cost of therapies, it represents remarkable progress that the country is now able

to meaningfully support children affected by rare diseases," he said.

He emphasised that this evolution reflects a broader shift in healthcare priorities, where attention is not only given to common diseases but also to those affected by rare, often genetic condition and termed the Government's rare disease programme as "a source of hope for thousands of children." Stressing the need to optimise available resources, Dr Bahl said that with a defined financial support framework, careful planning of diagnostics and treatment pathways is essential.

He highlighted the value of

family-based approaches, including parental genetic analysis and antenatal diagnosis, as cost-effective strategies for prevention and early intervention. Highlighting ongoing efforts, he said the ICMR is actively working to expand the range of tools available for managing rare diseases, including promoting the indigenisation of therapies and encouraging domestic production of affordable alternatives to high-cost drugs in collaboration with industry partners and supported by clinical evaluation through Centres of Excellence.

He also spoke about the use of repurposed drugs,

which are "medications that may not fully cure but can significantly improve outcomes and quality of life", adding that six such drugs have been identified and clinical efforts are being initiated for their use in rare diseases.

On advancements in frontier technologies, Bahl said efforts in gene therapy are being pursued in collaboration with institutions such as the Department of Biotechnology (DBT) and CSIR, noting that "India is making steady progress in this area and is closer than ever to realising such advanced therapies," citing developments like CAR-T cell therapy.

Nation Focus



VIETNAMESE PRESIDENT MEDITATES UNDER SACRED BODHI TREE IN GAYA

Vietnamese President To Lam, who is on a three-day tour of India, meditated under the sacred Bodhi Tree and prayed at the Mahabodhi Temple on Tuesday, officials said. Lam was earlier received at the airport here by Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary and other senior officials.

"The Vietnamese President offered prayers at the UNESCO World Heritage Mahabodhi Temple, meditated beneath the sacred Bodhi Tree, and also visited the Vietnamese monastery," an official said. "The spiritual, cultural, and heritage city of Gaya Ji warmly honours the arrival of the esteemed President of Vietnam."



DEFENCE MINISTRY SIGNS DEAL WITH BEL FOR ARMY ELECTRONICS

Ministry of Defence on Tuesday signed a contract with Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL), Hyderabad, for the procurement of five ground-based mobile electronic systems, worth ₹1,476 crore, for the Indian Army with a minimum 72 per cent indigenous content.

The contract, under the Buy (Indian-Indigenously Designed, Developed and Manufactured) category, was inked in the presence of Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh.

The system will modernise the Indian Army units and strengthen the indigenous defence manufacturing ecosystem of the country.

CPI(M) to introspect after LDF's debacle in Kerala



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Admitting to a "serious setback" in the recently concluded Assembly elections, the CPI(M) Polit Bureau on Tuesday announced that the party would undertake a comprehensive introspection to identify the reasons behind the defeat of the Left Democratic Front (LDF) in Kerala.

In a statement issued following the election results, the party noted that the loss in Kerala after ten years of continuous rule was one of the two major features of this electoral cycle, the other being the BJP's victory in West Bengal. The party also acknowledged the setback faced by the DMK-led alliance in Tamil Nadu, where Vijay's TVK emerged as a significant political force.

"The LDF was defeated in Kerala after a decade of governance, during which it did its best for the welfare of the people despite financial constraints imposed by the BJP-led Union Government," the Polit Bureau stated. The party assured its supporters that it would take all "necessary corrective measures" to regain public confidence.

Turning its focus to West Bengal, the CPI(M) attributed the BJP's landslide to strong anti-incumbency against the "corrupt" TMC Government. However, it launched a scathing attack on the saffron party's tactics, alleging that its victory was fuelled by a "communal, divisive, and vitriolic hate campaign," alongside the misuse of Central agencies and the Election Commission of India.

The Left leadership expressed deep concern over the "ascendancy of right-wing communal forces" in Bengal, Assam, and Puducherry.

States Focus



STALIN STEPS DOWN IN TN; GOV REQUESTS INTERIM MEASURES

Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar has accepted the resignation of Chief Minister MK Stalin and his council of ministers, the Lok Bhavan said on Tuesday. The CM had tendered resignation following his party, DMK's defeat in the April 23 Lok Sabha elections. According to a Lok Bhavan statement, the governor has requested Stalin "to continue in office until alternative arrangements are made." Following the poll debacle, the DMK chief submitted his resignation on Tuesday. The Tamil Nadu Assembly elections were held on April 23. Vijay-led TVK emerged as the single largest party by winning 108 seats, while DMK and AIADMK got 59 and 47, respectively.



SECLAR PARTIES CANNOT STOP BJP'S EXPANSION, SAYS OWAISI

AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi on Tuesday said that the West Bengal voters' verdict in favour of the BJP must be respected, and the so-called "secular parties" will not be able to stop the saffron party's expansion. Owaisi, who responded to the Assembly election results, thanked voters who cast their votes in favour of AIMIM in West Bengal, though all the 11 candidates fielded by the party lost. "The people of West Bengal have given power to the BJP. We have to respect that decision. It is the people's decision. Thirdly, I am of the opinion that I have been consistently saying that these so-called secular parties will not be able to stop the BJP," he told reporters.

TMC faces drubbing as women voters look away

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

A higher dole promise and shifting voter sentiment may have played a key role in reshaping the electoral choices of women in West Bengal, as the Trinamool Congress (TMC) faced a drubbing by the BJP in the Assembly election.

Women voters constitute nearly half of the State's electorate, and they have long been considered a strong force behind the Mamata Banerjee-led party.

The TMC Government increased the financial assistance ahead of the election in the 'Lakshmir Bhandar' scheme, widely regarded as the ruling party's most politically potent welfare programme for women, to ₹1,500 per month for the general category and ₹1,700 for those in the reserved bloc. In its manifesto, the BJP



Outgoing West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee addressing a press conference at her Kalighat residence

PTI

promised monthly assistance of ₹3,000 under its proposed 'Annapurna' scheme, and this could have made notable

inroads into the TMC's women voter segment.

The TMC has, since 2011, highlighted higher partici-

pation of women voters in elections, except during the 2014 Lok Sabha polls, the official said.

Assam polls: Only 7 women enter 126-member Legislative Assembly

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Of the 59 women candidates who fought to enter the 126-member Assam Assembly, only seven managed to win, the same as in 2021.

In the new Assembly, the ruling NDA will have six women legislators, while the Opposition Congress has one. Women comprise 49.98 per cent of the State's total electorate of 2.50 crore.

The BJP has increased the tally of its women MLAs to four, while its allies Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) and Bodoland People's Front will have one each. Of the 14



Assam Legislative Assembly

women candidates the Congress fielded, the highest among all parties, only one managed to win.

In the outgoing Assam Assembly, the BJP had three

MLAs, and the AGP and the Congress two each.

The NDA is set to form the Government in Assam for the third consecutive term after securing a two-thirds

majority, with a record high of 102 seats in the 126-member Assembly, while the Congress-led Opposition delivered its worst performance in recent times.

The BJP won 82 of the 90 seats it contested, while its allies — the Bodoland People's Front (BPF), which contested 11 constituencies, and the Asom Gana Parishad (AGP), which fought in 26 - bagged 10 seats each.

The most prominent woman candidate to win the election is State Finance Minister Ajanta Neog, who retained her Golaghat constituency for the sixth consecutive term.



AICC in-charge for Tamil Nadu Girish Chodankar

We ignored cadre's call for TVK tie-up: Girish

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

All India Congress Committee (AICC) in-charge for Tamil Nadu, Girish Chodankar, on Tuesday admitted that the Congress party leadership's decision to stick with the DMK alliance went against strong grassroots sentiment favouring the TVK.

"The local leaders, the grassroots level leaders, were suggesting that if Rahul Gandhi, who has a large acceptance in Tamil Nadu, joins the campaign with Vijay, it will create a big impact and we can sweep the Tamil Nadu polls, and get somewhere around 180-190 seats," Chodankar said.

According to him, because of the compulsion of the INDIA bloc and DMK being a long-time ally - the most trusted allies of Congress - the leadership decided to continue with the DMK alliance, knowing very well that TVK is going to do a remarkably good job.

Speaking on the victory of the TVK, Chodankar stated that a wave in favour of the new party had swept the State as youngsters and women voted decisively for a change, leading to a mandate that even saw the incumbent chief minister losing his seat.

Addressing the fallout of this decision, Chodankar admitted that many party workers were left angry, with some moving toward or even contesting for the TVK.

"Our cadres got angry, our voters also, and then they moved towards the TVK," he added.

However, he dismissed claims that the decision was influenced by a few individuals for personal interest, asserting that the party took a concise decision after careful consideration.

On the prospect of post-poll alliances, he stated that he has updated Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge and Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi on the present political situation.

Jobless teachers seek reinstatement from new Govt in West Bengal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Following the BJP's landslide victory in the West Bengal Assembly election, a section of jobless teaching staff, whose jobs were annulled by the Supreme Court order in 2025, on Tuesday said they now look forward to some appropriate steps by the new Government for reinstatement of their employment.

They said they voted keeping in mind the "uncertain future" they have been facing, and expressed hope that the new administration would meet their long-pending demand for transparent and timely appointments.

In April 2025, the Supreme Court ordered the cancellation of the appointments of over 25,000 teaching and non-teaching staff recruited through the West Bengal School Service Commission, citing large-scale irregularities and manipulation in the 2016 recruitment process when the TMC was in power.

"Due to the unimaginable corruption and nepotism by the previous Government, most of the jobless teachers are staring at an uncertain future," Mrinmoy Mondal, one of the jobless teachers, said.

"We now look forward to some appropriate steps by the new Government for legally reinstating the deserv-



FILE PHOTO

ing teachers," said Mondal, also the spokesperson of West Bengal Untainted Teachers Association.

'Untainted', 'deserving' or

'eligible' teaching or non-teaching staff are those whose involvement in the irregularities in the case was not proved.

Govern with humility, avoid CPI(M)'s mistakes: Congress' Antony tells UDF

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Veteran Congress leader AK Antony on Tuesday urged the UDF leadership to govern with humility and heed the people's mandate, warning against repeating the "mistakes" of the CPI(M)-led Left Government.

Speaking to reporters, he stressed that "people are the real masters" and said leaders must work with a clear understanding of public sentiment and expectations.

He cautioned that the errors committed by the Marxist party should not be replicated by the UDF.

The senior leader also



Veteran Congress leader AK Antony

advised the incoming dispensation to refrain from adopting populist measures and instead prioritise improving the State's financial health.

"The priority of the new Government should be to strengthen the economic condition of the State," he said.

Historic win for BJP in Nagaland's Koridang Assembly by-poll

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kohima

In a significant political milestone, the BJP Nagaland has scripted history by securing a victory in the 28th Koridang Assembly by-election. The success of the PDA consensus BJP candidate, Daochier I Imchen, marks a decisive shift in the State's political landscape, breaking a long-standing "jinx" regarding the party's inability to win by-polls in the region.

The party attributed the victory to the strategic guidance of Union Home Minister Amit Shah, National General Secretary (Organisation) BL Santosh, and Nagaland Prabhari Anil K Antony. Party officials stated that the result



PDA Consensus BJP Candidate Daochier I Imchen being felicitated by Nagaland BJP President Benjamin Yephthomi

PIONEER PHOTO

reflects the growing organisational strength and political maturity of the BJP in the Northeast.

The campaign was characterised by meticulous micro-management and booth-level coordination. State President Benjamin Yephthomi reportedly led from the front, stationing

himself in Mokokchung for 23 consecutive days to oversee grassroots mobilisation and election management.

"This victory has decisively broken the long-standing political jinx surrounding the BJP's inability to secure a by-election victory, creating a new chapter in the political history of Koridang

Mandal," a party spokesperson said. The win is being viewed as a testament to the increasing confidence of the electorate in the vision of the saffron party.

The BJP Nagaland expressed its gratitude to the people of Koridang for their "overwhelming support and trust." The party reaffirmed its commitment to people-centric politics, youth empowerment, and inclusive development across Nagaland following this historic mandate.

The victory of the PDA consensus candidate is expected to further solidify the alliance's grip on the State Assembly and strengthen the BJP's position as a dominant force in Nagaland's internal politics.

Rangasamy set for record 5th term as Puducherry CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Puducherry

The calm and soft-spoken N Rangasamy is all set to lead Puducherry for the fifth time with his party AINRC-led NDA winning the April 9 elections in the UT with a handsome margin.

The All India NR Congress has now emerged victorious in 12 out of the 16 seats it contested, and the BJP won four of the 10 seats it fought. The AIADMK and Latchia Jananayaga Katchi (LJK), other NDA constituents, emerged

successful from one seat each and the combine has 18 seats in the 30-member House, two more than the magic number of 16 required to form a Government.

Besides, there would be three nominated members. Rangasamy had been a Congress CM in the past (2001, 2006) before parting ways with the national party to float his outfit in 2011.

In 2011, he joined hands with late Tamil Nadu CM and AIADMK supremo J Jayalalithaa, and the combine won the elections then,



N Rangasamy

before ties soured between the two leaders.

On Monday, as results started emerging for the April 9 elections, it became evident that the UT had given a big thumbs up to the veteran leader, a man of few words, to lead Puducherry again.

On the other side, the INDIA bloc has garnered six seats - DMK five and one for the Congress. Most of its candidates, including sitting MP and former Chief Minister Ve Vaithilingam, bit the dust in the hustings. Vaithinlingam was defeat-

ed by Rangasamy on his turf, Thattanchavady. The TVK, a fledgling political outfit, won two seats, while the party backed Makkal Neya Kazhagam pocketed one. Three Independents have been elected from the Neduncadu reserved segment, Kadirkamam and Mahe region.

The successive NDA Government is likely to be a coalition ministry under the leadership of Rangasamy, just like the outgoing cabinet.

LJK and AIADMK are also likely to request accommoda-

tion in the ministry. The usual strength of the territorial ministry is six.

Meanwhile, the provision to have three nominated legislators would also be utilised. The nominated members enjoy no rights like the elected ones in areas such as voting during the presidential polls.

The Congress' performance in the April 9 poll has raised many questions about the party that has ruled the UT a number of times in the past. While the party contested in 16 seats, it won only one.



Rajeev Chandrasekhar

PTI

Stand against Bangladeshi Muslims helped NDA win, says CM Himanta

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Tuesday asserted that his Government's "uncompromising stand" in taking steps against Bangladesh-origin Muslims swayed people in favour of the BJP-led NDA in this year's Assembly elections, resulting in the alliance securing a two-thirds majority.

He maintained that the NDA's win was a victory for the Assamese indigenous people and affirmed continuing developmental work in the State.

Addressing a press conference, Sarma said, "The double-engine Government and unprecedented development the State witnessed in the last five years are among the main reasons for our victory."

"We had assured of securing the Assamese 'jati' (community) and took steps to deliver it. Assam progressed in the cultural and



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma during a meeting with Asom Gana Parishad Working President Keshab Mahantain Guwahati

economic sectors. Our uncompromising stand against Bangladesh-origin Muslims also had an impact," he said.

The NDA swept to a third successive term in the state by securing 102 seats in the 126-member State Assembly. The BJP won 82 seats, while its allies AGP and Bodoland People's Front bagged 10 each.

On Sarma predicting nearly exact numbers for the alliance before the results, he said the assessment was based on his connection with the people.

"I visited every Assembly segment thrice before elections. I have a good mass connect system, which helped in my assessment," he said. Sarma claimed that recommendations of the

Justice (retd) Biplab Sharma committee on Clause 6 of the Assam Accord, which deals with constitutional safeguards for the indigenous Assamese population, were implemented by his Government.

"It was because of it that the Assamese people won yesterday. It was not just a BJP victory," he asserted. The CM claimed the NDA secured the support of all sections of people, including Gen Z, which was evident in the young faces fielded by the BJP emerging victorious.

He dismissed the charge that the BJP has an "outsider" among its MLAs, referring to Guwahati Central legislator-elect Vijay Gupta.

"Vijay Gupta is an Assamese. If he is a Bihari, we (ancestors) also came from Kannauj. We all have come from different parts. Mongoloids came from outside, Aryans came from outside. This outsider narrative has been created by you all (media)," Sarma said.

BJP slams Mamata Banerjee over refusal to resign

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Tuesday termed outgoing West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's refusal to resign after her party TMC's defeat in the Assembly polls as "constitutional blasphemy" and accused her of undermining the concept of peaceful transfer of power.

Addressing a press conference in Kolkata a day after the BJP stormed to power in the State, Banerjee alleged large-scale irregularities in the counting process, claiming that the mandate in nearly 100 seats "was looted" and that counting was deliberately slowed down to demoralise her party.

"The question of my resignation does not arise, as we were defeated not by a public mandate but by a conspiracy. I did not lose; I will not go to Lok Bhavan. They can take action as per constitutional norms," she told reporters.

Hitting back, BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla, in a social media post, alleged that



BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla

Banerjee is suggesting "short-circuiting" the constitutional system through violence, drawing a comparison with the United States Capitol attack of January 6, 2021.

"What Mamata Banerjee is suggesting is anti-Constitution, anti-Ambedkar and amounts to constitutional blasphemy, apart from being a post-poll tantrum. She wants to overturn the concept of peaceful transfer of power, which is a hallmark of our constitutional

system," he said. In a video post, Poonawalla accused Banerjee of playing the "victim card" after electoral defeat and blaming the Election Commission of India instead of accepting the people's mandate.

"Mamata Banerjee is now playing the most disgusting victim card by not only disrespecting the verdict of the people but also saying she will not resign," Poonawalla said. "Even if she does not resign, the Assembly will dissolve on May 8, and she will anyway

lose her membership. It only shows that she is acting against the Constitution, as peaceful transfer of power is a hallmark of our democracy," he said.

Referring to past instances, he alleged that Banerjee has undermined constitutional principles earlier as well by opposing the implementation of central laws such as the Waqf Act and the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA), and by questioning the electoral process.

He also cited alleged incidents of post-poll violence in 2021 and the intimidation of judicial officials in recent months, claiming that law and order were compromised and that such actions contradict her claims of upholding constitutional values.

Poonawalla further said it will be "interesting" to see the response of Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, whom he accused of remaining silent on "anti-constitutional actions". "He should refrain from supporting or legitimising such actions, as it would reflect his own participation in this blasphemy of the Constitution," he added.

Jamnagar clears encroachments ahead of PM's likely visit



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jamnagar

With the possibilities of Prime Minister Narendra Modi visiting Gujarat on May 10 and 11, the Jamnagar Municipal Corporation (JMC) has swung into action to ensure smooth arrangements in the city.

Amid indications that the Prime Minister may halt overnight at the Lal Bangla Circuit House, civic authorities have initiated urgent measures to streamline key routes. The estate department of the municipal corporation has deployed two dedicated teams to carry out encroachment removal drives.

The operation focuses on clearing routes from

Jamnagar Airport to Lal Bangla Circuit House, as well as from the Air Force Station to the same destination. Street vendors, handcart operators, and others occupying road spaces have been verbally instructed to remove their setups immediately.

In addition, officials have directed the removal of hoardings and unauthorised signboards along these routes to ensure unobstructed movement. Civic authorities stated that a special cleanliness drive will also be undertaken over the next five days along both routes. Continuous monitoring will be carried out to keep the roads encroachment-free and well-maintained.

BJP ride vote swing to big wins in West Bengal, Assam

RAJESH KUMAR
■ New Delhi

The BJP's stupendous victory in the West Bengal and Assam Assembly polls was chiefly due to a big vote share shift of eight per cent and 4.6 per cent respectively, thereby ensuring that the saffron party will form the Governments on its own in the eastern States as it has an absolute majority. While West Bengal, for the first time, will have a BJP Government, the quantum jump in vote share in Assam has resulted in the party not needing allies to come to power.

For the first time since 1972, West Bengal is set to be governed by a party that is also in power at the Centre, a shift with far-reaching administrative and political implications. Coming to specifics, the vote share data highlighted the depth of the shift in Bengal. The BJP's share rose to 45.85 per cent, up from 38 per cent in 2021, while the TMC's dipped to nearly 40.94 per cent from 48 per cent. Translated into seat terms, the reversal was stark. The TMC's tally plummeted from 215 to around 80, even as the BJP surged from 77 to 207 seats, converting organisational expansion into a decisive and historic mandate. BJP received 29,218,815 votes, which translated into 207 seats, while TMC got 26,002,017 votes, which translated into 80 seats. Communist Party of India (Marxist) got 2,818,360 votes, which

managed to win only one seat, while the Congress won two seats, which got 1,884,900 votes.

Initial interpretation of the poll data also suggested that the BJP swept seats where the voter turnout was over 85 per cent, and the two parties fared more or less evenly in seats where 95 per cent or more of the people participated in the polls this year. The saffron camp amassed 45.84 per cent votes in its kitty, up 7.87 per cent compared with the 37.97 per cent votes it managed in 2021, the EC data said. The jump accounted for its tally of 207 seats in the state assembly, which was restricted to 77 seats in the previous elections.

In several seats, the BJP saw very large jumps in vote share — more than 20 percentage points in seats like Jangipur and Jadavpur. The TMC recorded some of its biggest drops of more than 30 percentage points in Rejinagar, Nowda, and Jangipur.

From the TMC viewpoint, the party's vote share shrank from 48.02 per cent in 2021 to 40.8 per cent, a slide of 7.22 per cent, which cost it a deadly blow of 135 seats, down to 80 seats compared to its previous tally of 215. Data available from the poll watchdog showed that the BJP won 172 seats in segments where the voter turnout was between 85 and 95 per cent. The TMC's gains in the same category stood at just 45 seats. In constituencies where more than 95 per cent of people voted, the TMC won 37 seats, while the BJP was victorious



in 28. In the current edition of the two-phase polls, West Bengal recorded a record average voter turnout of 92.47 per cent, which the EC said was the highest ever since Independence. In Karandighi, the BJP humbled the TMC by a margin of nearly 20,000 votes in a race where the contesting CPI(M) candidate managed to draw nearly 40,000 votes, finishing third. In Kaliganj, where the TMC won by a margin of a little over 10,000 votes, the candidate of the struggling CPI(M) still managed to poll nearly 23,000 votes in her favour.

As regards Assam, where the saffron party returned to power for the third consecutive term, a 4.6 percentage point shift in its favour helped it bag 22 more constituencies this time compared to 2021 and win 82 seats. According to information shared by the Election Commission, the ruling BJP received 37.81 per cent of the total votes polled in 2026, translating into 82

wins. Its vote share was 33.21 per cent in 2021, when it had won 60 seats. The Congress, on the other hand, saw a marginal 0.17 percentage point increase in its vote share even as its seats fell by 10 from the last Assembly polls to settle at 19 this time. The National Democratic Alliance (NDA) bagged 102 seats, its highest ever, way ahead of the halfway mark of 64 in the 126-member Assam Assembly.

For the Opposition Congress, its vote share increased to 29.84 per cent this year from 29.67 per cent five years ago, but its number of MLAs went down to 19 from 29 in the outgoing Assembly. For the BJP's ally Asom Gana Parishad (AGP), the vote share decreased to 6.47 per cent from 7.91 per cent in 2021, but it bettered its tally of MLAs by one to have 10 MLAs this time.

The Bodoland People's Front (BPF), another ally of the ruling NDA, got 3.73 per cent of the total votes

polled on its way to winning 10 seats. It had won four seats in 2021, but the EC had not shown its vote share separately in 2021. In the Opposition camp, the AIUDF saw its vote share erode to 5.46 per cent as it won only two seats. In 2021, it had 16 MLAs and 9.29 per cent vote share.

Of the total people who voted this time, 1.23 per cent chose the None of the Above (NOTA) option this time, a slender rise from the 1.14 per cent voters who chose it five years ago, the EC data showed. The Jharkhand Mukti Morcha did not win any seat but managed to corner 1.16 per cent vote share this time, signalling an expansion of the party to the Northeast. The EC said that in the 'others' category, comprising all other contesting parties and candidates, the vote share stood at 10.17 per cent. It was 13.7 per cent in 2021.

In the 126-member Assam Assembly, the ruling BJP won 82 seats, and its allies BPF and AGP pocketed 10 seats each in the results declared on Monday. The Congress and the Rajior Dal, who were part of a six-party Opposition alliance, won 19 and two seats respectively. AIUDF and Trinamool Congress fought separately as single entities and will have two and one MLA, respectively, in the new Assembly. Rajior Dal contested in 13 seats, Assam Jatiya Parishad in 10, CPI(M) in three, and the All Party Hill Leaders Conference in two. There were 258 Independent candidates in the polls.

Malayalam actor Santhosh Nair dies in road accident

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Pathanamthitta (Kerala)

Malayalam actor Santhosh Nair was killed in a road accident at Enathu in this district early on Tuesday, police said.

The accident occurred around 6.30 am when the car in which Nair was travelling collided with a lorry, leaving him and his wife injured.

Nair sustained critical injuries after his chest hit the steering wheel of the vehicle, police said. He later succumbed to the injuries. His wife suffered rib fractures and is undergoing treatment, they added. Nair made



his debut in cinema with the 1982 film 'Ithu Njangalude Katha' and went on to act in over 100 films, portraying a wide range of roles, including hero, villain and sup-

porting characters. His latest film 'Mohiniyattam' is currently running in theatres.

Superstar Mohanlal and actor-turned-politician Suresh Gopi expressed grief

over Nair's demise. In a Facebook post, Mohanlal recalled that Nair was his college mate and a close friend, describing him as a warm personality who earned the affection of everyone.

"Santhosh was my junior in college. From those days onward, he was not just a good friend but like a brother to me. We have worked together in many films," Mohanlal said on his FB post.

Union Minister Suresh Gopi also said Nair was like a brother who had been a constant presence in his life, and that his death has left an irreplaceable void.

Omar's cryptic post sparks buzz amid BJP poll surge

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

On Monday, a cryptic post by Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah invited sharp reactions soon after the Assembly poll result trends hinted at Bharatiya Janata Party's stupendous performance in West Bengal, Assam and Pondicherry.

Leader of the Opposition Sunil Sharma demanded a public apology from Omar Abdullah while accusing him of insulting democracy and the people's mandate.

On Tuesday, it was the turn of the People's Democratic Party (PDP) president, Mehbooba Mufti, to trigger a fresh row. The

former Chief Minister went on to accuse the Election Commission of India (ECI) of "subverting" the democratic process with the aid of Central agencies.

In a post on X, Mehbooba Mufti said, "India was once admired as a global model for free and fair elections, especially after TN Seshan transformed ECI into a fearless guardian of democracy. Today, that very institution stands accused of subverting the electoral process, aided by central agencies."

She further wrote, "A tragic fall. We may not have become Vishwaguru, but we seem to have mastered the art of electoral manipula-



tion. West Bengal is the latest reminder of this disturbing reality." On the other hand, the National Conference (NC) president, Farooq Abdullah, in a measured response, expressed hope that the new Governments will discharge their duties, keeping in mind that the country belongs to

all, irrespective of religion and language.

Speaking to reporters at Char-e-Shareef in Central Kashmir's Budgam district, Abdullah said the new Governments should work for everyone's progress. When asked about the poll results, he said, "What can my reaction be? The decision of the people is in front of you. What can I do about it?" Former Jammu and Kashmir chief minister said,

To another question about the holding of local bodies elections in Jammu and Kashmir, the NC chief said the polls should be conducted as local bodies are pillars of democracy.

2.4 lakh CAPF personnel secure peaceful, record West Bengal turnout

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/ Kolkata

West Bengal has long been synonymous with intense political rivalry, often marred by reports of booth-level intimidation, political violence and a pervasive sense of fear that kept many voters, especially women, minorities and Opposition supporters, away from polling stations. The 2021 Assembly elections, spread over eight phases, saw over 50-300 incidents of violence and a voter turnout of just 81 per cent.

Fast-forward to the 2026 polls, held in a condensed two-phase format on April 23 and April 29, the Election Commission of India (ECI) orchestrated an unprecedented security overhaul. Over 2.4 lakh personnel from the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF), including CRPF, BSF, CISF, ITBP, SSB and others, were deployed, nearly three times the strength of 2021.

A historic voter turnout of 92.49 per cent with zero poll-related deaths due to violence, an outcome that underscores how neutral, visible central security can transform a climate of intimidation into one of empowerment. "Higher turnout reflects not just numbers but qualitative inclusion", said a top CRPF official.

West Bengal's electoral history is punctuated by cycles of dominance by local political cadres, crude bombs, and post-poll reprisals. In past elections, State police were often perceived as partisan or ineffective against powerful local muscle, leading to low turnout in rural and semi-urban pockets. Voters hesitated, fearing threats, booth capturing, or retaliation.

The ECI's decision for 2026 to deploy a record 2,400+ companies, establishing integrated control rooms, Quick Response Teams (QRTs), drone surveillance



Security personnel stand guard outside a vote counting centre during the West Bengal Assembly election results day in Kolkata on Monday

and even armoured vehicles from conflict zones like Chhattisgarh and Jammu & Kashmir, marked a deliberate shift. Polling was compressed into fewer phases to allow concentrated security, signalling that free and fair voting required overriding local power structures.

CAPF units launched coordinated drives under names like "All

Out, Night Dominance, Kavach (Shield), Trust." Flag marches, round-the-clock area domination, and over 100 armoured and anti-riot vehicles patrolled sensitive constituencies. Forces were stationed within 100 metres of polling stations, with chiefs of all CAPF units reviewing measures in Kolkata. Drones and real-time monitoring added layers of deter-

rence. Crucially, personnel engaged directly with communities, ensuring villagers, particularly in rural Bengal, "No one will stop you from voting or threaten you. We are here. Vote freely." CRPF officials explicitly described the presence as fostering "trust and an atmosphere of peace."

This visible, neutral force, unfiliated with State politics, served as a psychological shield. Where local goons once dictated terms, central personnel created a "safe, conducive environment," as one senior CRPF officer noted. Mobility curbs (e.g., on motorcycles) and pre-emptive actions against troublemakers further neutralised traditional intimidation tactics. The proof lies in the numbers. Voter turnout jumped sharply to 92.49 per cent, a clear 11+ percentage increase from 2021. Phase-2 alone touched 90-92 per cent in several areas, with reports of enthusiastic participation even in historical-

ly volatile districts like Birbhum, Murshidabad and Diamond Harbour.

Violence was virtually eliminated: unlike 2021's dozens of clashes, 2026 recorded no poll-related deaths attributable to political violence (one isolated death occurred, but not linked to polling violence). Officials directly attributed this to the deployment: "Turnout was high because people were not scared to vote." Central forces, unlike state police, were seen as impartial arbiters. Their sheer presence deterred cadre-led intimidation, breaking the cycle where fear suppressed turnout.

Women, first-time voters and those in minority or Opposition-leaning pockets often the most vulnerable responded to direct reassurances. Reports of forces engaging villagers and assuring safety translated abstract security into personal confidence,

encouraging hesitant groups to step out. The 2026 West Bengal experience illustrates how strategic CAPF deployment can be a force multiplier for democracy. By replacing fear with assurance, it enabled citizens to exercise their franchise freely, delivering higher turnout and peaceful polls. As counting proceeds and results unfold, the retained forces will continue safeguarding peace, ensuring the mandate reflects the people's will, not the might of local intimidation.

In an era where electoral violence remains a challenge in parts of India, Bengal 2026 offers a replicable blueprint: robust, visible, neutral security not only protects the process but restores faith in it. The ballot, once a source of anxiety, became an act of empowered participation thanks to the men and women in uniform who stood guard so citizens could vote.



Editor's
TAKE

Nepal's Lipulekh protest tests ties with India

Nepal's latest objection to reopening the Lipulekh route for the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra is a reminder of an old wound that refuses to heal

Nepal's new government, under Prime Minister Balen Shah, is less than two months old, but it is already rewriting governance and the rules of engagement with its neighbours. Balen Shah came to power after Gen Z protests and has quickly cracked down on the corrupt and ailing system, making headlines for his radical reforms. He has also resolved to assert Nepal's sovereignty and keep the two bigger nations, India and China, at bay. It may not be high on his agenda, but he cannot afford to appear yielding when it comes to India. The latest protest by Nepal regarding the Lipulekh route to Mansarovar must be seen in this context.

Nepal's latest objection to India and China reopening the Lipulekh route for the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra is not new. Yet this time, the context is different. The boundary question has always been both a matter of diplomatic posturing and a domestic necessity in Nepalese politics— something leaders in Nepal have always used to stir public sentiment and deflect attention from pressing internal issues they could not resolve.

Under leaders like K P Sharma Oli, the Lipulekh-Kalapani issue was a tool to deflect attention. Shah inherits that hardened reality. But his leadership emerges from a very different moment. The movement that reshaped Nepal's politics in 2025 was not about territory or identity; it was about governance – jobs, accountability, and representation.

That distinction matters. It means the Shah government's legitimacy rests primarily on its ability to deliver internally, not on external posture. But at the same time, he cannot appear soft on border issues or on the Lipulekh Pass, as accepting Indian position would erode his credibility.

Lipulekh is considered a sacred gateway for the Kailash Mansarovar Yatra – a traditional route for Indian pilgrims travelling to Mount Kailash and Lake Mansarovar in Tibet. It has been under India's control for a long time. Nepal's Foreign Ministry's objection-carefully worded, routed through diplomatic channels, and restrained in tone – is more formal than menacing. But the message is clear: sovereignty must be defended and transaction must be on equal footing. At one level, India-Nepal relationship remains intact – open borders, economic interdependence, and deep cultural ties are proof enough. But beneath that stability, Nepal today is less willing to appear deferential.

Within Nepal's domestic politics, complacency towards India can be construed as weakness. India's position on Lipulekh has been consistent, rooted in its reading of history and long-standing administrative control. In Kathmandu, however, the issue is no longer just about territory – it is about voice, respect, and equality. China's role in this triangular dynamic remains careful and calculated. While Beijing is directly involved in reopening the route, it has avoided taking a clear stand on the sovereignty question. For India, the instinct to treat Lipulekh as a settled matter is understandable but must be recalibrated keeping sentiments of Nepal today. The challenge is no longer legal clarity; it is political sensitivity.

Why we need a new information world order

In an age where information moves faster than our ability to process it, clarity is giving way to confusion. What we are witnessing is not just a period of global instability, but a deeper crisis in how conflict is communicated – and understood



CHAITANYA
K PRASAD

There's a strange kind of fatigue in the air right now.

You can feel it when you open your phone in the morning. Another alert. Another headline. Another "breaking" situation somewhere in the world that suddenly feels a little too close for comfort. Wars don't feel distant any more; they feel immediate, almost personal. And not necessarily because we understand them better, but because we're constantly watching them unfold in real time.

But here's the thing no one really talks about enough: we're not just living through a time of conflict; we're living through a crisis in how that conflict is being communicated. And that changes everything.

We've built a world where information moves faster than we can process it. There was a time when news came with some kind of pause-time to verify, to reflect, to contextualise. That gap doesn't exist any more. Now it's instant. Continuous. Overwhelming. And in theory, that should make us more informed. But in reality, it often just makes us more anxious.

Because when everything is urgent, nothing is clear. You see a video, but you don't know when it was shot. You read a headline, but you don't know what's been left out. You scroll through opinions that sound like facts and facts that are framed like opinions. Somewhere in all of this, truth starts to feel... slippery.

Whenever things get messy in the information space, the instinct is to swing to extremes. Either clamp down, control the narrative, restrict information, filter what people can see-or do the opposite: let everything flow freely and assume the truth will somehow sort itself out. Both approaches sound logical. Both fail in practice.

Over-controlling information creates distrust. People start questioning what's being hidden, and that uncertainty often does more damage than the information itself. But a completely unfiltered environment isn't any better. It rewards the loudest voices, the most dramatic takes, the content that triggers reaction, not reflection. So we're stuck in this loop. Too much control feels suffocating. Too little control feels chaotic. What we actually need is something far more nuanced-and, honestly, far more difficult.

This is where the idea of a basic framework, or even an informal SOP, for crisis communication begins to make sense. Not as a tool to dictate what people can or cannot say, but as a way to shape how things are said when the stakes are high. Because in moments of conflict, communication is not casual-every word carries weight. Tone matters more, timing



matters more, and the impact of even the smallest misstep is amplified.

A slight exaggeration can spiral into widespread panic. A half-verified update can unintentionally escalate tensions. A dramatic headline can distort perception, making a situation feel more immediate or more severe than it actually is. In such an environment, the way information is framed becomes just as important as the information itself.

What complicates this further today is the role of technology, particularly AI-generated content. We are no longer just dealing with misreporting or bias; we are dealing with entirely fabricated realities that can look convincingly real.

AI-generated images, deepfakes, synthetic audio, and manipulated videos can circulate within minutes, often before they are even questioned. A single fabricated visual, if believable enough, can influence public sentiment, trigger outrage, or even provoke real-world consequences before the truth has a chance to catch up.

This makes the responsibility around dissemination even more critical. It is no longer enough to verify what is being said; we now have to verify what we are seeing and hearing as well. The burden of discernment has increased-not just for media institutions, but for individuals too.

Responsible dissemination, then, does not require complicated rules or rigid control. It simply calls for a few grounding principles: slowing down just enough to verify before amplifying, offering context rather than isolated fragments, clearly separating what is known from what is still uncertain, and avoiding language that triggers unnecessary alarm. It also means being cautious with visual content, especially in a time where authenticity itself can be manufactured. Equally important is the willingness to acknowledge uncertainty when it exists, rather than filling gaps with speculation.

None of this takes away from people's ability to speak. It does not silence voices or

A LITTLE MORE
CARE. A LITTLE
MORE
AWARENESS OF
IMPACT. A
RECOGNITION
THAT WHAT WE
SAY, AND HOW
WE SAY IT, CAN
SHAPE HOW
OTHERS
UNDERSTAND
THE WORLD

Chaitanya K Prasad is a commentator and writer on cinema, branding, media management, and geo-strategic communication. He has co-authored the book *When Branding Met the Movies*, published by the National Book Trust. Inputs were provided by Zoya Ahmad and Vaishnavie Srinivasan.

dailypioneer

@Chatty111Prasad

The Pioneer

How devotion leads to experiencing God



AJIT KUMAR
BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

In order to experience God, we must learn some facts about God and His relationship with us. God has three main roles vis-à-vis us. The first is the continuation of creation based on dharma (the highest principles). The main feature here is the karmaphala principle, which is: "What you sow is what you reap." The second is to help all those who turn to God, as appropriate. The third is to micromanage the lives of devotees in order to take them towards liberation. God uses His ichcha shakti (divine willpower) to do all this.

God respects the free will of all souls – His parts (the Bhagavad Gita 15.7). Didn't Lord Krishna involve Arjuna in the Mahabharata war only after Arjuna agreed, stating that he would do what the Lord asked him to do, which was to fight to uphold dharma? God adjusts His response according to what suits a particular devotee. In my case, my Lord



has much to reform in order to help me qualify for the privileged position of liberation. Only very advanced devotees, like Swami Vivekananda, attain it at a relatively young age.

For others, kriyamana (what is presently being done) is crucial. Svabhava (nature) change is what has to be addressed. Don't we each have a unique nature due to our varied past? God deletes the balance prarabdha (accumulated karmaphalas) prior to granting liberation, once the nature becomes acceptable.

Now, about experiencing God: the first thing you need to do is to have His company 24x7. It is not practical to do this in a temple, but it is possible with a large photograph of an avatar (incarnation). You also have to ensure that the image is such that the Lord's eyes are painted in a way that

they appear to follow you and see whatever you are doing. This photograph must be hung in the room where you spend most of your time. In my case, it is my bedroom, where I have also placed my worktable.

Now become aware that God is watching you. He does, whether you realise it or not. Lord Krishna has clearly stated that His eyes are everywhere (Bhagavad Gita 13.14). This is a good start. Now begin praying for whatever you need. Remember, God will not be pleased if your prayers are for anything even remotely against dharma.

Simultaneously, start some spiritual practice, such as chanting God's names-in your case, the name of the avatar chosen by you. Now a communication has been established between you and God. It is a good time to seek guidance and help in whatever you do. God will respond because you have met all the necessary conditions for it.

You will be surprised, as God uses many mediums and ways to communicate. In my case, my Lord usually speaks to me early in the morning. Additionally, intuitions come

regularly. The extent of my purity determines how receptive I am. Life has taken a superb turn; I am able to experience and enjoy God's company whenever I turn to Him.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a popular columnist

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

A performing government has been rejected

The results of the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections convey that the people of the state, particularly women, students, and youngsters who have benefited the most during the DMK rule, have become blatantly ungrateful and have fallen prey to a despicable cine craze. This is more so when they have gone to the extent of defeating Chief Minister MK Stalin, who spent every minute of his time on the uplift of the state across key parameters and made it the number one state among all states in India.

It is unfortunate that a performing government has been defeated by immature fans of an inexperienced actor, from whom not much can be expected for the benefit of the state.

In the defeat of the DMK government, and particularly CM Stalin, one also has doubts about the involvement of the Election Commission of India, which has appeared blatantly partisan in favour of the ruling BJP dispensation, which worked day and night for the defeat of the DMK government, especially CM Stalin, who was gaining popularity at the national level as well. The DMK should seek verification of the votes polled and recorded in the EVMS with the VVPAT records.

THARCIOUS S FERNANDO | CHENNAI

BJP's lotus blooms in Bengal

BJP has won a resounding election victory in West Bengal, a state that had been a rare opposition stronghold, expanding its consolidation of power across the country. It is the first time that the Indian Prime Minister's Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has won Assembly elections in West Bengal, a large and politically significant state in eastern India.

Over the past 15 years, the state had been ruled by the Trinamool Congress (TMC), a key opposition party, under the leadership of Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee. Banerjee had been one of the most outspoken critics of Narendra Modi and his religious nationalist agenda over the past 12 years.

In a result that will have significant implications for India's political landscape, and deal another demoralising blow to the already weakened opposition, the BJP won more than 205 out of 294 seats in Bengal's Assembly, a landmark majority and a significant moment in the state's history.

The West Bengal Assembly elections will be remembered for long. People's power has prevailed, and BJP's politics of governance has triumphed. The victory strengthens the party's influence in eastern India, marking a major political shift in the region.

CK SUBRAMANIAM | MUMBAI

Vijay reshapes Tamil Nadu politics

Against considerable scepticism, Joseph Vijay has turned doubt into momentum, delivering a striking political debut that few anticipated. His emergence comes at a moment when public discontent has been steadily building against the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), with criticisms of entrenched corruption and "divide and rule" governance shaping voter sentiment and testing the leadership of Chief Minister MK Stalin. It is important to note that the Chief Minister lost in his own constituency. At the same time, the opposition has struggled to present a credible alternative. The alliance between the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has faltered due to internal divisions and declining public trust. This vacuum has created an opening that Vijay has swiftly occupied. Blending star power with grassroots outreach, he has connected with younger voters and those disillusioned with traditional politics. His rise signals a shift in Tamil Nadu's political landscape, where legacy alone no longer guarantees loyalty.

It also reflects a growing demand for fresh leadership and new political narratives. The electorate now appears more willing to challenge long-standing political dominance.

AP THIRUVADI | CHENNAI

PIC TALK



People offer prayers on 'Angarki Sankashti Chaturthi' at Siddhivinayak Temple, in Mumbai.

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

www.dailypioneer.com

facebook.com/dailypioneer

@TheDailyPioneer

instagram.com/dailypioneer

linkedin.com/in/The Pioneer

RIISING TENSIONS IN STRAIT THREATEN GLOBAL STABILITY

US President Donald Trump on Monday issued a stark warning to Iran, stating that it would be "blown off the face of the Earth" if it targeted US vessels escorting ships through the strategically vital Strait of Hormuz.

The remarks come amid heightened tensions following reports that ships moving under a US-led escort operation, dubbed "Project Freedom" by United States Central Command, came under attack in the region. Trump alleged that Iranian forces had fired on multiple vessels, including a South Korean cargo ship.

Iran swiftly rejected these allegations, with officials denying any deliberate attack on foreign commercial vessels. A spokesperson for Iran's foreign ministry stated that Tehran

remains committed to freedom of navigation but warned against what it described as "provocative military posturing" by the United States.

Iranian officials also cautioned that any escalation or direct confrontation would destabilise global energy routes. They reiterated that security in the Strait should be maintained through regional cooperation rather than "external intervention".

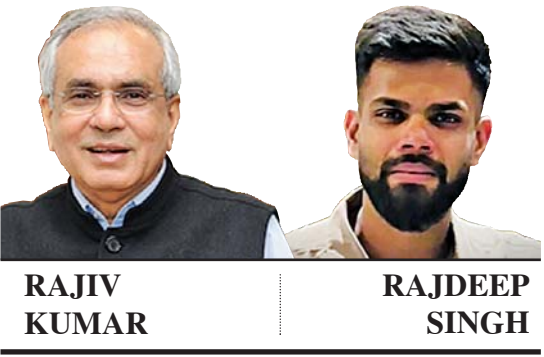
The Strait of Hormuz, through which a significant portion of the world's oil supply passes, remains on edge amid the ongoing crisis, with global markets closely monitoring developments for signs of further escalation.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

One nation, one election: The reform India cannot defer any longer

The choice before India is not between democracy and development. It is between a democracy aligned with its aspirations and one that is not. That alignment begins, though it does not end, with this reform



A democracy that is perpetually distracted cannot deliver desired development.

There is a peculiar kind of paralysis that visits the world's largest democracy with clockwork regularity. It does not announce itself. It simply settles quietly, methodically-over the machinery of the Indian state every few months. It happens as yet another election cycle begins somewhere across its thirty-six states and union territories. Executive decisions are deferred. Files move with greater caution. Senior bureaucrats are shifted en masse. Political leaders trade governance for rallies. And a nation attempting one of the most consequential structural transformations in modern economic history shifts into a lower gear-not by choice, but by design.

This is the hidden cost of India's staggered electoral calendar. And it is a cost the country can no longer afford as it grapples with enormous challenges in meeting the rising aspirations of its young population amid turbulent global times.

The architecture of interruption

India's founding fathers bestowed upon us a synchronised electoral democracy. From 1951 through 1967, Lok Sabha and state assembly elections were held simultaneously. That synchronisation unravelled progressively-through premature dissolutions of state assemblies between 1968 and 1971 and through subsequent constitutional developments-producing the fragmented, rolling electoral calendar that characterises Indian polity today. The negative consequences have compounded with each passing decade.

Between 2019 and 2024, elections were conducted across nearly every major Indian state, at different times, triggering the Model Code of Conduct (MCC). The constitutionally mandated MCC, necessary for free and fair elections, typically extends for six to eight weeks for each election, redirecting policy attention and pausing administrative action. Multiplied across a near-continuous cycle of state polls, its cumulative effect can be structural, substantial, and often irreversible.

The financial dimension reinforces this picture. The Centre for Media Studies, in its 2024 assessment, estimated that India's general elections that year involved total expenditure of approximately ₹1.35 lakh crore (\$8 billion), making it the most expensive democratic exercise in recorded history. Aggregated across five years of state elections, local body polls, and by-elections, the cumulative figure rises manifold. Yet even this understates the true cost. The higher cost lies in the compounding drag of deferred decisions, delayed projects, and long-horizon planning repeatedly subordinated to the short-term imperatives of the electoral cycle. Every election also triggers a cycle of freebies and quid pro quo, which is inimical to good governance.

India, at this juncture, should be attempting a structural leap across multiple dimensions of development. The capital expenditure budget of the Centre and states has grown by 100 per cent between 2020 and 2025. This record outlay of ₹11 lakh crore in the FY27 budget, largely on infrastructure, should ideally not be subject to unpredictable interruptions caused by recurring elections. Such investments require sustained monitoring, multi-year financing certainty, and uninterrupted institutional attention. A governance model that enters election mode four to six times a year is, by its very architecture, incompatible with that requirement.

The clearest illustration of this governance disruption, caused by repeated elections, is perhaps the still incomplete railway freight corridors — the West to



East and the Delhi to Mumbai projects-which have been ongoing for the past 18 years. The projects were approved by the Cabinet in 2006. Changes in government at the Centre and in the intervening states have delayed the clearing of bottlenecks in land acquisition and other constraints. In the meantime, project costs have ballooned from roughly ₹28,181 crore (initial sanction in 2008 for EDFC and WDFC) to over ₹81,459 crore by 2015. The opportunity cost of congested tracks, delays in freight movement, and revenue loss can hardly be estimated. Several such examples abound. It is time to restrain the currently prevalent ultra-hyper democracy that vitiates optimal policy design and timely project execution. No single government is responsible for this pattern. The structure is. And that structural gap is precisely what needs to change.

The High-Level Committee on Simultaneous Elections, chaired by former President Ram Nath Kovind, which submitted its unanimous report to the Government in March 2024, frames One Nation One Election (ONOE) not as an administrative convenience but as a governance imperative. Drawing on inputs from constitutional experts, administrative bodies, and over forty-seven political parties, the Committee recommends a phased transition-aligning state electoral cycles with the Lok Sabha over a defined period, with appropriate constitutional provisions to manage synchronisation where needed.

The widely expressed concerns about federalism are legitimate and deserve serious engagement. India's states are constitutional entities, not administrative subdivisions. Their electorates have the right to hold state governments accountable on their own terms. Any reform that dilutes that right would be worse than the problem it seeks to solve. But the Kovind Committee does not propose to dilute state sovereignty. It proposes to synchronise electoral timing. Every voter will retain their rights. Every state government will retain its constitutional mandate. Only the calendar changes. And that will enhance the capacity of the executive to address development challenges.

The argument for ONOE rests on a simple proposition: infrastructure projects and long-term programmes, interrupted repeatedly by election-induced pauses, will perform sub-optimally. The results are time overruns, inflated budgets, and administrative inertia. This should not be acceptable at a time when India must accelerate growth to achieve Viksit Bharat by 2047.

India's ambitions are generational in scale. Its current electoral calendar is ultra-short-term, making it misaligned with development imperatives. It is an institutional design problem-one that compounds silently with every election cycle.

ONOE will not resolve all governance challenges. It is not a panacea. But it is a structural precondition for a democracy that seeks to plan and execute over sustained periods, rather than remain perpetually distracted by multiple electoral cycles.

The choice before India is not between democracy and development. It is between a democracy aligned with its aspirations and one that is not. That alignment begins, though it does not end, with this reform.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

INDIA'S AMBITIONS ARE GENERATIONAL IN SCALE. ITS CURRENT ELECTORAL CALENDAR IS ULTRA-SHORT-TERM, MAKING IT MISALIGNED WITH DEVELOPMENT IMPERATIVES.

Rajiv Kumar, Chairman at Pahlé India Foundation; and Rajdeep Singh, Executive Assistant to the Leadership Office at Pahlé India Foundation

dailypioneer

@TheDailyPioneer

The Pioneer

Public health challenges in migration and conflict



Global health is a shared responsibility among all nations, not the duty of any single country, because no nation exists in complete isolation in today's interconnected world. This basic concept has been the foundation for ensuring that no one is left behind until today. It has guided international cooperation since the adoption of the Constitution of the World Health Organization in 1948 and led to the development of the International Health Regulations in 1969 and their revision in 2005. This cooperation is reflected in Article 1 of the World Health Assembly in May 1980: "THE WORLD AND ALL ITS PEOPLES HAVE WON FREEDOM FROM SMALLPOX". Therefore, it was a collective global effort that won the battle against and eradicated smallpox worldwide. However, this concept now appears to be under jeopardy amid the current massive changes in the multilateral world.

The current trend of international negotiations suggests the possibility of emerging threats such as Mpox, a return of COVID-19, and the increasing spread of influenza. These risks require a comprehensive understanding of their underlying mechanisms, cross-national variations, and the available strategies for prevention and mitigation. This cannot be achieved by one country alone; it requires collaboration, trust, knowledge-sharing, and transparency. Such cooperation cannot be sustained through bilateral negotiations that protect one side over the other. This raises the question: have we truly been within a multilateral system, or has it been ruled by bilateral arrangements that continue without fulfilling multilateral obligations? And how will this impact different countries?

There are multiple perspectives regarding the decisions the Trump administration has made since early 2025. They could be seen as a way to direct health priorities, with multilateralism shifting towards bilateral and power-based interests rather than collective global interests, which does not work well in health. They may also highlight a defect that has been eroding multilateral diplomacy for a long time, though this was not very clear before 2025. However, one thing is evident: the growing focus on health security over "health for all" and the broader improvement of the international economy.

In the Middle East and North Africa (MENA) region, many countries are under multiple stressors; many are in conflict or in a fragile state. The sense of possibly being left without support since January 2025 has revealed these countries' vulnerabilities in terms of public health. In countries such as Yemen and Sudan, all the main aspects of the health system have been depleted because of civil conflicts, and the added weight of losing support has had a major impact. In Yemen, the depleted health system must deal with increased morbidity and mortality caused by the conflict, alongside the spread of communicable diseases, a rising burden of non-communicable diseases, and widespread malnutrition.

The health systems of both countries need to support a huge number of internally displaced persons-over three million in Yemen and over nine million in Sudan. Yemen also acts as a transit country for migrants, which requires additional support from health services. In 2025, over one hundred and fifty thousand migrants passed through the country, with more than 21,500 in December alone, marking an increasing trend in migrant arrivals. These migrants have significant health needs, particularly regarding communicable diseases, which could become a future concern for the government of Yemen and surrounding countries. Prioritising such needs and determining how countries should address them remain critical questions. Irregular migration predisposes both migrants and the local population to increased health risks.

A study by LP Goldsmith on COVID-19 vaccination equity among undocumented migrants highlighted that low vaccination coverage, driven by supply — and demand-related barriers such as limited vaccine availability, documentation requirements, fear of deportation, lack of accessible information, and weak local health systems, further increases public health vulnerabilities in fragile and conflict-affected settings. This represents a serious situation that requires multi-level investment, including strengthening health infrastructure, improving biological disaster preparedness, and building inclusive health systems-all of which demand doubled or even tripled rebuilding efforts in contexts of collapsed governance following civil conflict.

At the same time, countries such as the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Qatar may also be at risk of disease spread and may require support. This could influence the emerging shape of multilateral health cooperation. Addressing these issues will involve shifting priorities, especially in light of changing geopolitical interests. Prioritising national health security alone will lead to greater individualism if all countries follow the same approach. This also reinforces the perception that outbreaks originate only in developing countries-an unpredictable and misleading assumption that may further deepen divisions between nations. Many countries are already under extreme political and social tensions. Should we wait until another large-scale global health crisis spreads, and a new wave of widespread mortality leads to the loss of a large percentage of the world's population, as smallpox once did-killing over 1.4 million annually worldwide in the 1960s-before we regain our solidarity as humans and our sympathy for one another and for the world? Must we wait until then to admit that it is our shared responsibility? Or is this a call to rediscover that same solidarity and unified aim to protect against diseases?

The global landscape is likely to disproportionately affect countries that are already at the bottom of the priority list for support during crises, making them increasingly vulnerable to future disease outbreaks. In the end, will the answer be closing borders? And how will that impact the world? These are questions that must be asked and carefully considered.



These migrants have significant health needs, particularly regarding communicable diseases, which could become a future concern for the government of Yemen and surrounding countries. Prioritising such needs and determining how countries should address them remain critical questions. Irregular migration predisposes both migrants and the local population to increased health risks.

A study by LP Goldsmith on COVID-19 vaccination equity among undocumented migrants highlighted that low vaccination coverage, driven by supply — and demand-related barriers such as limited vaccine availability, documentation requirements, fear of deportation, lack of accessible information, and weak local health systems, further increases public health vulnerabilities in fragile and conflict-affected settings. This represents a serious situation that requires multi-level investment, including strengthening health infrastructure, improving biological disaster preparedness, and building inclusive health systems-all of which demand doubled or even tripled rebuilding efforts in contexts of collapsed governance following civil conflict.

At the same time, countries such as the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Qatar may also be at risk of disease spread and may require support. This could influence the emerging shape of multilateral health cooperation. Addressing these issues will involve shifting priorities, especially in light of changing geopolitical interests. Prioritising national health security alone will lead to greater individualism if all countries follow the same approach. This also reinforces the perception that outbreaks originate only in developing countries-an unpredictable and misleading assumption that may further deepen divisions between nations. Many countries are already under extreme political and social tensions. Should we wait until another large-scale global health crisis spreads, and a new wave of widespread mortality leads to the loss of a large percentage of the world's population, as smallpox once did-killing over 1.4 million annually worldwide in the 1960s-before we regain our solidarity as humans and our sympathy for one another and for the world? Must we wait until then to admit that it is our shared responsibility? Or is this a call to rediscover that same solidarity and unified aim to protect against diseases?

The global landscape is likely to disproportionately affect countries that are already at the bottom of the priority list for support during crises, making them increasingly vulnerable to future disease outbreaks. In the end, will the answer be closing borders? And how will that impact the world? These are questions that must be asked and carefully considered.

Shantesh Kumar Singh, Professor, Centre for International Politics, Organisation and Disarmament, School of International Studies, JNU, New Delhi, India and Weiam Al-Hunaishi, University of Malaya, Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia, Executive Diploma Candidate, United Nations Institute for Training and Research (UNITAR)

dailypioneer

@TheDailyPioneer

The Pioneer



to workers whose sacrifice gave Asia one of its most important labour rights: the 8-hour workday.

As the 90th anniversary of the Savana Mill Labour Strike is remembered, the spotlight falls on a remarkable truth-Puducherry became the first place in Asia to implement the 8-hour workday in 1937. This was not a gift from rulers. It was earned through courage, unity, and sacrifice. In the 1930s, Puducherry was under French colonial rule.

Textile mills formed the backbone of the local economy. Among them, the Savana Mill stood as a symbol of both industrial growth and human suffering. Workers toiled for nearly 14 hours a day. Wages were painfully low. Working conditions were harsh and exhausting. There were no formal rights, no protections, no voice.

The idea of limiting work to eight hours had already stirred movements in other parts of the

world. In Puducherry, it sounded almost impossible. Still, the workers chose to dream-and then to act. On July 30, 1936, the workers of Savana Mill launched a historic strike. Their demands were clear: an 8-hour workday, fair wages, and the right to form unions. This was more than a protest. It was a demand for dignity and recognition as human beings, not just as labouring hands.

The response from the French colonial administration was swift and brutal. Armed forces confronted unarmed workers. Gunfire broke out. Twelve workers lost their lives. The day entered history as a "Black Day" for Puducherry.

Families were shattered. The streets carried the silence of grief and anger. Sacrifice often becomes the turning point of history. The deaths of these workers did not crush the movement. It strengthened it. Public outrage grew. The incident exposed the deep injustice of colonial labour practices. Pressure mounted on the authorities.

The result came within a year. In 1937, Puducherry achieved what no other region in Asia had at the time — the official implementation of the 8-hour workday. This was a landmark moment. It placed Puducherry ahead of many parts of the continent in labour reform. It proved that organised resistance could force even a colonial regime to change its policies.

This achievement carries global significance. The demand for an 8-hour workday had earlier shaken the United States during the Haymarket Affair. Workers there had also faced violence



while fighting for the same cause. Puducherry's victory connected it to this global wave of labour movements. It showed that the spirit of resistance knew no boundaries-geographical or political. The Workers' Memorial on the Puducherry-Cuddalore Road stands today in honour of those who laid down their lives.

Many pass by without knowing that this place represents a breakthrough for workers across Asia. It is not just a statue. It is a symbol of one of the earliest victories for labour rights on the continent.

The 8-hour workday now feels normal. It shapes daily life across industries. Offices, factories, and institutions follow this rhythm. Behind this normalcy lies a history of struggle.

The workers of Puducherry turned an impossible demand into a living reality. This 90th anniversary is not just about remembering the past.

It is about understanding the value of what was achieved. In today's world, where work patterns are changing rapidly and debates on labour rights continue, the story of Puducherry offers a powerful lesson. Rights are not permanent unless they are protected and remembered.

Puducherry's place in history deserves wider recognition. It stands as a pioneer in Asia's labour movement. It reminds us that even under colonial rule, ordinary workers could reshape systems through unity and determination.

The next time one passes that quiet statue on

the Puducherry-Cuddalore Road, it is worth pausing for a moment. Those figures represent more than memory. They represent a victory that changed working life across a continent. Eight hours of work. Eight hours of rest. Eight hours to live as human beings. This simple idea became a reality in Puducherry in 1937. And that changed Asia forever.

Conclusion

The victory of Puducherry's workers did more than shorten the workday — it redefined the relationship between labour and power. It showed that even under colonial rule, organised workers could compel structural change, setting a precedent that echoed across Asia's emerging labour movements.

The 8-hour day became a foundation for modern labour rights, influencing wage structures, workplace safety norms, and the idea of work-life balance itself. Its implications endure today, as new forms of employment challenge established protections. The lesson is clear: rights are neither automatic nor permanent.

They must be defended, adapted, and renewed. Puducherry's achievement is not just history — it is a living benchmark for dignity at work.

The writer is Professor Centre For South Asian Studies, School of International Studies & Social Sciences Pondicherry Central University

dailypioneer

@TheDailyPioneer

dr-santhosh-mathew-7a68533ba

Your Trusted Management Advisory

www.transglobeadvisors.in

Order Order

Thane Court acquits three; prosecution fails to establish guilt

A Thane court has acquitted three persons accused in a 2021 murder case, noting that the prosecution failed to establish their guilt beyond a reasonable doubt, with key witnesses not supporting the case. While the medical evidence confirmed homicidal death, it was insufficient to link the accused to the crime, Principal District and Sessions Judge SB Agrawal said in the order passed on Monday.

The prosecution alleged that the accused had assaulted the victim, Gulab Shaikh, with an iron pipe of an umbrella on December 3, 2021, in the Kalwa area of Maharashtra's Thane city, following a monetary dispute over liquor consumption. The victim later died.

The accused, however, contested the charges against them. During the trial, the prosecution examined eight persons, including an informant, a medical officer, an investigation officer and two "eyewitnesses".

The court found significant gaps in the prosecution's case. Both alleged eyewitnesses also did not support the prosecution. (PTI)



Sukesh's wife denied bail in ₹200 cr extortion case

The Delhi High Court on Tuesday refused to grant bail to Leena Paulose in the ₹200 crore extortion case involving her husband, alleged conman Sukesh Chandrasekhar, but granted her reprieve in a related money laundering case.

"I have rejected the application in the MCOCA case but allowed it in (ED case)," said Justice Prateek Jalan while dealing with Paulose's bail pleas in the two cases probed by the Delhi police and Enforcement Directorate (ED).

The Delhi Police has booked Chandrasekhar for allegedly duping the wives of former promoters of Ranbaxy, Shivinder Singh and Malvinder Singh, of ₹200 crore. The police alleged that Chandrasekhar and his associates reportedly took money from Shivinder Mohan Singh's wife, Aditi Singh, by posing as Government officials and promising to secure bail for her husband, who was in jail in a money laundering case.

Several separate investigations against Chandrasekhar in the country are currently underway. (PTI)



Delhi HC permits Engineer Rashid to visit father in AIIMS till May 10

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Tuesday permitted jailed Baramulla MP Sheikh Abdul Rashid alias Engineer Rashid to meet his ailing father in AIIMS Delhi for 12 hours a day till May 10.

Modifying its earlier order granting interim bail to Rashid in a terror funding case to enable him to see his father in Srinagar, a bench of Justices Prathiba M Singh and Madhu Jain clarified that after the meeting in AIIMS, he would return to jail.

The bench added that the other conditions, including the presence of at least two police personnel in plain clothes with Rashid, would be the same. The court added that the police officials would stand outside his father's ward in AIIMS.

"Since the appellant's



father is already in AIIMS Delhi and the intention of the order dated April 28 was for the appellant to spend time with his father, the order is modified to the effect that the appellant be permitted to meet his father from 8 am to 8 pm on a daily basis till the 10th of May," the court said.

"After the time elapses, the appellant shall continue to be lodged in jail," it added.

The court also turned down a request by the NIA

their applications alleging conflict of interest and apprehension of bias.

Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma deferred the hearing on the CBI's petition challenging the trial court decision till May 8, observing that it would be appropriate to proceed with the matter once someone is appointed to represent them.

"I will appoint an amicus. I will appoint somebody. I will appoint three seniors in this case," Justice Sharma said. Solicitor General Tushar



Excommunicating Parsi women discriminatory, observes SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Tuesday observed that the practice of excommunicating Parsi women for entering into interfaith marriages is prima facie discriminatory.

A nine-judge bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said the right of conscience under Article 25 (1) of the Constitution is a right by birth and cannot be taken away by marriage.

The bench, also comprising Justices BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan and Joymalya Bagchi, was hearing petitions regarding discrimination against women at



religious sites, including the Sabarimala temple in Kerala, as well as the scope of religious freedom across various faiths.

The Constitution bench is also

examining the question whether the community's religious head's power to expel member(s) from religious life can coexist with the individual's right to profess and practice religion

Allahabad HC convicts 2 men in 1984 murder case, overturns acquittal after 42 years



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The Lucknow bench of the Allahabad High Court has convicted two persons in a 1984 murder case, overturning their acquittal after over four decades, officials said.

A division bench of Justices Rajneesh Kumar and Babita Rani on Monday allowed the State Government's appeal and held the accused guilty of culpable homicide not amounting to murder under Section 304 of the IPC.

The court directed that the two surviving accused be taken into custody and produced before it on May 11 for a hearing on the quantum of sentence.

There were four accused in the case, all of whom had been acquitted by a trial court in 1986 on the grounds of self-defence. However, two of them died during the pendency of the appeal, leaving the remaining two to face the High Court verdict.

The case pertains to an inci-

dent on June 15, 1984, in the Maakhi police station area of Unnao district.

According to the prosecution, the deceased, Jamuna Prasad, was constructing a drain on the roof of his house when the accused, Tulsi Ram, Laxmi Narayan, Jagat Pal and Harnam, objected to it, leading to an altercation.

The dispute escalated, and the accused allegedly attacked Jamuna Prasad and his brother Amrit Lal with sticks and spears. Jamuna Prasad succumbed to his injuries on the way to the hospital.

The trial court had acquitted the accused, observing that they had acted in self-defence as they too had sustained injuries, which the prosecution failed to explain.

Rejecting this reasoning, the High Court held that taking a person's life over a minor dispute, such as water drainage, cannot be justified as self-defence and termed the trial court's findings as "completely flawed", according to the order.

Drone import bribery case: Delhi court grants bail to senior executive of corporate group

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has granted bail to Bharat Mathur, a senior vice president of a major corporate group, who was arrested along with a deputy director general of the DGCA in connection with a ₹2.5 lakh bribery case allegedly linked to facilitating the import of drones for a private company.

Special Judge Chhavi Kapoor was hearing Mathur's plea seeking relief. The accused had been earlier remanded to five days of CBI custody and was subsequently sent to judicial custody till May 6. On April 18, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) arrested Mathur and Mudavath Devula, Deputy Director General in the Airworthiness



Directorate of the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) at its New Delhi headquarters.

In an order passed on Monday, the judge said, "It is not denied by CBI that the amount of ₹2.5 lakh, which was allegedly paid as a bribe by the accused to the co-accused public servant, has

Thane MCOCA court acquits robbery case accused, cites identity doubt

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

A special court in Thane district on Monday acquitted a 43-year-old man in a 2022 robbery case in which he was also booked under the tough Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act, observing the prosecution failed to prove the accused's identity beyond reasonable doubt.

Special MCOCA Court Judge VG Mohite acquitted the accused, Bakar alias Babar Akram Alli, a resident of Bidar in Karnataka, of all criminal charges slapped on him. He was booked under Section 394 (voluntarily causing hurt in commit-



ting robbery) read with section 34 (common intention) of the IPC and relevant provisions of the MCOCA.

The special public prosecutor told the court that a woman was robbed of a gold necklace worth ₹1.5 lakh by two masked motorcycle-borne men at Thakurli in Thane district on October 10, 2022. Advocate Poonit

Mahimkar, who represented the accused, sought to punched holes in the prosecution story.

During the trial, the court observed that the prime witnesses failed to reliably identify the accused as the perpetrators wore masks during the robbery.

Judge Mohite noted, "The identity of the accused is not proved beyond doubt by the prosecution. Evidence of prosecution witnesses is a weak piece of evidence to prove his identity.

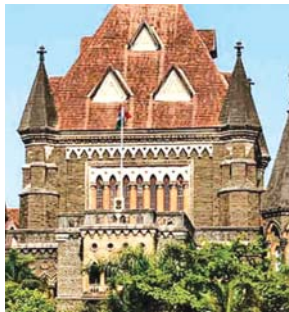
They have not properly seen the faces of robbers as they had covered their faces by masks and the incident happened in a fraction of moment."

HC frees 50 stranded seafarers; raps vessel owners for treating crew worse than pets

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court on Tuesday directed the release of 50 seafarers stranded on three ships arrested off the Mumbai coast, slamming vessel owners for treating crew members worse than "pet animals" by providing minimal food and water for months.

"Life comes only once. We don't believe in rebirth," the court observed while accusing the ship owners of being "least interested in human lives" and prioritising their commercial activities over the health of the crew.



The seafarers, in their plea in HC, claimed that they were stranded with a minimum supply of food and water on the vessels, which were practically abandoned by the owners, following arrest for illegal fuel oil and bitumen transfers mid-sea, about 11 nautical miles from the city.

As many as 50 seafarers were stranded onboard MT Asphalt Star, MT Stellar Ruby and MT Al Jafzia, and seven of them moved the High Court with a habeas corpus (produce the person) petition. The court on Monday ordered the Yellow Gate police to produce all 50 seafarers before it on Tuesday.

PIL has become Paisa Interest Litigation and Political Interest Litigation, says SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Commenting on the misuse of PILs, the Supreme Court on Tuesday remarked that Public Interest Litigation has now become 'Private Interest Litigation', 'Publicity Interest Litigation', 'Paisa Interest Litigation' and 'Political Interest Litigation'.

This observation came from a nine-judge Constitution bench while they were hearing petitions regarding discrimination against women at religious sites, including the Sabarimala temple in Kerala, as well as the scope of religious freedom across various faiths.

The bench comprised Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justices BV Nagarathna, MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B



Varale, R Mahadevan and Joymalya Bagchi.

The top court questioned the objective of the Indian Young Lawyers Association over its 2006 PIL challenging the prohibition of women aged 10 to 50 from entering the Sabarimala Temple in Kerala.

Advocate Ravi Prakash Gupta, representing the Indian Young Lawyers Association, argued that the PIL was based on four news-

paper articles published in June 2006.

In response, the CJI remarked that the PIL should have been dismissed outright. "How does this article give the cause of action to file a PIL? It is easy to get articles written for the sake of filing PILs," the bench said.

Justice Nagarathna added, "We have been entertaining PILs in High Courts and in the Supreme

Court for the general public who need it. Not for articles being written in newspapers.

"Public Interest Litigation has now become Private Interest Litigation, Publicity Interest Litigation, Paisa Interest Litigation and Political Interest Litigation. All are called PILs, but we entertain only real and genuine PILs," she said.

She also noted that the CJI receives hundreds of letters daily, questioning whether they could all be turned into PILs.

The hearing is underway. A five-judge Constitution bench had lifted the ban preventing women between the ages of 10 and 50 from entering the Sabarimala Ayyappa temple in a 4:1 majority verdict in September 2018, ruling that the centuries-old Hindu religious practice was illegal and unconstitutional.

departmental action against the CBI's investigating officer in the liquor policy case.

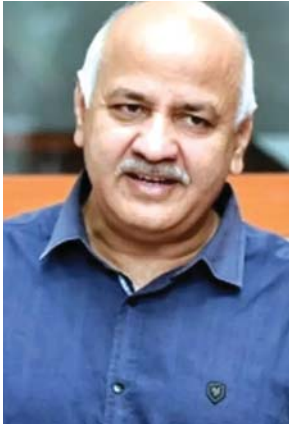
While issuing notice to all 23 accused on CBI's plea against their discharge, Justice Sharma said certain observations and findings of the trial court at the stage of framing of charges prima facie appeared erroneous and needed consideration.

Subsequently, Kejriwal, Sisodia and other respondents moved an application seeking the recusal of the judge.

would not appear before her personally or through a lawyer and would follow "Mahatma Gandhi's path of Satyagraha".

On February 27, the trial court discharged Kejriwal, Sisodia and 21 others in the liquor policy case, observing that the case was wholly unable to survive judicial scrutiny and stood discredited in its entirety.

On March 9, Justice Sharma's bench stayed the trial court's recommendation on the initiation of



Mehta, appearing for the CBI, asked if the court was making the appointment for Kejriwal and others who were unrepresented in the proceedings, the judge replied in the affirmative.

"We will list it on Friday. I will pass an order on amicus and then start hearing," she added.

After Justice Sharma dismissed their applications seeking her recusal in the case on April 20, Kejriwal, Sisodia and Pathak wrote to Justice Sharma, stating they

They claimed that the judge's children are empanelled central Government lawyers who receive work through solicitor general Tushar Mehta, who appears for the CBI in the excise case.

On April 20, Justice Sharma junked the recusal plea, saying that judges cannot recuse themselves to satisfy a litigant's unfounded apprehension of bias.

Pathak, Vijay Nair and Arun Ramchandra Pillai had also sought her recusal.

Will appoint senior counsel to represent Kejriwal, Sisodia in excise case: Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Tuesday said it will appoint senior lawyers as amici curiae to represent AAP leaders Arvind Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia and Durgesh Pathak in the CBI case against their discharge in the liquor policy case.

The former Delhi chief minister and MLAs boycotted the hearing before Justice Sharma after the judge refused to recuse herself on

iexceed

Appzillon™

AI Powered Digital Banking Solutions

WWW.i-exceed.com

Stock markets decline as geopolitical tensions drag markets

Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty buckled under selling pressure on Tuesday as fresh tensions flared in the Strait of Hormuz region and the ceasefire between the US and Iran came under strain.

The rupee hitting a record low against the US dollar amid elevated crude prices also made investors cautious.

In a volatile session, the 30-share BSE Sensex dropped 251.61 points, or 0.33 per cent, to settle at 77,017.79. During the day, it tanked 754.37 points, or 0.97 per cent, to 76,515.03. The 50-share NSE Nifty edged lower by 86.50 points, or 0.36 per cent, to end at 24,032.80.

“Domestic equities witnessed a volatile session, closing lower as post-election optimism faded and sentiment re-aligned with global weakness amid rising geopolitical tensions.” “Elevated crude prices continued to pressure the rupee, which slipped to record lows. Despite these headwinds, the ongoing earnings season, with results slightly ahead of expectations, provided some support and triggered selective bottom-fishing,” Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.

From the Sensex firms, ICICI Bank, Eternal, Tech Mahindra, Axis Bank, Bharti Airtel and Larsen & Toubro were among the major laggards.

On the other hand, Mahindra & Mahindra, UltraTech Cement, Bajaj Finserv and Bajaj Finance were top gainers. (PTI)

Rupee falls 2 paise at fresh record low of 95.25 against US dollar

The rupee fell 2 paise to close at an all-time low of 95.25 (provisional) against the US dollar on Tuesday, as investors are retreating from riskier assets amid renewed clashes in the Gulf and targeting of UAE infrastructure, which have reignited supply chain fears.

Forex traders said Brent oil, hovering near \$110 per barrel, is maintaining pressure on oil-importing economies like India. Moreover, factors such as unabated foreign capital outflows amid rising geopolitical uncertainties dented investor sentiments further.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.30 against the US dollar, then lost ground and touched an all-time low of 95.44 in intraday trade. The rupee finally settled for the day at a fresh record low of 95.25 (provisional), registering a fall of 2 paise over its previous close.

On Monday, the rupee fell 39 paise to close at an all-time low of 95.23 against the US dollar. (PTI)

Inflation target could be tweaked: RBI DG

India could consider lowering the inflation target and trimming the tolerance band if GDP growth remains robust with a more stable inflation over the next five years, RBI Deputy Governor Poonam Gupta said on Tuesday.

However, if the global environment remains as challenging as it has been during the past six years, it would warrant both predictability and flexibility inherent in the existing framework, she said.

The Government, after consultation with the RBI, has notified the inflation target framework for a five year period through March 31, 2031. As per the framework, the Reserve Bank has to keep inflation at 4 per cent (+/- 2 per cent) from FY27-FY31. Speaking at an NCAER seminar, Gupta said the future of the inflation targeting framework in India would depend on the combination of inflation and growth outcomes as they evolve during the next five years. Also, the future inflation targeting framework would have to take into account the global shocks that the economy may have to weather.

“If growth-inflation mix evolves as it has in the past 10 years in the sense that we continue to have robust growth and lower and more stable inflation, perhaps one could consider going the way other economies have gone,” she said.

“Perhaps there would be a case to lower the level and narrow the band. But much would depend on the experience of the next four years, which would be taken as input into the next review,” Gupta said. (PTI)

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | WEDNESDAY | MAY 6, 2026

India most resilient emerging economy: Moody's

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India has been the most resilient large emerging market economy since 2020, and its sizeable forex reserves have helped check currency volatility and reinforce confidence during global shocks, Moody's Ratings said on Tuesday.

In a report on emerging market, Moody's said India is well placed to manage future shocks because monetary policy frameworks are clear and predictable, inflation expectations are well anchored, and exchange rates

can adjust when needed. Stating that India is “better placed” among emerging market sovereigns to manage future global shock, Moody's said the country would also enter any future periods of stress with strong and accessible buffers.

“India's reliance on domestic funding is balanced by deep local markets and sizeable reserves... Nevertheless, India's relatively high debt burden and weak fiscal balance limit the amount of space available to respond to successive shocks,” Moody's added. It said India had made key policy choices that

support stability well before the recent stress period.

Moody's said several large emerging market sovereigns have absorbed a series of

major global shocks over the past five years without sharp increase in risk premia or a loss of market access.

This reflects durable

India, Jamaica agree to boost trade, skilled mobility: Jaishankar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kingston

India and Jamaica agreed to further strengthen trade linkages and explore cooperation for recruitment and mobility of skilled professionals, including healthcare workers and teachers, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said.

Addressing a joint press conference here after talks with his Jamaican counterpart Kamina J Smith on Monday, Jaishankar said the discussions were comprehensive, and they reviewed the entire gamut of bilateral ties, identifying new avenues to deepen the partnership.

“We signed several important agreements and discussed effective implementations of MOUs which have been recently concluded in the fields of digital transformation, cultural exchange, sports and digital payments to ensure tangible outcomes on the ground,” he said.

India recognised Jamaica's growing role as a logistics hub and gateway to the Caribbean for trade and investment, Jaishankar said.

“We agreed to further strengthen trade, business and investment linkages, explore cooperation for recruitment and mobility of skilled professionals, including nurses, healthcare

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar addressing a gathering during a meeting with Jamaica's industry and business leaders in Kingston PTI

workers and teachers,” he said. The two sides also discussed expanding cooperation in defence and security, healthcare, digitisation, agriculture, education and infrastructure, the minister said.

Highlighting development cooperation as a key pillar of ties, Jaishankar noted the successful completion of the Improving Rural Livelihoods Project in Kitson Town in March 2026, implemented with Indian assistance of \$1 million under the India-UN Development Partnership Fund, benefiting over 200 individuals and impacting thousands more. He said

India is also discussing the feasibility of establishing an artisan empowerment hub in Jamaica and reiterated support for the country's recovery following Hurricane Melissa.

As part of humanitarian assistance, India has supplied relief material, deployed a medical team and is in the process of providing 30 dialysis units. It is also sending 40 fishing boats and 200 GPS units to aid recovery efforts.

The ministers reaffirmed close cooperation in multilateral fora and discussed issues such as reformed multilateralism, climate

India fuel retailers face credit strain as high oil prices persist, says Fitch

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's oil marketing companies could see mounting credit pressure if crude prices remain elevated, with delayed fuel price pass-through threatening earnings and cash flow, Fitch Ratings said on Tuesday.

Sustained high oil prices would quickly erode EBITDA if domestic pump prices fail to keep pace with rising input costs, while large inventory holdings and refining volumes would increase working-capital needs.

Fitch said the duration of elevated prices, rather than short-term spikes, is the main credit risk. “Indian oil marketing companies are more vulnerable if elevated crude prices persist. Fuel marketing losses can quickly erode EBITDA if domestic pump prices do not adjust in step with input costs. “Companies' large inventory holdings and refining volumes mean a sustained rise in crude prices would increase working-capital needs and pressure Free Cash Flow (FCF). This

makes duration, rather than any short-lived price spike, the main credit risk,” it said. Differences in business mix and capital spending are likely to drive divergence in stand-alone credit profiles.

Indian Oil Corp's more diversified operations should provide greater resilience, while Bharat Petroleum faces tighter headroom due to rising expansion and transition spending. Hindustan Petroleum's credit profile may strengthen as major joint-venture projects are completed, although prolonged high prices could delay that improvement. “Pressure on Indian issuers' Standalone Credit Profiles (SCPs) may

diverge based on their business model and capex intensity. Indian Oil Corporation Ltd's more diversified business mix should make its financial profile more resilient than peers.

“Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited's SCP headroom is more exposed to a prolonged adverse environment because of its rising expansion and transition spending. We expect Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited's limited SCP headroom to improve as major joint-venture growth projects are completed, but a longer period of high oil prices would delay that increase,” Fitch said.

Auto industry posts record retail sales at 26,11,317 units in April, says FADA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Total automobile retail sales in India grew by 12.94 per cent with a record 26,11,317 units in April as compared to 23,12,221 units in the same month last year, making a bright start to the new fiscal, Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations said on Tuesday.

Sustained tailwinds from GST 2.0 affordability gains, RBI's supportive rate stance, healthy rural cash flows post a strong rabi cycle and an extended marriage season helped the industry post a robust performance, Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA) said in a statement.

Passenger vehicles (PV) retail sales were at a record 4,07,355 units last month as compared to 3,63,028 units in April 2025, a growth of 12.21 per cent, it added.

Two-wheelers also clocked best-ever monthly numbers at 19,16,258 units in April this year as compared to 16,95,638 units in the same month a year ago, at a growth of 13.01 per cent, it added.

FADA further said three-wheeler sales stood at 1,06,908 units last month as compared to 99,741 units in April 2025, up 7.19 per cent. Commercial vehicles also

witnessed a growth of 15.02 per cent at a record 99,339 units last month as compared to 86,364 units in April 2025, it added.

“The Indian auto retail industry has opened FY2026-27 on an exceptionally strong note, retailing 26,11,317 units in April 2026, a 12.94 per cent YoY expansion that delivers the highest-ever April in our records,” FADA Vice President

Sai Giridhar said. Five of the six vehicle categories, along with the total industry, registered all-time April records, he said, adding, “This clearly underlines that the structural demand momentum which defined the second half of FY26 has carried into the new financial year.”

Giridhar said in the PV segment, the defining feature was the continued “outperformance of Bharat over the metros” as rural sales grew 20.40 per cent, nearly three times the Urban pace of 7.11 per cent.

“This confirms the structural broadening of personal mobility into Tier-3 and rural India, supported by a small-car revival, sustained SUV demand and a richer alternative-powertrain product mix where CNG share held firm at 22.62 per cent and EV share improved further to 5.77 per cent,” he said.

BUSINESS

11

improvements in policy frameworks and the buildup of buffers, as well as particularly supportive external conditions. Moody's assessed emerging market sovereigns' track records of resilience in their funding costs and market access to volatile financial conditions.

It focussed on large emerging market countries (India, Indonesia, Mexico, Malaysia, Thailand, Brazil, South Africa, Nigeria, Turkiye, Argentina) over four stress episodes identified by sustained increases in global risk aversion. These are the onset of the Covid-19 pandemic in early 2020, the

global inflation surge and associated US Federal Reserve tightening cycle in 2022, US regional banking stress in early 2023, and renewed tariff tensions in 2025.

Together, these episodes capture a range of external shocks that typically generate late-cycle emerging market stress through exchange-rate pressure, tighter funding conditions and refinancing risks. Moody's said.

“Relatively accommodative external market conditions in the wake of recent shocks helped emerging markets absorb successive external shocks since 2020,” it noted.

India's coffee exports jump 27% in Jan-Apr

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's coffee exports rose 26.6 per cent to 1.74 lakh tonne in the January-April period of 2026, mainly driven by higher shipments of robusta and instant coffee, Government data showed.

The country had exported 1.37 lakh tonne of coffee in the year-ago period. India ships arabica and robusta varieties, as well as instant coffee.

In value terms, total exports rose to ₹936.57 crore from ₹757.07 crore a year ago, while unit value realisation edged higher to ₹4,94,766 per tonne from ₹4,75,023 per tonne.

Robusta exports climbed 36 per cent to 85,168 tonne in January-April from 62,736.92 tonne in the year-ago period, while instant coffee shipments rose to 20,332 tonne from 17,504 tonne, Coffee Board data showed.

Re-exports of instant coffee increased to 38,169 tonne from 30,274 tonne.

Arabica exports, however, fell 58 per cent to 30,589 tonne from 72,479 tonne a year ago. India exported 3.82 lakh tonne of coffee in the 2025 calendar year.

Experts said India's coffee sector is entering 2026 with renewed momentum, with the country's role in the global coffee economy evolving beyond its traditional identity as a robusta supplier. Record production estimates, rising export values, higher imports for processing and steady domestic consumption growth point to an industry at an inflection point, they said.

The Coffee Board of India's post-blossom estimate for 2025-26 (October-September) projects output at a record 4,03,000 tonne, with gains expected across the three major producing states of Karnataka, Kerala and Tamil Nadu.

end remains relatively insulated. At the same time, channel inventory corrections and more value-conscious consumers are extending upgrade cycles. Together, these factors are driving near-term volume pressure — especially in the affordable and value-for-money tiers — resulting in the projected 10-12 per cent decline in 2026,” he said.

Apple shipments in India increased 6 per cent YoY and 9 per cent market share during the reported quarter. Surprisingly, Apple shipments were driven by demand for iPhone 16 during the reported quarter.

West Asia crisis to moderate

India's growth pc to 6.3%: ADB

KUMAR DIPANKAR
■ Samarkand (Uzbekistan)

The ongoing Middle East crisis is going to shade off India's GDP growth by 0.6 per cent to 6.3 per cent and also stoke inflation significantly in the current financial year, as per the latest update, ADB Chief Economist Albert Park said on Tuesday.

The Asian Development Bank (ADB) in April projected India's GDP growth to remain “robust” at 6.9 per cent in the current fiscal, and rise to 7.3 per cent in the next fiscal, driven by strong domestic demand.

With regard to inflation, ADB had projected at 4.5 per cent for the current fiscal.

For India, Park said, “we do find that growth would be lower by 0.6 per cent (FY27). This is based on our model scenario. But it would not negatively affect growth next year. India would kind of bounce back next.” Inflation

would increase by 2.4 per cent this year to 6.9 per cent, he told PTI in an interview on the sidelines of ADB Annual Meet here.

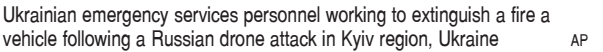
“So that's a bit higher than the inflation impacts for the region (Asia-Pacific), because India is more reliant on imported oil and gas. The growth effect, if you take out China, this negative 0.6 per cent on growth this year is pretty similar to the region as a whole region as well,” he said. (PTI)

IRAN

Thirteen persons have been arrested in Pakistan's Punjab province for their alleged involvement in "anti-state" social media activities, an official said on Tuesday. The arrested individuals include those associated with jailed former prime minister Imran Khan's Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) party. "In a crackdown against anti-state social media activities, the National Cyber Crime Investigation Agency (NCCIA) has arrested 13 individuals from different cities of Punjab recently," NCCIA Punjab Director Muhammad Ali Waseem said in a statement. The arrested individuals have been accused of running a campaign against the Pakistan Army and the Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz (PML-N) government on different social media platforms.

An Indian national and a Nepalese mountain guide were injured during an attempt to scale Mt Everest on Tuesday, an official said. Indian climber Nimish Kumar Singh, 40 and Pemba Tenduk Sherpa, 44, Nepalese mountain guide, were injured when an ice block fell on them early on Tuesday morning while attempting to scale Mt Everest, Nisha Thapa Raut, director at Tourism Department, Nepal's Ministry of Tourism and Civil Aviation, said. The incident occurred days after the trail was open for the climbers for the season. They were hit by the Ice serac while moving towards Camp II from the Base Camp, she said. They have been rescued from the mountain and immediately flown to Kathmandu where they are receiving treatment at Hams Hospital, she added. The condition of both the climber and the mountain guide is out of danger, said a staff at Summit Treks, who carried out the rescue operation.

HANNA ARHIROVA ■ Kyiv



Zelenskyy replied that Ukraine would observe a truce beginning at the end of Tuesday and would respond in kind to Russia's actions from that moment on. He didn't put an end date on the truce.

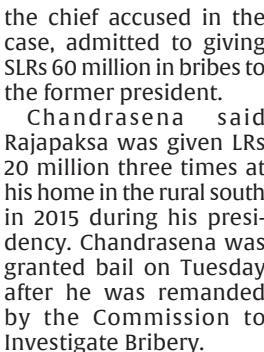
Air defense units stopped 149 drones and one missile, but others got through, it said. Two ballistic missiles failed to reach their targets,

attacked the Kirovskiy Remnery in the Leningrad region close to St Petersburg, sparking a blaze in the town's industrial zone, local Governor Alexander Drozdenko said. (AP)

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

He said that it is essential that the ceasefire be upheld and respected, to allow necessary diplomatic space for dialogue leading to enduring peace and stability in the region. The attacks came amidst uneasy calm in the region after the US and Iran

■ Colombo



Sri Lanka's anti-graft agency will question former president Mahinda Rajapaksa in a case involving the purchase of aircraft for the national carrier during his presidency, a court was told on Tuesday.

Rajapaksa has been issued notices to appear before the Commission to Investigate Allegations of Bribery or Corruption (CIABOC) on May 12.

Prosecutors told the Colombo Chief Magistrate's Court that SriLankan Airlines' former CEO Kapila Chandrasena,

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dhaka

The Border Guard Bangladesh (BGB) has seized a large consignment of smuggled Indian sarees valued at over Taka 1.7 crore during an operation in the Shashidal border area near Brahmanpara upazila of Cumilla.

According to BGB sources, it was made following specific intelligence. A patrol team from Shashidal Border Outpost (BOP), operating under Sultanpur Battalion (60 BGB), carried out an anti-smuggling drive in the area and recovered a substantial quantity of high-quality sarees.

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

The meeting of police chiefs, business and civil society leaders came a week after a terrorist attack targeted Jewish men on the streets of Golders Green in north-west London. "Last week's terrorist attack in Golders Green was utterly appalling. But it was not an isolated incident. It is part of a pattern of rising antisemitism that has left our Jewish communities feeling frightened, angry, and asking whether this country, their home,

The UK PM said that ministers are “clear-eyed” that antisemitism doesn’t have “one source alone” and pointed to Islamist, far-left and far-right extremism as areas of concern.

“That is why this government has put in place the first coordinated national plan to strengthen cohesion and confront extremism



Leaders from business, civil society, health, culture, higher education and policing gathered at the

My client NAIK CHAND GEORGE (N.C.GEORGE) having Aadhar No. 374087976867, Aged about 78 yrs, S/o Late Shri Mangla Ram, R/o Flat No. 6/2, B-Block, Signature House, Apartments, Mukherjee Nagar, New Delhi - 110029, India, appearing at:- House No. 173, Ground Floor, Outram Lane, Kingsway Camp, Delhi-110009, do hereby declare, state and reaffirm that his past/present name i.e. NANAK CHAND GEORGE (N.C.GEORGE) are one and same which pertain/relate and belong to him only as after professing the Christian religion on 10/05/1971, he got added "GEORGE" as suffix to his previous name "CHAND". He further states that said client did not wish to derive any illegal benefit and privileges from any public or Govt authority on any ground whatsoever in nature. The present name i.e. NANAK CHAND GEORGE (N.C.GEORGE) has been adopted and maintained in his all provide as well as Public documents i.e. Aadhar, Passport, Driving License, Voter I.D. and in all bank records, be considered and used for all legal and purpose. He further states that said client already signed and executed an Affidavit dated 05/05/2026 duly authenticated before the SDM concerned, New Delhi and it is being declared put to the knowledge of public at large that the intention to change the name of said client as aforesaid name i.e. NANAK CHAND GEORGE (N.C.GEORGE) as aforesaid, has not been intended and motivated to derive any illegal or un-authorised privilege/s or any other benefit which may accrue to the State/Govt as well as Govt. of India and accordingly, he declares that his past/present name i.e. NANAK CHAND GEORGE (N.C.GEORGE) are the one and same under which he has been known to all. Given under my hand and seal on this 5th day of May, 2026 at New Delhi.

(Nalini L. Sahai) Advocate,
D/1054/1994 Delhi High Court
SAHAY & ASSOCIATES
Advocates & Solicitors
His Chamber No. 616, Lower Ground Floor,
Court Complex, New Delhi-110017
9899969643/nalinisahaiaadvocate@yahoo.co.in

To All Interested Bidder's in Construction Tender of N.R.Iy.

Northern Railway Construction Organization has been assigned to execute the project works of "**Delhi-Ambala 3rd & 4th line (194 km)**" and "**3rd & 4th line between GZB-MB-RAC-SPC (403km)**". In this regard, Chief Administrative Officer/ Const./ Northern Railway, Kashmir Gate, Delhi is intending to place a bidders/contractors meet with Civil, Electrical & S&T Contractors at **11:30 Hrs on 14.05.2026** in the office of Northern Railway Construction HQ, Church Road, Kashmir Gate, Delhi-06.

All interested & prospective bidders & contractors are requested to attend the above interaction physically or virtually for giving valuable suggestions for implementation and packaging of the above projects. **The online VC link is as under:-**

<https://railnet70.webex.com/railnet70/j.php?MTID=m7fdf4f5705057059ac31b791973a174>

Thursday, May 14, 2026 11:30 AM | 5 hours 30 minutes |
(UTC+05:30) Chennai, Kolkata, Mumbai, New Delhi

Meeting number: 2510 869 7982

Password: 123456 (123456 when dialing from a phone or video system)

Join by video system

Dial 25108697982@railnet70.webex.com

You can also dial 210.4.202.4 and enter your meeting number.

Join by phone: +65-6703-6949 Singapore Toll

Access code: 251 086 97982

**Dy. Chief Engineer/C/T&C
for Chief Administrative Officer/Const.**

No.: 74-W-CAO-C-SEMINAR/T&C Dated: 05.05.2026 1500/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NOTICE INVITING TENDER				Date: 06.05.2026	
E-tenders under two Bid System (Unpriced & Priced) are invited as per the following details:					
NIT No.	Tender Description	Estimated Cost (₹)	Cost of EMD (₹)	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & Time of Opening
CMC/BY/26-27/RS/AS/10	Shifting of 33KV & 11KV & LT cables network infringing on Redevelopment of New Delhi Railway Station and construction of associated infrastructure Project by RLDA Scheme no. EC26SH1005	2.46 Crore	5.00 Lakhs	26.05.2026 15:00 Hrs	26.05.2026 15:30 Hrs
Cost of each Tender Document: ₹1,180/-					
For details in respect of Equipment/BOM/Services, Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/submission of tender documents, corrigendum etc. please visit our website www.bseshdelhi.com --> BSES YAMUNA POWER LTD--> Tenders-->Open Tenders.					
Regd.Off: BSES Yamuna Power Ltd, Shakti Kiran Building, Karkardooma, Delhi-110032 CIN: U40109DL2001PLC11525 Website: www.bseshdelhi.com TEL: 011-41247111					

... A joint venture with Govt. of NCT of Delhi

BIDDER		Date: 06.05.2026	
or the following details:			
Estimated (₹)	Cost of EMD (₹)	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & Time of Opening
16 re	5.00 Lakhs	26.05.2026 15:00 Hrs	26.05.2026 15:30 Hrs

ents, Terms & conditions, purchase/submission of
dmdelhi.com -> **BSES YAMUNA POWER LTD->**
Head (Contracts & Materials)
Maha, Delhi-110032 | CIN: U04109DL2001PLC111525
011-41247111

DESTRUCTION OF OLD MEDICAL RECORD OF PATIENTS
We hereby notified to all our patients and general public that **"Kailash Hospital, Kailash Noida"** and **"Kailash Institute of Naturopathy, Ayurved & Yoga"** proposes to destroy old Indoor Medical Records of patients (from I.P. No. 22G/1001 to 22G/24953 and I.P. No. 22A/1001 to 22A/1930) admitted during the period of **04.02.2022 to 31.03.2023** as per hospital policy. Any patient requiring his/her Medical Records may approach the designated within 30 days from the date of publication of this notice and failing which the records will be disposed off without further notice.

Dr. Manager-MPH

[illegible]

Recruitment for Various Non-teaching positions at IIM Ranchi

IIM Ranchi, invites applications for various Non-teaching positions at IIM Ranchi.

For further details regarding eligibility and application process please visit the website- <https://iimranchi.ac.in/careers/>

Last date for receiving online application is 25 May 2026.

DR. H. K. SINGH, DEAN, HR & I.D. OFFICE
Indian Institute of Management Ranchi
Post Bag No. 10, Rourkela Road, Jamshedpur - 831 015, Jharkhand
India
Phone: +91 661 253 1234 | Fax: +91 661 253 1235
Email: careers@iimranchi.ac.in

Manjit Kour D/o Babu Singh Mudher
o Balwinder Singh R/o WZ-707/C,
et No-18, Jail Road , Shiv Nagar,
akpuri B-1 S.O, West Delhi, Delhi-
0058, my name has been Wrongly
tten as Manjit Kaur in my 12th class
ificate & marksheet Roll No. 325420
sing Year 1983, My correct name is
Manjit Kour in my 10th class certificate.



सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया
Central Bank of India

Regional Office (Gurugram)
1398, First Floor, Chandni Chowk,
Delhi-110006. Tel: 011-4028985

E-AUCTION
SALE NOTICE
(Under SARFAESI Act 2002)

1911 से आपके लिए "सेन्ट्रल" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911

APPENDIX- IV-A [SEE PROVISO TO RULE 8(6) & 9(1)] SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) & 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to the secured creditor, the **Physical / Symbolic Possession** of which have been taken by the Authorized officer of **Central Bank of India**, secured creditors, will be sold on **28.05.2025** "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is" basis for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mentioned Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties. For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in: www.centralbankofindia.co.in or BAANKNET.com

DESCRIPTION OF PROPERTIES TO BE AUCTIONED ON 28.05.2026 (15 DAYS NOTICE)

S. No.	Name of Branch	Authorised Officer/B.M.	Name of the Account	Description of Property & Owner Name	Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (Rs. in Lakhs)	Date & Type of Possession	Amount in Rupees
							Reserve Price EMD Bid Increase
1.	Dwarka (3583) New Delhi	Mr. Ashish Kumar MOBILE: 8800013553	MRS. MANJU YADAV & MR. SANTOSH YADAV	Free Hold Residential Property Bearing No.24, Flat No.306, 2nd Floor without Roof Rights, Area of Village Kilo kari, Colony known as Sidharth Nagar, New Delhi-110014. Area 37.62 Sq.Mtr. or 404.94 Sq.Ft. Owned by - Mrs. Manju Yadav W/o Mr. Santosh Yadav	Rs. 12,18,524.73 as on 12.09.2025 + Interest + Other Charges	26.08.2025 (Physical Possession)	₹ 18,42,000.00 ₹ 1,84,200.00 ₹ 20,000.00

Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 28.05.2026 Upto 3:30 PM. Bidder will register on website: (<https://BAANKNET.com>) and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in Global EMD Wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer (after generation of challan from (<https://BAANKNET.com>)).

The auction will be conducted through, the Bank's approved service provider "<https://BAANKNET.com>" E-auction will be held on "**As is where is**", "**As is what is**" and "**whatever is there is**" basis. (All other charges/dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser). For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in www.centralbank.bank.in Secured Creditor or Auction Platform (<https://BAANKNET.com>) BAANKNET Helpdesk: (+91) 8291220220. E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com

NOTICE FOR SUB STATUTORY 15 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) & 9(1) OF SARFAESI ACT 2002
The borrowers/guarantors/ mortgagors are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.

DATE: 05.05.2026
PLACE: DELHI

Authorised Officer, CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA,
Regional Office (Gurugram) Chandni Chowk, Delhi

Bangladesh, Iran FMs head to China amid conflict

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Bangladesh and Iran have stepped up high-level diplomatic engagement with China, as their foreign ministers embark on separate visits to Beijing against a backdrop of rising regional tensions and shifting geopolitical alignments.

Iran's Foreign Minister Seyed Abbas Araghchi is also scheduled to arrive in China this week at Beijing's invitation. He is expected to meet Wang Yi for talks focused on regional tensions, bilateral ties, and wider global strategic issues.

Araghchi's visit comes amid heightened geopolitical strains in the Middle East, particularly around the Strait



of Hormuz, a critical artery for global energy supplies.

The trip also precedes a potential visit to China by former US President Donald Trump, adding further significance to Beijing's role as a key diplomatic hub during a volatile period. According to Iranian state media,

Araghchi's visit forms part of ongoing consultations with multiple countries as Tehran navigates a complex regional landscape. In recent days, he has held discussions in Pakistan, Oman, and Russia as part of broader diplomatic outreach. Analysts say the overlapping visits by

Bangladesh and Iran underscore China's expanding diplomatic footprint, with Beijing positioning itself as a pivotal player in both South Asian economic cooperation and Middle Eastern geopolitical dialogue.

The visit coincides with a broader wave of diplomatic activity in Beijing.

Bangladesh's Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman has begun a three-day official visit to China, signaling a renewed push in Dhaka-Beijing relations under the country's new BNP-led Government.

The visit follows a series of recent diplomatic interactions between China and key regional players, including India and Iran, underscor-

ing Beijing's growing centrality in regional affairs.

During the trip, Rahman is scheduled to hold bilateral talks with his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi.

According to officials from Bangladesh's Ministry of Foreign Affairs, discussions will focus on expanding trade, boosting investment, and exploring new avenues of economic cooperation.

Dhaka is expected to press for concessional financing, longer loan repayment timelines, and a stronger influx of Chinese investment.

Officials say economic engagement with China had slowed in recent months amid political unrest linked to last year's July uprising, but momentum is now returning

following the formation of a new Government. A senior Bangladeshi foreign ministry official indicated that Beijing appears ready to "revamp its activities" in the country, particularly in infrastructure and development sectors where several projects had previously stalled.

China has reiterated its commitment to strengthening ties with Bangladesh. A spokesperson for the Chinese Foreign Ministry described the two countries as "close neighbours and comprehensive strategic cooperative partners," highlighting Beijing's intent to deepen political trust and advance cooperation under the Belt and Road Initiative.

Two schools from India on the Global Prize 2026 shortlist



ADITI KHANNA
■ London

Two schools from India were among the top 50 shortlisted for the Sone million Global Schools Prize 2026.

While Katha Lab School in Delhi was named in the Arts and Culture category, Delhi Public School Bangalore North (DPSBN) has made it in the Inclusive Education category from around 3,000 nominations across 113 countries. The Sone million prize, organised by UK-based Varkey Foundation, celebrates the world's most innovative and impactful schools that are reimagining education for the future across 10 categories.

"Congratulations, Katha Lab School and Delhi Public School Bangalore North; your approach to teaching and learning powerfully demonstrates how schools play a defining role in

equipping young people with the knowledge, skills, and values needed to shape our rapidly evolving world," said Sunny Varkey, founder of the Varkey Foundation.

"By highlighting your achievement, we hope to inspire a global movement to reimagine learning and turn bold ideas into real-world impact," he said.

Katha Lab School in Delhi's slum cluster of Govindpuri serves hundreds of children from low-income families and has the distinction of delivering "extraordinary results". Founded by Padma Shri awardee Geeta Dharmarajan, the school pioneered StoryPedagogy - replacing textbooks with storybooks and weaving language, science, mathematics and the arts into one joyful learning experience, the Global Schools Prize noted. (PTI)

26 killed in blast at fireworks factory in China

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Beijing

At least 26 people were killed and 61 others injured in a massive explosion at a fireworks factory in China's Hunan province, officials said on Tuesday.

The explosion occurred on Monday afternoon at the plant operated by the Huasheng fireworks manufacturing and display company in Liuyang, a county-level city under Changsha, the provincial capital. Videos circulating on Chinese social media showed massive destruction of property spanning several kilometres.

More than 480 rescuers, organised into five teams,



Firefighters working to out the fire after an explosion at a fireworks plant in Guandu Town of Liuyang in China

have been deployed for relief operations, with three rescue robots pressed into service. Officials said 26 people were killed and 61 others were injured.

The injured have been rushed to hospitals for treat-

ment. China is a leading manufacturer and exporter of fireworks.

As the explosion site is located near two black powder warehouses, the rescuers have evacuated nearby residents and set up a buffer

zone to prevent a secondary accident, the state-run Xinhua news agency reported. Changsha Mayor Chen Bozhang expressed condolences to the victims and apologised to their families, affected residents and society at large.

"We are deeply grieved and filled with remorse," he said at a press conference, where attendees observed a moment of silence for the victims, Xinhua reported.

The Ministry of Emergency Management has dispatched experts to the scene to guide rescue efforts.

The person in charge of the company has been detained by police and the cause of the accident is being investigated, the report said.

Pak court acquits PM daughter, husband in corruption case

M ZULQERNAIN
■ Lahore

A Pakistani court has declared the daughter of Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and her husband "innocent" and absolved them of all charges in a mega corruption and money laundering case in just "one hearing".

The Anti-Corruption Establishment (ACE) told the Anti-Corruption Court on Monday that PM's daughter Rabia Imran and her husband Ali Imran Yousaf are not found involved in the Punjab Saaf Pani Company corruption and money laundering case as no evidence is available against them.

Last week, an accountability court suspended the perpetual arrest warrants issued against the couple in the multi-billion-dollar corruption case.

The accountability court had issued perpetual warrants for their arrest in 2022 during the tenure of the Imran Khan Government.

Rabia and her husband fled to the UK in 2022 to evade arrest, and the court subsequently declared them proclaimed offenders. (PTI)



Ultra-Orthodox Jews gathering around a bonfire during Lag BaOmer, a Jewish holiday traditionally marked by bonfire, music, and communal celebrations in Bnei Brak, Israel

Armenia hosts historic EU summit as it charts course away from Russia

ELISE MORTON/ AVET DEMOURIAN
■ Yerevan

Armenia hosts its first bilateral summit with the European Union on Tuesday, a landmark diplomatic moment for the Caucasus Mountains nation that has formally declared its ambition to join the bloc and is cautiously loosening its ties with longtime ally Russia.

The EU-Armenia summit in Yerevan follows the eighth gathering of the European Political Community, which brought dozens of European leaders to the Armenian . The officials addressed European security issues and the US-Israeli war in Iran in remarks.

The two meetings underscore how Armenia is seeking to turn westward and shed Russia's influence. Armenia's relations with Moscow, its longtime sponsor and

ally, have grown increasingly strained since 2023, when neighbouring Azerbaijan fully reclaimed the Karabakh region and ended the decades-long rule by ethnic Armenian separatists.

Armenian authorities accused Russian peacekeepers who were deployed to the region of failing to stop Azerbaijan's onslaught. Moscow, busy with its war in Ukraine, rejected the accusations, arguing that its troops didn't have a mandate to intervene.

The war was "a belated demonstration that Russia is dangerously unreliable as a partner," Richard Giragosian, director of the Regional Studies Centre in Yerevan said.

Since then, Prime Minister Nikol Pashinyan's Government has pursued closer ties with the West, a move welcomed by the EU. In remarks to the EPC conference on Monday, EU Council President



European Council President Antonio Costa, Armenia's Prime Minister Nikol Pashinyan and European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen attending a signature ceremony during the EU-Armenia summit in Yerevan, Armenia

Antonio Costa thanked Pashinyan for "the courageous political decisions he has taken to bring Armenia closer to the European Union".

"The direction of travel is unmistakable," Costa said, stressing that it was "vital to

strengthen Armenian democracy and fight external interference and misinformation".

The opening ceremony of the EU-Armenia summit on Tuesday saw Costa walk the red carpet side-by-side with Pashinyan and European Commission President

Japan's defence chief visits Philippines to deepen security ties, witness a combat exercise

JIM GOMEZ ■ Manila

Japanese Defence Minister Shinjiro Koizumi travelled to the Philippines on Tuesday to witness an international combat drill and conduct talks with Philippine President Ferdinand Marcos Jr intended to broaden defence ties between the nations, officials said. Koizumi's meeting in the capital Manila with Marcos and Defence Secretary Gilberto Teodoro Jr may include discussion of a possible transfer of used Japanese destroyers to the Philippines.

The Philippines and Japan, both treaty allies of the United States, signed a pact in 2024 allowing their forces to stage large-scale combat drills. The Reciprocal Access Agreement paved the way for Japan to deploy 1,400 military



Philippine President Ferdinand greetings Japan's Defense Minister Sshinjiro in Manila

personnel to become regular participants in the exercises called Balikatan.

US, Filipino and other allied forces annually take part in Balikatan, the Tagalog word for shoulder-to-shoulder, to brace for

security contingencies and deter China's increasing assertiveness in the region.

Koizumi will be among representatives from 16 countries, including India and Australia, who are expected to travel

Wednesday to the northwestern Philippine town of Paoay to witness a key Balikatan exercise in which Philippine, US, Japanese and Canadian firepower will be used in a mock attack on a ship about 40 kilometres (25 miles) from the coast.

Japanese forces will fire two volleys of Type 88 missiles to help sink the decommissioned World War II-era Philippine navy warship, Philippine Marine Corps Col Dennis Hernandez told The Associated Press, adding that Marcos plans to watch the live-fire maneuvers via video in Manila.

Before reaching the Philippines, Koizumi visited the Indonesian capital Jakarta and signed a defence cooperation agreement Monday with Indonesian Defense Secretary Sjafrie Sjamsoeddin. "As Japan faces

the most severe and complex security environment in the postwar era, it is important to establish a multi-layered network of allies and like-minded countries, while expanding it and strengthening the deterrence," Koizumi said in a recent news conference in Tokyo.

Japan has bolstered its offensive capability with long-range missiles to attack enemy targets from a distance, a major break from its post-World War II principle limiting the use of force to self-defence.

Japan scrapped a ban on lethal weapons exports on April 21, another major change in its postwar pacifist policy as Japan seeks to build up its arms industry in response to growing Chinese aggression in the region. The Philippines shares that concern following a spike in territorial spat

with Beijing in the South China Sea.

Lifting the ban allows Japan to consider the transfer to the Philippines of up to six used Japanese destroyers of the Abukuma-class, which can be utilized for patrols and detecting aerial, sea surface and undersea threats, Hernandez said, noting the issue could come up in Koizumi's talks with Philippine officials. The details of the potential exchange have not been disclosed.

While allies led by the US and Australia welcomed Japan's updated policy, China criticised the change. Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Guo Jiakun said last month that the global community, including China, will "resolutely resist Japan's reckless moves toward a new type of militarism." (AP)

2 Indian win Pulitzer Prize for highlighting cyber fraud



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New York

Indian journalists Anand RK and Suparna Sharma have won the prestigious Pulitzer Prize for their work highlighting digital surveillance and cyber fraud.

Anand and Sharma won the award, announced on Monday, in the Illustrated Reporting and Commentary category. They share the award with Natalie Obiko Pearson of Bloomberg.

According to The Pulitzer Prizes website, the award-winning work titled

"trAPPed", produced for Bloomberg, narrates the "riveting account" of a neurologist in India who was held under a "digital arrest" through her phone, using a blend of "visuals and words" to underscore the "growing global challenges of surveillance and digital scams". The Pulitzer Prizes, administered by Columbia University, are regarded as among the highest honours in journalism, literature and music composition, recognising excellence in reporting and storytelling.

Sri Lankan leaders congratulate Vijay on his victory



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Sri Lankan leaders on Tuesday congratulated actor-turned-politician Vijay, who led Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam party to a historic victory in Tamil Nadu's assembly elections.

Vijay-led TVK on Monday created a record of sorts in the electoral history of Tamil Nadu by securing an impressive 108 seats in the assembly elections.

Celebrations were reported in Sri Lanka's Tamil-dominated Northern Province, where youths hailed the actor's victory.

The opposition Sri Lanka Podujana Peramuna's National Organiser and MP Namal Rajapaksa congratulated Vijay.

"Congratulations to Vijay on a magnificent victory! The real work begins now, and I wish you and your team the strength and determination to overcome the challenges ahead and deliver meaningful benefits to the people," he said.

PROSPECT

Shahid Smriti Van earns national recognition for tackling industrial pollution

Surat-based environmentalist Viral Desai has received national acclaim for his flagship urban forest project, 'Shahid Smriti Van', which is being recognised for its measurable impact in combating industrial air pollution. The recognition came during the National Environmental Conference held at IIT Bombay, where experts from leading institutions, including NEERI and CPCB, highlighted the project's contribution to improving air quality in industrial regions.

Scientific validation for the initiative was presented through a study titled "Effect of Dense Vegetation on PM Concentration in Industrial Area of Surat City." Conducted by researchers Abhishek Patel and Rajeshree Kadachha under the guidance of Dr Namrata Jariwala at SVNIT Surat, the research used remote sensing tools alongside real-time ground monitoring to assess environmental impact.

The findings showed a significant reduction in PM2.5 levels in areas surrounding the dense vegetation of Shahid Smriti Van, located in Surat's Udhna industrial belt—an area historically affected by high pollution levels.

Desai, often referred to as the "Greenman" for his environmental initiatives, said the forest serves a dual purpose—improving ecological health while honoring national heroes. "It is truly serving as the green lungs for the industrial belt of Surat," he said, referring to his 'one tree for one martyr' initiative embedded within the project.

Desai has emerged as a key figure in India's urban sustainability movement. His work has also earned him multiple national awards for energy conservation, setting a benchmark for integrating environmental restoration with community-driven initiatives. Experts at the conference noted that projects like Shahid Smriti Van could serve as scalable models for industrial cities across India, where balancing economic activity with environmental sustainability remains a pressing challenge.



RBI: UDGAM helps users to search unclaimed deposits across banks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Reserve Bank of India on Tuesday told the Supreme Court that the Unclaimed Deposits - Gateway to Access Information (UDGAM) portal facilitates the registered user to search unclaimed deposits across multiple banks.

The submissions were made before a bench of Justices Vikram Nath, Sandeep Mehta and Vijay Bishnoi which was hearing a plea filed by journalist Sucheta Dalal seeking a direction to set up a mechanism to inform the legal heirs of deceased depositors about the unclaimed deposits lying dormant in bank accounts.

The counsel appearing for the RBI informed the bench that around 44 lakh searches have been made on UDGAM, which is an interactive portal.

Advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for the petitioner, said the issue is how does the legal heirs of deceased depositors find out about the unclaimed deposits lying in bank accounts.

He argued while the RBI has said that they have asked all the banks to put the details on the UDGAM portal,



उद्गम UDGAM Unclaimed Deposits Gateway To Access inforMation

deposits were also being made in post offices and insurance.

"Nothing has been done to integrate them," Bhushan said, adding that the mechanism should be such that legal heirs can find out all these details in one search.

The counsel representing the Centre told the bench that they have prepared an updated affidavit which would be filed in the court.

The bench asked the Centre to file the updated affidavit giving the relevant details within a week and posted the matter for hearing on May 19.

While hearing the plea on March 17, the top court asked the Centre and the RBI why details of bank accounts of deceased persons could not be disclosed to heirs, and said the government must come up with a policy on the issue.

Bhushan had argued that

the RBI had also recommended the need to have a "centralised and searchable database" so that people can trace the accounts of their deceased parents.

Additional Solicitor General N Venkataraman, appearing for the Centre, had said if a genuine heir comes forward, the amount was refunded to them from the Depositor Education and Awareness Fund.

The Depositor Education and Awareness Fund, established by the RBI in 2014, holds unclaimed deposits from commercial and co-operative banks.

The apex court had earlier asked the Finance Ministry to file its response to the PIL seeking directions to create a centralised database providing information about bank accounts, insurance, deposits and post office funds lying in accounts held by



those who are no longer alive. The plea has also sought a direction to establish a procedure that eliminates unnecessary litigation while dealing with claims of legal heirs qua bank deposits, insurance, post office funds, etc.

The plea said that the Depositor Education and Awareness Fund had ₹39,264.25 crore at the end of March 2021, up from ₹33,114 crore on 31 March, 2020 and a sharp rise from ₹18,381 crore at the end of March 2019.

The petition stated there is an urgent need to develop a centralised online database under the control of RBI that will provide information about the deceased account holder, including such details as the name, address and last date of transaction by the deceased account holder.

J&K Bank posts record ₹2,363 cr profit in FY26

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar



Jammu and Kashmir Bank on Tuesday posted a record profit of ₹2,363 crore for the 2025-26 financial year. The bank, which declared the annual results here on Tuesday, said it was for the fourth consecutive financial year that the premier financial institute of Jammu and Kashmir posted record profits. "The bank registered a year-on-year growth of over 13 per cent in its annual profit when compared to ₹2,082.46 cr reported for FY2024-25, despite a one-time impairment provision of ₹179 cr on its investment in J&K Gramin Bank during the first half of the financial year," a spokesperson of the bank said.

The bank also ended the financial year on a high with a record quarterly performance, posting a net profit of almost ₹800 crore compared to ₹584.54 crore in the year-ago period.

The bank declared its annual and Q4 results on Tuesday after its board of directors approved the figures at a meeting held here at the bank's corporate headquarters.

The bank's net interest margin (NIM) for the financial

year stood at 3.60 per cent. The return on assets (RoA) witnessed an increase of 34 bps year-on-year to 1.78 per cent for the quarter as against 1.44 per cent last year with an RoA for the year recorded at 1.37 per cent. Cost-to-income ratio of the bank also improved for the fourth year running, being recorded at 56.18 per cent for the year. The Bank's Return on Equity (RoE) was recorded at 16.85% for the FY 25-26.

"Even against a backdrop of geopolitical uncertainties and a demanding local environment, the bank delivered record profits for the fourth consecutive year – alongside sustained improvement in asset quality and strong capital adequacy – underscoring its resilience and disciplined execution. Significantly, the bank has also been able to rationalise its operating expenses even as the business scales up, thereby enhancing operational efficiency and strengthening overall productivity," MD & CEO Amitava Chatterjee said.

REC Limited extends CSR assistance of ₹11.55 crore to Sankara Eye Hospital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

REC Limited, a Maharatna CPSE under the Ministry of Power, marked a significant milestone in healthcare accessibility with the inauguration of the Sankara Eye Hospital in Saharsa, Bihar. Funded through a ₹11.55 crore CSR grant under the flagship initiative "Bringing Vision to Bihar," the facility was opened to the public in a high-profile ceremony.

The hospital was inaugurated by Giriraj Singh Union Minister, alongside TSC Bosh, Director (Projects), REC Limited, and other senior government dignitaries. A Roadmap for Vision Restoration



The new facility is set to transform the ophthalmic landscape of Northern Bihar. Over the next five years, the project is structured to deliver:

1.5 Lakh Outpatient Consultations: Providing com-

prehensive screenings and specialized eye care.

40,000 Cataract Surgeries: Focusing on the eradication of preventable blindness through advanced surgical intervention.

Inclusive Healthcare: A dedicated mandate to provide free and subsidized services to underserved and economically marginalized communities.

Utilization of the ₹11.55 crore CSR Grant.

REC Limited's financial support has equipped the hospital with modern medical infrastructure, including advanced Ophthalmic Technology with cutting-edge diagnostic and surgical equipment.

Rural outreach fleet: Specialized vehicles to conduct eye-screening camps in remote villages.

Operational Infrastructure: Fully equipped patient wards and sterile operation theaters.

Patna, Ahmedabad, Secunderabad contestants win crossword challenge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

The results for the month of April in the year-long daily online crossword challenge, known as ACAD (A-Cue-A-Day), have brought to the fore remarkable performances by school students in the hinterland of Bihar.

While young crossword aficionado Bittu Kumar of Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar Residential School, Bharra, Begusari, sits at the apex of the national ranking in the School category, Aditya Raj and Ravi Kishan, both of Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar Residential School, Pokhira, Muzaffarpur, have clinched the 2nd and the 3rd spots, respectively.

Shraddha Shree of St. Michael's High School, Patna; Dharendra Kumar of Ahmedabad; and Samit Kallianpur of Secunderabad have won the 1st position in the College, Senior, and Global categories, respectively. The 2nd and the 3rd place winners, respectively, in these cat-



egories are as follows: College – Tisha Taneja of IIT Madras and Soham Sarthak of IGIMS, Patna; Senior – Jacob Brahmakulam from Thrissur and Sree Prakash from Ernakulam; and Global – Ramakrishnan Krishnan of and Aashirwad

Vishwanathan, both from Chennai.

ACAD started in the year 2014 to engage school students on a daily basis to provide a quality pastime that also worked as a learning tool combining fun. Over the past 13 years, this has grown into a four-segment contest due to an overwhelmingly popular demand. Conducted by Extra-C, a civil society initiative, it is conducted on the organization's official website www.crypticsingh.com. While the first two categories are obvious by their nomenclature, ACAD Senior is meant for participants in the age-group of 60 and above. ACAD Global is for anyone anywhere in the world who wants to partake of this intellect-driven challenge. The participation at any stage of the contest is free of cost. A participant may register on the website, get a password, and enter the game daily. There are surprise gifts for top performers in different categories. Though a year-long event, its competitive phase runs between Feb 1 and October 31 every year.

DAILY SUDOKU

8379

7583

457

1458

9176

3764

31957

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★☆☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (5.05.26)

6	2	7	9	3	5	4	8	1
4	8	1	6	2	7	9	5	3
3	5	9	8	4	1	6	2	7
5	9	6	2	1	8	7	3	4
8	3	2	7	9	4	1	6	5
7	1	4	3	5	6	8	9	2
9	6	5	4	7	2	3	1	8
2	4	3	1	8	9	5	7	6
1	7	8	5	6	3	2	4	9

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

WEDNESDAY | MAY 6, 2026

12345678

10111213141516

17181920212223

242526272829

3031

ACROSS

1 The greatest way to eat? (5)

6 Glide smoothly yet very noisily in a boat (5)

9 It's on the wing (7)

10 Next to synthetic fur, it's a natural product (5)

11 Runs out, as mother does at teatime! (5)

12 Was slow to get a republican in court (5)

13 Thought highly of, though always in the red (7)

15 Aged figures with plenty of energy (3)

17 Soon admits ignorance of authorship (4)

18 A scale used somewhere on the Continent (6)

DOWN

2 Get tough on difficult points (6)

3 Girl bowled over? (6)

4 Location of tip-up seats? (3)

5 Can it keep one's chest a bit warm in bed? (5)

6 In a silly, sentimental yet absorbing way? (7)

7 It's tied to the idea of speed (4)

8 Favourable figures relating to acid (6)

12 Battery units (5)

13 Frantic weaving of braid (5)

14 There's something gripping about love, say (5)

19 Roman who, having got in, went out to work at a trade! (5)

20 Finds an unfulfilled desire irritating? (6)

22 Enough beef for eleven? (4)

24 Quite definitely it's said to be cast (3)

25 Spanish sportsman, a cad at heart (7)

26 Like Herb, he has his roots in the soil (5)

27 A wooden one's not for winning (5)

28 Long neglected duty about the first of September (5)

29 At the end of winter, wild cats spread out (7)

30 James, the father of David? (5)

31 Sort of drum for a catchy rhythm? (5)

15 A name I had for being good (5)

16 Something to read (5)

18 Smith's property in the block (5)

19 What a sinner may do with a letter from Penzance (7)

21 Drink it up very quietly, there's some left! (6)

22 Planet starting satisfactorily to rotate (6)

23 Who? (6)

25 Potable paint, possibly? (5)

26 An extra big-hearted employer? (4)

28 Sideshow man? (3)

SOLUTION (4.05.26)

ACROSS

8. Clat-me-d

9. Catches on

13. Aught

14. Thin-C

15. Ring-net

16. Concern

17. Th-re-e

18. Prior

20. To-piles

22. B-and-it

23. Posted

25. Ran-sack

DOWN

27. Fortune

30. Put out

31. Vi's-age

32. Discus/s

35. Sheer

36. Ahead

37. Has-been

39. Opt-i-mum

41. Lo-tto

42. Leave

43. Get-a-t-able

44. Ag-it-at

24. Cone through

26. Squaremeal

28. Tiger illy

29. Man-dred

30. Pistol

32. Desolate

33. Son-net

34. Oatmeal

38. Ex-acts

40. Thee

VFS Global-led consortium wins contract to modernise property registration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

VFS Global, in partnership with WFS Excel Software Pvt. Ltd., has secured a five-year contract from the Inspector General of Registration (IGR) and Controller of Stamps under Government of Maharashtra to establish 60 Model Sub-Registrar Offices (SROs) across the state. The initiative is aimed at transforming Maharashtra's property registration system into a faster, more transparent, and citizen-friendly process. The rollout will be executed in phases, with each centre designed to deliver efficient services through advanced digital infrastructure and modern facilities.

The consortium will handle the end-to-end setup and management of the Model SROs. These centres will feature fully air-conditioned environments, spacious waiting areas with Wi-Fi, and robust digital systems to ensure seamless processing. Trained service personnel will assist citizens throughout their visit, while additional amenities such as refreshments and water dispensers are expected to improve overall experience.

Ravindra Binwade, Inspector General of Registration, said the initiative addresses persistent issues such as overcrowding, long queues, and outdated infrastructure in traditional SROs. Jiten Vyas, Chief Commercial Officer at VFS Global, described the project as a major step in advancing technology-led governance reforms.

ICANN opens global window for new web domains

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Internet Corporation for Assigned Names and Numbers has opened applications for its New gTLD Program 2026 Round, giving businesses, governments, communities and other organisations across world a fresh chance to operate their own internet domain extensions for the first time in more than a decade. The application window, launched this month, will remain open till August 12.

The programme allows eligible entities to apply for generic top-level domains, commonly known as gTLDs, which are the letters appearing after the final dot in a web address. This means companies and institutions can seek customised domain endings such as brand names, city names or industry identifiers

and build their own controlled digital ecosystems around them.

ICANN, the global non-profit body that coordinates the internet's Domain Name System, said the new round marks a major digital opportunity for organisations looking to strengthen online identity, improve trust and create secure internet spaces for users. Kurtis Lindqvist, President and Chief Executive Officer of ICANN, said the new domains can serve as long-term strategic tools for communication, commerce and security. He said they can help businesses build

stronger brands, allow cities and regions to establish dedicated digital identities, and enable communities to create more focused online platforms. The previous round of applications was held in 2012 and resulted in the launch of more than 1,200 new domain extensions. These included company-specific domains, location-based domains and category domains used for sectors and specialised services.

According to ICANN, the expansion showed that custom domains can improve user confidence, make web navigation simpler and help organisations gain better control over their online presence. Under the new programme, an approved applicant will be able to decide who can register websites under that domain extension and how the entire namespace will be managed.

राष्ट्रीय प्रौद्योगिकी संस्थान, कुरुक्षेत्र

NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY

(Under the Ministry of Education, Govt. of India)

KURUKSHETRA-136119

Advt. No.07/2026

Admission to Ph.D. Program in Odd Semester of Academic Year 2026-27

National Institute of Technology, Kurukshetra invites online applications via Google Form from Indian and Foreign nationals for admission to the Doctor of Philosophy (Ph.D.) Degree Programmes on Full Time (Institute/CSIR-UGC-NET-JRF, Project), Visvesvaraya Fellowship Scheme, Full-Time (Self-Financed), and Part-Time seats for Academic Year 2026-27. Number of Seats, Online Application Form Link, and other relevant details along with Ph.D. Ordinance & Regulations are available on the Institute website: www.nitkkr.ac.in under Admission 2026-> Ph.D. tab.

All interested candidates may fill the Google Form latest by **June 10, 2026, 05:00 p.m.** if the application is incomplete or any information is found misleading/false at any point during or after the admission process, the candidate's candidature/admission will be cancelled and the application fee will not be refunded in any case.

Please visit Institute website regularly for any announcement or updates in this regard.

Registrar I/c

BRIEFLY

Sevilla beat Real Sociedad to escape La Liga relegation



A second half goal from Alexis Sanchez lifted Sevilla over Real Sociedad 1-0 and out of La Liga's relegation zone. The 37-year-old Chilean scored five minutes after coming on as a halftime substitute. Sevilla rose to one point above Alaves in the third relegation place.

Only three points separate Alaves in 18th and Valencia in 12th as the relegation dogfight looks destined to go to the wire. Sevilla lost five of its previous six games coming into the match but Monday's win gave it back-to-back home wins in the league for the first time since October 2024. The home side even had a late second from Lucien Agoume ruled out after a video review.

The loss was a big blow to Sociedad, which is eyeing European football next season. A win would have taken it into joint sixth with Celta Vigo but instead it lingered in ninth, three behind Vigo and a point behind Getafe and Athletic Bilbao.

(AP)

Thousands of fans attend funeral of Alex Zanardi



Thousands of fans have attended the funeral for Alex Zanardi, the Italian auto racing champion-turned-Paralympic gold medalist who died last week at 59.

Zanardi's hand-bike was placed near the altar inside the basilica in Padua where the service was held on Tuesday, and his hand cycling teammates sat in the front row near his wife, Daniela, and son, Niccolo.

Also in attendance were Stefano Domenicali, the president and CEO of Formula One, skier Alberto Tomba, Paralympian Bebe Vio and a host of politicians and other officials. In 2020, Zanardi was seriously injured in a handbike accident after crashing into an oncoming truck during a relay event in Tuscany. Zanardi suffered serious facial and cranial trauma in the crash and was put in a medically induced coma.

Nearly 20 years earlier, Zanardi lost both of his legs in an auto racing crash.

One fan inside the church held up a sign that said, "Farewell Alex, your legend will never die."

(AP)

Roma thumps Fiorentina and Cremonese miss survival boost



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Rome

Roma scored three times in a commanding first half on its way to a 4-0 win over Fiorentina that boosted its hopes of a top four finish and a Champions League place in Serie A.

The capital club moved into fifth place, just one point behind Juventus.

Gianluca Mancini headed home the opener from a corner kick after 13 minutes and Wesley added a second five minutes later to put Gian Piero Gasperini's side in the driving seat.

Mario Hermoso added the third after great set up work by Manu Kone, and Niccolò Pisilli completed the scoring early in the second half.

It was the first league defeat for Fiorentina in eight games. La Viola still need a point to guarantee their Serie A survival and remain in 16th, nine points clear of the relegation zone.

Lazio beats Cremonese: Cremonese relinquished a first-half lead in losing at home to Lazio 2-1, missing a chance to grab crucial points in its fight to avoid relegation.

Cremonese has won only one of its last 21 league matches. It remained third from bottom, four points adrift of safe and 17th-placed Lecce with three games to play. The home side took the lead in the first half when Federico Bonazzoli's left-foot shot squirmed under the body of Lazio goalkeeper Edoardo Motta.

Gustav Isaksen brought Lazio level in the second half, and Tijjani Noslin curled in the winner two minutes into stoppage time.

James Vardy made a substitute appearance for Cremonese after missing four games with a muscle strain but he made no difference.

Lazio moved into eighth, two points above Bologna and Sassuolo.

Man City stumble at Everton, Arsenal surge

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Liverpool

Jeremy Doku scored a last-gasp equalizer for Manchester City to snatch a 3-3 draw at Everton and throw the Premier League title momentum back to leader Arsenal.

The draw ended a run of three consecutive wins for City and left it five points behind the London club. City has a game in hand but the loss at Everton's Hill Dickinson Stadium meant the title was now Arsenal's to lose. The Gunners have three games to play.

"It's painful now," Doku said. "There's a lot of games to go, everything can happen. We lost two points today but we will keep on fighting."

"We know that one point can still be important in the end."

City has four games left and knew it needed a win to keep the pressure on Mikel Arteta's side. But although it dominated possession in the first half it struggled to create real chances and it wasn't until the 42nd minute that Doku found space in a crowded penalty box to curl in a peach of a strike and break the deadlock.

Everton, though, came out a different



side in the second half and struck three times in 13 minutes.

City defender Marc Guehi's short back pass was intercepted by substitute Thierno Barry, who slipped it past an incredulous Gianluigi Donnarumma.

Five minutes later, the City defense was all at sea again as Jake O'Brien rose at the near post to glance home a corner from James Garner.

Barry made it 3-1 in

the 81st when a shot deflected into his path, giving him the simplest of finishes. But just as City fans were beginning to stream out of the stadium, many returned when Erling Haaland stormed forward and clipped his 25th goal of the season over Jordan Pickford.

City threw everything forward and in the seventh minute of stoppage time Doku curled in a sublime strike with almost the last kick of the match.

It was a killer blow to Everton, which is still hopeful of securing a European place. A win would have lifted it within two points of seventh but instead it was 10th, tied on

points with Fulham and Chelsea.

"We let ourselves down, we defended the second goal so poorly and that was the main reason (for the draw)," Everton coach David Moyes said.

"But at halftime we'd have taken this result because we were hugely outplayed in the first half. Getting a point against Manchester City's not a bad result but when you're 3-1 up, you're thinking you're in with a great chance of winning."

Forest beats Chelsea: Earlier, Chelsea slumped to a sixth straight Premier League defeat and saw its Champions League qualification hopes virtually disappear after

losing to Nottingham Forest 3-1.

Taiwo Awoniyi scored two either side of earning a penalty converted by fellow striker Igor Jesus, inspiring a heavily rotated Forest to the brink of safety. Forest was six points above the relegation zone with three rounds left.

Joao Pedro's overhead kick in second-half stoppage time ended Chelsea's scoreless run in the league stretching back almost two months but proved to be only a consolation. On a humiliating day for the London club and interim coach Calum McFarlane, Cole Palmer had a penalty saved in a 14-minute period of first-half stoppage time — required after 18-year-old Chelsea winger Jesse Derry, making his first Premier League start, needed lengthy treatment following a clash of heads with Forest's Zach Abbott at a corner.

Both had to leave the field, Derry on a stretcher as Stamford Bridge fell quiet and his teammates looked concerned.

Reaching the FA Cup final last week has failed to rouse Chelsea's players, who were booed by their own fans at halftime and fulltime, amid their dreadful run of form in the league that has plunged the team to ninth place and out of contention for a top-five finish.

Sixth place could yet earn qualification for the Champions League, but only in the specific scenario of Aston Villa - currently in fifth place - finishing in that position and also winning the Europa League. Chelsea is four points behind sixth-placed Bournemouth.

Deotale shines as Indian men seal top-3 finish in Archery WC



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Shanghai

Former world champion Ojas Deotale led from the front as India's men compound team secured a top-10 finish in the qualification round of the Archery World Cup Stage 2 on Tuesday.

Deotale, who became India's first-ever male world champion in archery by winning the 2023 World Archery Championships in Berlin, was the best-placed Indian, shooting 711 points to finish seventh overall that set the tone for the team's effort.

Sahil Jadhav also logged in 711 points, taking the next spot on

X-count, while Kushal Dalal completed the trio with an overall 18th-place finish as India sealed the third seeding in the team event.

Asian Games medallist Abhishek Verma, however, endured a disappointing outing, finishing 25th with 705 points to miss out on the team combination. He will still feature in the individual elimination rounds.

In the women's compound section, former world champion Aditi Swami finished 13th with 700 points — seven behind USA's Alexis Ruiz, who topped the qualification.

Hearts leap in Scottish league title race

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Edinburgh (Scotland)

The three-team race in a Scottish league title chase for the ages now looks down to two after leader Heart of Midlothian rallied to beat Rangers 2-1.

Hearts is three points ahead of second-placed Celtic with three rounds left, chasing a first league title for 66 years as a big underdog against richer opponents.

Rangers was all but knocked out of the running, now seven points back. Rangers can do Hearts a huge favor on Sunday at Celtic in a Glasgow derby between fierce rivals who have combined to win the league in each of the past 40 years.

Hearts took a big step toward a stunning and unheralded Scottish Premiership triumph with second-half goals from defender Stephen Kingsley and talismanic forward Lawrence Shankland. Rangers took a first-half lead on Dujon Sterling's deflected shot.

Shankland's decisive left-foot strike in the 71st minute — his 14th league goal this season — showed the kind of form that could see him lead Scotland's attack when the



Tartan Army returns to the World Cup against Haiti on June 13 at the New England Patriots' stadium.

Hearts next plays on Saturday evening at Motherwell and can go six points clear one day before

Celtic hosts Rangers. Hearts also has a better goal difference than Celtic which is the first tiebreaker if they are level on points after the last game of the season — when they meet in Glasgow on May 16.

Was asked to pay ₹5 crore for MLA ticket, says Manoj Tiwary

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi

Former India cricketer and outgoing Trinamool Congress MLA Manoj Tiwary on Tuesday said the "TMC chapter is over" for him, alleging that the party denied him a ticket from Howrah's Shibpur constituency for refusing to pay ₹5 crore.

The 40-year-old former India batter and highest run-getter in history of Bengal cricket (10,195 first-class runs) was a Minister of State for Sports in the government led by Mamata Banerjee, whose 15-year tenure ended with a BJP sweep of the latest assembly elections on Monday.

"Look, I am not at all surprised by this debacle. This was bound to happen when an entire party has indulged in corrupt practices and there was no development in any sector," Tiwary told PTI in an interview.

"Only those who could pay hefty money could buy tickets. At least 70-72 candidates this time paid around ₹ 5 crore to get a ticket. I was asked but I refused to pay. Just check how many of those who paid up have managed to win," he said.

"As far as TMC is concerned, that chapter is over (for me)," he declared.

Tiwary said he had no intention of joining politics even though he was offered a Lok Sabha Ticket by TMC back in 2019. He eventually relented by contesting and winning from Shibpur in 2021 assembly polls.

"At that time, I had played for Punjab Kings in the IPL and was still playing Ranji Trophy seriously when Didi (Mamata) wanted me to contest Lok Sabha.



"I had politely declined but before the 2021 elections, Didi once again called and told me 'Manoj, I have a message for you and Aroop will tell you'. I was asked to contest from Shibpur and I thought that I could make a meaningful change," Tiwary recalled.

"Paid from own pocket for development work": Tiwary alleged that Trinamool Congress lacks internal democracy.

"I have attended meetings where all TMC ministers were summoned. Now I was given a Lollypop called MoS which basically meant nothing. If I stood up and said 'Didi I want to draw your attention to a certain problem', she would just stop us midway and say 'I don't have time for you people'."

Tiwary said the longstanding issue of failing sewage and drainage systems in Howrah district was not addressed despite his repeated efforts.

"Being a sitting MLA, I would run from pillar to post for drainage work in my con-

stituency but people who controlled Howrah Municipality for years without allowing elections to happen, never cared.

"They would simply stall developmental work which is very basic. I can tell you that some of the work that I got done was not just from MLA fund but also I paid from my own pocket to complete projects.

"Every year Didi would announce a Master Plan for upgradation of underground drainage system but that was it, just lip service."

On Allegations that he extorted money: Tiwary has had to fight perception battles of his own, including allegations that he was involved in extortion from builders in his constituency, he laughed off the charge.

Let me tell you that when I filed my income affidavit before the 2021 elections, I had declared that I had ₹20 crore in cash. I have played IPL for 10 years, first-class cricket for 20 years, was part of Indian squads for good number of years.

Skippping Pro League in 2019 cost us dearly: Pak hockey head coach

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Lahore

Newly-appointed hockey team head coach Manzoor ul Hassan believes Pakistan erred by not taking part in the first edition of the FIH Pro League back in 2019, saying it denied players of valuable exposure against top opposition.

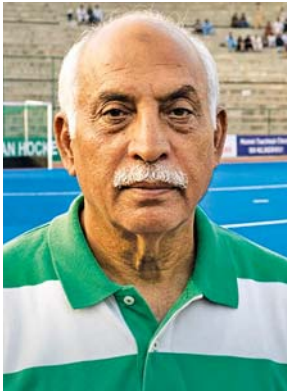
Pakistan had been excluded from the inaugural FIH Pro League after withdrawing from their first three matches. As a result they had to play in the second divisions Nations Cup alongside lower-ranked teams before earning a promotion back to the Pro League.

"It was a mistake to not play in the FIH Pro League when it started in 2019 and our players missed out on valuable opportunities to test themselves against top sides," the former Olympian said on Tuesday.

"If you look at the other teams they have been playing in the Pro League since 2019 which we missed out on as our players were relegated to playing against low ranked sides," he added.

Hassan is currently overseeing a training camp ahead of next month's Pro League leg, where Pakistan are set to face top sides including Belgium, Spain, India and England.

Hassan identified deep defence as the team's biggest area of concern and stressed the need for significant improvement in that depart-



ment. "In modern day hockey I think deep defence has a very important role to play as now attacks and counter attacks happen very quickly so the goalkeeper and deep defenders have to be very grounded," he said.

Pakistan has qualified for the World Cup to be played in Belgium and Netherlands in August after a gap of eight years. The former Olympian said his immediate priority is to ensure Pakistan performs strongly at the Asian Games and secures direct qualification for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

His appointment has sparked debate within Pakistan hockey circles, with some questioning whether the 74-year-old is in tune with the demands of modern hockey and suggesting a foreign coach might have been a better choice ahead of the World Cup. However, Hassan dismissed concerns over his age.

I pick Rohit's brain on batting: Ryan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Mumbai Indians opener Ryan Rickelton says he never misses an opportunity to pick Rohit Sharma's brain on different facets of batting but the Indian legend is way better at demonstrating how it's done, pulling off shots that he can strike only in his "wildest dreams".

The 29-year-old Rickelton (83) and Rohit (84) combined for their second century partnership of this season to power Mumbai Indians to a six-wicket win over Lucknow Super Giants on Monday, helping the team stay alive in the competition after a tumultuous run.

"I picked his brain a little bit more (in the) first year, just about batting in general. Not necessarily T20 batting, (it was) more (about) Tests and 50-overs batting and the specifics and the mentality around it," Rickelton said when asked about the tips he has received from Rohit.

"It's never always (a) life-changing advice that you hear. It is the stuff that you've heard through different paths and closures as you kind of work



your way through the game. It is just more (about) how he manages pressure, how he stays calm and how he backs his ability and understands his game really well," he said.

Rickelton said having different areas to target and being clear about their methods is the secret behind their success as an opening pair.

"We compliment each other nicely as a left-hand right-hand (combination), we score in very different areas and we are quite clear in our methods and who we want to put pressure on," he said.

Talking about their approach as a pair, Rickelton said, "Sometimes he gets away really quickly and

takes a lot of pressure off me and sometimes I get away quickly and take a lot of pressure off him."

"Coming back from five or six games out, he gave himself a few balls to just get back to batting again and his routines and then transferring that pressure onto the bowlers. He hit some shots

that I could only have in my wildest dreams."

Rickelton said having senior South African wicketkeeper-batter Quinton de Kock, who also scored an IPL ton earlier this season, in the squad also put pressure on him. "It was tricky to manage mentally because maybe you are burning yourself with a bit more pressure to do well, because you have a guy who is flipping good sitting behind you and the whole world is screaming to pick him," he said.

"...you can put yourself under a bit too much pressure. But on the flip side, I got an opportunity when he did some damage to his hand," Rickelton added.

Rickelton, who made 83, said he got an earful from de kock for not pulling off a hundred.

"He was the first person to absolutely abuse me tonight, saying I threw away a hundred, which I agree with him."

No idea about Pandya's injury: Rickelton said he was not aware of the extent of skipper Hardik Pandya's injury. Pandya missed the clash due to a back spasm.

Samson stands out on tricky track as CSK demolish Delhi Capitals

BHARAT SHARMA
■ New Delhi

Sanju Samson paced his unbeaten 87 off 52 balls perfectly on a tricky track as Chennai Super Kings kept themselves relevant in the Indian Premier League with an eight-wicket win over a self-destructing Delhi Capitals here on Tuesday.

After opting to bat, DC's struggles with the bat at home continued as they ended with a below par 155 for seven on a pitch offering assistance to the spinners with odd ball holding up.

Samson and Kartik Sharma (41 not out off 31 balls) forged a 114-run partnership off 66 balls for the third wicket, taking CSK home in 17.3 overs for their fifth win of the season. For DC, the road to play-offs got a lot tougher with their sixth loss in 10 matches.

While the CSK spin duo of Akeal Hosein and Noor Ahmad excelled, DC's lead spinner Kuldeep Yadav conceded 34 runs in his three overs. He was hit for four sixes in those 18 balls, releasing all the pressure DC had put on the opposition by limiting them to 44 for one



in the powerplay.

While skipper Axar Patel did the containing job well, Kuldeep failed to get a wicket in the middle overs to make it easier for CSK. Trump card Mitchell Starc was not able to strike early on though Lungi Ngidi removed Ruturaj Gaikwad in his opening over.

It seemed Samson had it all figured out in his head. Having laboured to 15 off his first 17 balls, he targeted Kuldeep post the powerplay to anchor the chase for his team. His innings included half a dozen sixes.

The opener has also struck

two hundreds in his debut season for the storied franchise.

Earlier, DC's free fall began with the loss of opener Pathum Nissanka who failed to clear the mid-on fielder off a slower ball from left-arm pacer Mukesh Choudhary.

Both Nissanka (19 off 15 balls) and K L Rahul (12 off 13 balls) began with crisp boundaries but did not last long. After Nissanka, Rahul attempted an inside-out hit off left-arm spinner Akeal Hosein but could not get to the pitch of the ball on the charge to be caught by opposition captain Ruturaj Gaikwad.

India retain No 1 position in ICC T20I rankings



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dubai

World Cup winners India on Tuesday retained the top spot in the ICC T20I rankings followed by England and Australia at second and third respectively.

India had created history by becoming the first team to successfully defend their T20 World Cup title and also win it for a record-extending third time in March, when they co-hosted the tournament with Sri Lanka.

"The latest rankings rate all matches played since May 2025 at 100 per cent and those of the previous two

years at 50 per cent," the ICC said on its website.

"Sitting at 275 points, India see their lead over England (262 points) trimmed by merely one point, while Australia are placed closer to England at the third place with 258 points," it added.

While two-time winners England have 262 rating points, one-time champions Australia have 258 points.

In all, there is no change in ranking for the top seven teams in the ICC T20I rankings with New Zealand (247), South Africa (244), Pakistan (240) and the West Indies (233) remaining at the following spots.

Doesn't reflect level-playing field: US Group on losing RR bid

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

"Deeply disappointed" after losing the Rajasthan Royals' ownership bid to the group led by industrialist Lakshmi N Mittal, the US-based Kal Somani-led consortium on Tuesday denied that it pulled out of the bidding process, asserting that the final outcome does not reflect a "level playing field".

Lakshmi Mittal and his son Aditya Mittal, along with vaccine manufacturer Adar Poonawalla, acquired a majority stake in Rajasthan Royals for \$1.65 billion (₹15,600 crore approx) after the consortium comprising Somani (Tech Entrepreneur), Rob Walton (Walmart Group) and Sheila Ford Hamp (Ford group) pulled out of the race, according to the franchise.



"We are deeply disappointed not to be part of the Rajasthan Royals ownership group, following a long six-month process in which we were the lead bid from start to finish," the consortium stated in a press release.

"Contrary to stories that have been planted in the press, our group was and has always been fully funded, prepared to close with certainty, and never withdrew our bid," it added.

The group said it had documen-

tation in place and was told that the franchise's board meeting on Saturday was held to approve its bid.

"In the end this was never the case. We approached this process with the highest standards of honesty, integrity, professionalism and in good faith, but unfortunately that wasn't enough.

"We do not believe the outcome ultimately reflected a level playing field, and it is difficult to reconcile the strength of our bid and preparedness to close with the final decision," it said.

The US-based consortium led by Somani had offered \$1.63 billion but as per sources there were multiple issues with its documentation, which could not pass the scrutiny of the existing owners — Manoj Badale and consortium.

Things don't always go your way: KL Rahul



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

KL Rahul has accepted that things won't always go his way, especially when it comes to his T20 International career, but the India and Delhi Capitals batter is glad that he has managed to "break" the perception of him being a Test specialist.

Last month, the 34-year-old smacked a 64-ball 152 not out in the ongoing IPL, albeit in a losing cause against Punjab Kings, but the record-breaking knock showed his growth in the shortest format. The Karnataka player has not turned up in a T20 for India since 2022, but remains a Test and ODI regular.

Speaking on JioStar show 'Superstars', Rahul said he is proud of the progress he has made in the last decade.

"Ten years ago, I would have given anything to be part of a T20 team. I was never rated as a T20 player or even considered a good white-ball player; I was branded a Test player," he said.

"So, to break out of that mould, develop my white-ball game and come this far is something I'm really proud of. Along the way, I've made mistakes and there are things I could have done better," he added. "But, what I'm proud of is that I've given my absolute best every time I've played and prepared as well as I could to give myself the best chance to succeed. That's sport; things won't always go your way."

Rahul said he has tried to "stay balanced" irrespective of the results.

"You have to take it in your stride and enjoy the journey... Whenever I feel low about what I haven't achieved, I remind myself of what I have, and it gives me perspective.

"I still have some time left. So, I'll keep trying my best and see how many trophies I can win."

'Fatherhood has changed me': Rahul welcomed a baby girl last year with his actor wife Athiya Shetty. He said the new role has helped his cricket as well.

"Fatherhood has been the most beautiful thing for me. I always felt I had calmness and happiness in my life, but I was so wrong. You don't truly know happiness, peace or joy until you hold your baby," he said.

MI would have won game or two if Rohit been available earlier: Harbhajan Singh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Mumbai Indians might not have been in such a precarious position as far as IPL playoffs qualification is concerned had former skipper Rohit Sharma recovered earlier from his hamstring injury, rued Harbhajan Singh.

Rohit returned to action following an injury-enforced layoff with a strokeful 84 in MI's highest-ever successful run-chase in the IPL in pursuit of 229 when they beat Lucknow Super Giants by six wickets here on Monday.

The former Mumbai Indians' skipper had missed in all five matches since leaving the field after suffering a hamstring injury



while batting against Royal Challengers Bengaluru here on April 12. "It's important to be in the middle. You can do only so much sitting in the dugout. But you can make a difference by being in the

middle, and Rohit Sharma did exactly that," Harbhajan told JioHotstar.

"You needed that foundation to chase down that many runs and he didn't just lay the foundation, but built a couple of floors on it as well, leaving very little for the rest to do. It would have been even better if he had got his hundred, but for the time he was there, he played exceptionally well."

"I wish his injury had healed a little earlier. Who knows, they might have won a game or two during that losing streak and would have still been alive in the competition?" the former



India spinner added. Harbhajan, who played for MI from the inaugural edition in 2008 to 2017, hoped the five-time champions would keep fighting hard in their remaining matches.

With three wins and seven defeats in 10 matches, MI only have six points and need to win each of their remaining four to remain alive. "They will give themselves a chance if they win every game from here and get to 14 points. Who knows, if other teams start losing, there could be a net run-rate situation at 14

points, anything can happen," Harbhajan said.

Meanwhile, former India head coach Ravi Shastri said LSG paid a price of being inconsistent.

"The problem with LSG is that when their bowling unit performs, the batters fail to back it up, and when the batters score runs, the bowlers go for plenty. There's no consistency," Shastri said.

"Six losses in a row can really dent a side's confidence, and even in games where you are in a comfortable position, there are thoughts like, 'Will we win, won't we?' You are 100 for one in 7 overs, and in the next 13 overs, you score less than 130, which means you have faltered."

IPL mania hurls a yorker to cricket fans and Pundits: Is the yorker dead in T20?

MR MISHRA ■ New Delhi

There was a time when the final overs of a T20 contest carried a familiar script. As panic spread through the batting side and the equation tightened, captains would turn to specialists capable of delivering cricket's ultimate pressure-release valve — the classical yorker.

But in an IPL era increasingly shaped by 220-plus totals, premeditated ramps, reverse scoops and batters willing to stand virtually anywhere on



the crease, the delivery that once inspired dread is facing its sternest test.

The question increasingly being asked in dressing rooms and fan discussions is:

Has the league's batting revolution killed the yorker? Has the yorker become a high-risk delivery that hapless bowlers prefer to avoid? Not really. We can hold off on writing the yorker's epitaph, say the pundits.

The delivery that once defined an era built by Lasith Malinga and perfected by Bumrah still survives. Only now, in a batter-dominated age, it demands even greater courage and precision to remain cricket's ultimate finishing weapon.

Batting woes haunt Punjab Kings

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Punjab Kings batters will be under pressure to halt a worrying slide when they face a confident Sunrisers Hyderabad in the Indian Premier League here on Wednesday.

Punjab, which had emerged as the team to beat with six wins on the trot, stumbled in the last two matches and both the defeats exposed frailties they would be keen to address swiftly.

Despite leading the standings with 13 points



from nine games, the margin for error has narrowed considerably, with Royal Challengers Bengaluru, Sunrisers Hyderabad, Rajasthan Royals and Gujarat Titans all within touching distance, just a point behind.

Punjab's recent dip can largely be attributed to a loss of rhythm. Their explosive performances with the bat had covered up for an inconsistent bowling unit much of the season, but the cracks have now begun to show.